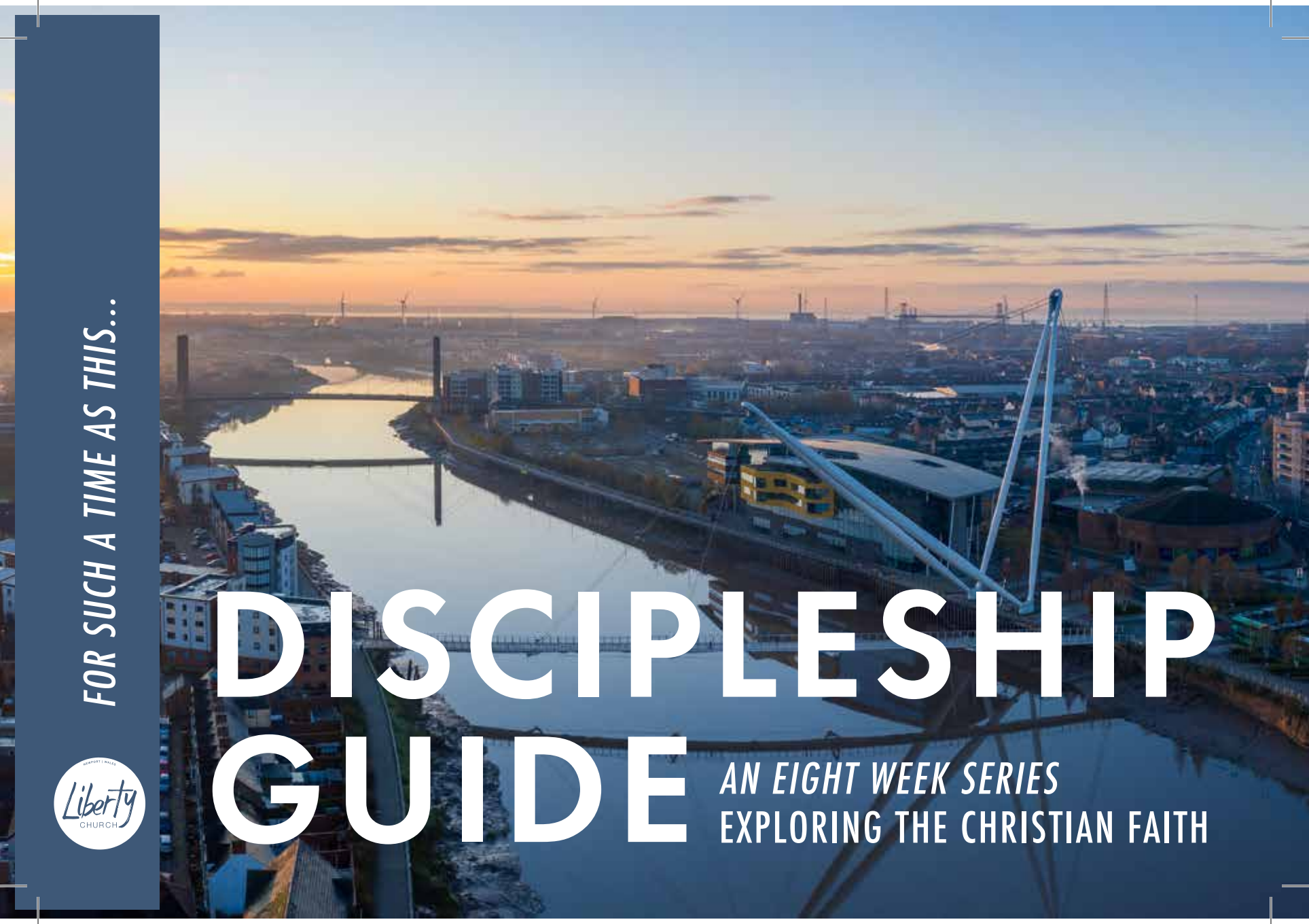
FOR SUCH A TIME AS THIS...



DISCIPLESHIP GUIDE

AN EIGHT WEEK SERIES
EXPLORING THE CHRISTIAN FAITH



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Memory verses and other resources can be found at discipleshipguide.com.
Unless otherwise indicated, all Scripture quotations are from the NIV.

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Welcome to the Discipleship Guide!

You're about to embark on an amazing journey in this Discipleship Guide. The picture of a journey or race is a theme we encounter throughout scripture; Israel's journey from Egypt where they were in slavery to living free in the Promised Land; Jesus' journey from Galilee to Jerusalem and from there his ascension into heaven; and your journey and mine from enemy of God to friend, from outsider to family, from foreigner to citizen.

But your journey didn't end when you came to Christ in saving faith. If anything, that's the beginning of your journey. All of your walk with God, from being forgiven and being saved until you stand face to face before God in heaven, is what the Bible calls salvation. Scripture clearly shows us that salvation has past, present, and future elements that together bring us into the fullness of the salvation God won for us through Christ (see diagram below).

In this Discipleship Guide, we're inviting you to dig deeper into the life-shaking implications of your salvation. We will look back to what happened when you were saved and what it means because you cannot move forward with confidence, peace, and fruitfulness until you've settled "who" you now are! Then, we will look at what it means to become more like Christ — how we keep in step with the Holy Spirit and cooperate with him, to get free of baggage we've carried past the cross or have picked up along the way. We will look at how we experience the fruit of the Holy Spirit as a daily and ever-increasing reality. Finally, we will explore what impact our guaranteed glorification has on our lives and how those promises of what is to come shape our thinking and actions today.

This Discipleship Guide is your personal resource, so feel free to make notes in it: write down what God is saying to you, highlight key truths, and scribble down



questions you need to discuss with your mentor. We suggest you use this guide as your daily devotional time with God from Sundays to Thursdays for the next eight weeks, allowing the Spirit to be your teacher. Then, as you've arranged with your mentor, meet weekly to discuss material you've been through. That will be a good time to bring up the questions you've written down but also to discuss what God has been doing in you — what truth bombs have exploded in your life this week. The goal is for you to have fully grasped what was covered that week and to have started applying it to your life.

One of the other tools we have given you is memory verses. Twice a week, we have given you printed out key scriptures that we know will be hugely helpful to you in your journey. Stick them on your bathroom mirror or download them from discipleshipguide.com and have them as your screensaver. Ask the Holy Spirit to plant these into your heart and memory like a seed that will bear fruit over and over again. Practice repeating them without reading them until they are yours to keep. You can do it.

So here we go, "Week 1, Day 1: God loves you." What a fantastic place to start the journey.

For he chose us in him before the creation of the world to be holy and blameless in his sight. In love, he predestined us for adoption to sonship through Jesus Christ, in accordance with his pleasure and will – to the praise of his glorious grace, which he has freely given us in the one he loves.

EPHESIANS 1:4-6

WEEK 1 DAY 1

WEEK THEME:
Steps to Salvation

DAY THEME:
God Loves You



MEMORY VERSE:

"But God demonstrates His own love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us."

ROMANS 5:8

There's a story about a certain medieval monk who announced that he would be preaching one Sunday evening on "The Love of God." As the shadows fell on that Sunday and the light ceased to come in through the cathedral windows, the congregation gathered and in the shadow of the altar, the monk lit a candle and carried it to the crucifix. First, he illuminated the crown of thorns, next, the two wounded hands of Jesus and finally, the mark of the spear wound in his side. In the hush that fell, he blew out the candle and sat down – there was nothing else to say.

GOD LOVES YOU.

We rightly question it when someone says "I love you" but their actions tell the opposite story. Words are cheap. But God's actions emphasize and profoundly demonstrate the truth of his claim that he loves us – he doesn't sit in an ivory tower watching us destroy ourselves. No! He sent his Son. Jesus became a man with one aim – to die. John, dubbed the apostle of love, says emphatically, "This is love: not that we loved God, but that he loved us and sent his Son as an atoning sacrifice for our sins." When we get the opportunity to truly see this love for what it is and engage God in his ultimate act of love, it transforms us for all eternity.
This week we will explore four central truths about salvation:

1. *God loves all people.*
2. *Sin and sinfulness separate us from God.*
3. *God made a way for us to be forgiven and reconciled to him in Christ.*
4. *We have to make a personal choice to either receive or reject Christ's offer of eternal life.*

The greatest danger is that we end up agreeing that something is true but only in a general sense and so do not take the step of applying it to our own lives. This week is about exploring the truth of those four statements, but unless there is a personal and volitional response to that fact it means nothing. It would be like overhearing someone confess their undying love to their lover…It may be true, but it doesn't affect your life. Your creator – the God almighty – is shouting out unashamedly in the sacrifice of his Son: *I LOVE YOU.*

Too many people seek to paint a picture of a God that is cold, aloof and frankly disinterested in us. This distorted picture shows us a god waiting to reward us only when we comply with religious rules, and punish us the moment we step out of line. How utterly opposed to the picture of God revealed in the sacred texts of the Bible. Here we encounter God as he is: just and true, and also compassionate, kind, gentle and patient. A God whose very name "Immanuel" means the God who comes near, a God who invites us to call him Father.

Our heavenly Father hates the fact that those he created are ensnared by sin and face a destiny of death and eternal separation from him. Our Father didn't just say he loves us – he has acted! He sent his Son that you and I might have freedom, real life, and be restored into relationship with him.

> *I am the gate; whoever enters through me will be saved. They will come in and go out, and find pasture. The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy; I have come that they may have life, and have it to the full.*
> John 10:10

The offer of life – and life to the full – is one of the expressions of God's love for us. Jesus reveals how this is to be accomplished in the next few verses:

> *I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep. He who is a hired hand and not a shepherd, who does not own the sheep, sees the wolf coming and leaves the sheep and flees, and the wolf snatches them and scatters them. He flees because he is a hired hand and cares nothing for the sheep. I am the good shepherd. I know my own, and my own know me, just as the Father knows me and I know the Father, and I lay down my life for the sheep.*
> John 10:11-15

In this passage, Jesus is portraying himself as a good shepherd. This is a shepherd who knows and cares deeply for his sheep so when danger comes their way, he is prepared to stand and fight. He loves those who are entrusted to him so much that he is even prepared to lay down his life. This is what Paul is talking about in the opening of his letter to the church in Ephesus where he wants to remind the readers of the great love that God has for them, a love that means they have been chosen and adopted as sons and daughters of God. All this is only possible because of the love that God has for each one of us.

You are not overhearing someone else's declaration of love! God is speaking *TO YOU*, "I love you." Acknowledging what God has said (and conclusively demonstrated in Christ) is the first step to an engagement with him that will transform you in ways you cannot even conceive. Why don't you fill your name in this sentence right now and invite the Holy Spirit to speak these words into your soul.

"I LOVE YOU_____."
- GOD

We would like you to find a place to spend some time each day in solitude, reflecting upon the questions and challenges the day's reading may raise. Christ gave the example by setting himself apart from distractions and other people to devote time to his relationship with the Father. Some people call these "quiet times" and for the purpose of this guide, we will refer to that place as your listening room. Why don't you go right now and find a place where you can sit and talk with God and answer the questions below.

Reflection Questions:

1. Do you believe God loves you? If not, what prevents you from believing?

2. How does knowing that God loves you change how you see yourself?

3. How does knowing that God loves you change how you see other people?

Challenge:

Today, in prayer, ask God to reveal His love for you.

In him, we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of sins, in accordance with the riches of God's grace that he lavished on us.

EPHESIANS 1:7-8

WEEK 1 DAY 2

WEEK THEME:
Steps to Salvation

DAY THEME:
Man is Sinful

I'm not very good about going to the doctor. I suppose I think I'll just get better if I give it enough time. Often that's true, but there are situations where the condition is so painful or the remedial action is so beyond my own ability that even I admit the best thing is to get to the doctor as soon as I can. Then as we get older, we find ourselves visiting the doctor even when things seem fine - checkups that are recommended to make sure we aren't sick without knowing it. This is especially important if our parents or grandparents had a disease that can be passed on in our genetics! Catching these "invisible" symptoms early will often save someone's life.

Today's reading is like one of those visits to the doctor, but this time it's a spiritual ailment that is being diagnosed. The Bible says we have all inherited a sickness called sin from our earliest forefather Adam. Adam sinned against God and since then every human being has been born with a heart bent towards sin. Sin is any thought, word, or deed that falls short of God's standard of holiness and perfection, and all of us, because of this sin-sickness, fall short. You may have heard of the Ten Commandments, which were given by God to Israel as a standard so that they could know how to live a holy life. Well for thousands of years, Israel tried but always fell short. We do too. Jesus took it even further saying that if we look at a woman lustfully, we have committed adultery; that if we get angry with our brother, we have committed murder. Have you ever lusted or gotten angry with someone? Have you ever lied or coveted someone else's property? Have you ever failed to love God with all of your heart? Yeah, me too.

Some people argue against what the Bible teaches about sin, saying that we are born good but learn wickedness, suggesting that if we can change the way our society is set up, we can be free of sin. That's a way of saying, we can save ourselves. However, as Malcolm Muggeridge once said, "The depravity of man is the most empirically verifiable reality." In other words, every generation and culture has proven our irresistible tendency towards sin. Even our very progressive generation, with all our advances in technology and psychology, is marked by rising rates of relational hostility, anxiety, suicide, divorce, greed, and abuse. The Bible's diagnosis that "all have sinned" (Romans 3:23) is shown again and again in our attitudes and actions as accurate, and goes on in chapter 6 to say that tragically, "the wages of sin is death." Not only does our sin mess up our human relationships and rob us of peace and joy in this life, but it also leads to an eternal separation from God. Eternal death in hell where we pay the penalty for our sin. That is the bad news.

The apostle Paul, who wrote the letter to the church in Rome, however goes on to tell us that there is also good news: that while the wages (what we deserve) of sin is death, the gift of God (what we don't deserve) is *ETERNAL LIFE* (Romans 6:23).

Hundreds of years before Paul wrote these words, the prophet Isaiah was praying in the Temple in Jerusalem when he saw a vision of God on his throne. As he gazed upon the Lord Almighty, he cried out, "Woe to me! I am ruined! For I am a man of unclean lips, and live among a people of unclean lips, and my eyes have seen the King, the Lord Almighty" (Isaiah 6:5). When Isaiah was confronted with God, he saw so clearly his own sinfulness, and that this made him utterly unqualified to be in God's presence.

That recognition by Isaiah, that he was "a man of unclean lips," was as strange as it seems, the first step towards salvation. That is because the idea that we can

save ourselves is a lie from Satan - only in Christ can we find forgiveness for the sin that separates us from God the Father. When Isaiah admitted his guilt to God, God responded.

> *Then one of the seraphim flew to me with a live coal in his hand, which he had taken with tongs from the altar. With it, he touched my mouth and said, 'See, this has touched your lips; your guilt is taken away and your sin atoned for.'*
> - Isaiah 6:6-7

God dealt with Isaiah's sin. The guilt and shame were taken away and his sin was atoned for. This encounter in the Temple was a foreshadowing of the mission and ministry of Jesus and his substitutionary death on the cross.

We must all, like Isaiah, admit our own fallen state: "Woe to me! I am ruined! For I am a man of unclean lips." Do you recognize that the words of Paul we read earlier are true – that we all have sinned and fallen short of the glory of God, including you? Without the forgiveness of God through Christ's sacrificial death on the cross, we remain separated and condemned. If, however, like Isaiah, you admit that you are justly condemned, and cry out to God for his mercy you will receive forgiveness and salvation.

> *Everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved.*
> - Romans 10:13

Friend, you may not be experiencing a vision like Isaiah had that day in the Temple, but you are, right now, in front of the Lord God Almighty - how will you respond? Will you be like the many who gloss over their sin and ignore this wakeup call? Or will you acknowledge the truth of God's word, admit you are a sinner, and rest only on the assured hope of salvation through Jesus Christ's death and resurrection?

Reflection Questions:

1. What do you think your response would be if you were to encounter The Holy God face to face?

2. How do you see the effect of your sinful nature play out in your life?

3. What does repentance, declaring "Woe to me! I am ruined! For I am a man of unclean lips" look like for you?

Challenge:

Ask God to come and search your heart and mind, showing you the areas of your life where you know that you have broken God's law. If you haven't repented of your sin and come to Christ in faith, but you feel God drawing you strongly now, look ahead and read Day 4.

"God, I ask you to come and search my heart and mind. Show me the areas of my life where I know that I have broken your laws and my sins have separated me from you. I am truly sorry, and now I want to turn away from my past sinful life toward you. Please forgive me and help me avoid sinning again. I believe that your son, Jesus Christ, who died for my sins and was resurrected from the dead, is alive and hears my prayer. I invite Jesus to become the Lord of my life, to rule and reign in my heart from this day forward. Please send your Holy Spirit to help me obey you and to do your will for the rest of my life. In Jesus' name, I pray, Amen."

In Him, we have redemption
through His blood, the forgiveness
of sins, in accordance
with the riches of God's grace
that He lavished on us.

EPHESIANS 1:7-8a

WEEK 1 DAY 3

WEEK THEME:
Steps to Salvation

DAY THEME:
Jesus is Salvation

MEMORY VERSE:
"Everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved."
ROMANS 10:13

Yesterday we looked at the sinful state of man and the separation this causes between us and God. Today we will look at God and his response to the sin that enslaves us. Despite our rejection of God, scripture shows emphatically that he wants to restore us to a right relationship with him. The problem is that sin creates a separation between God and us; it wasn't that God had moved away from us but that humanity, in Adam, chose to remove itself from a vibrant, submitted, and worshipful relationship with God. God wasn't the one who changed – we were. Now in our sinful state, we aren't able to do anything about restarting it.

The gospel / good news is this: our sin has been dealt with so we can be declared innocent and reconciled to God. Our rebellion from God required a price to be paid but due to our sinful nature, we are not able to pay it. Only one who is sinless can atone for our sin and this rules out every human as all are stained by sin.

There is only one way for God to forgive us without being unjust (looking the other way with regards to our crimes / sin) – for God himself to take our place and bear the just punishment that our sins deserve. The only way for God to be just and to be the One who justifies (forgives) is for God himself to bear the penalty for our sin. So in God's audacious rescue plan, Jesus was supernaturally conceived of a virgin and born both fully God and fully man. Free of Adam's inherited sin, he lived a sinless life for the express purpose of dying as the perfect sacrifice for our sin. In his death and resurrection, Jesus overcame sin and death so that all have access to forgiveness, and a way to be reconciled to God the Father.

This is the crux of the Christian message: we are all sinners and Jesus' substitutionary death on the cross is the only way our sin can be forgiven and we can be saved. We are unable to save ourselves! For many, this is a stumbling block because it demands that we come to God empty-handed and humbly receive the salvation we could never earn ourselves. Yet for those who accept this truth, it is the path to salvation. Without Jesus, whether you realize it or not, you are a broken, rebellious sinner who is spiritually lost and facing an eternity separated from God. But once you are "in Christ" the Bible says you are:

SAVED
from the penalty of your sin by grace through faith.

CHANGED
from sinner to a righteous saint not through your own "good" works, but through the actions of your Savior Jesus.

ADOPTED
into the family of God as his child.

GIVEN
the Holy Spirit to live in you and empower you to carry out the mission of Christ.

This is the good news that Paul spent his life preaching, and what he wanted the church in Ephesus to remember. This is why he reminded them that:

> *In him, we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of sins, in accordance with the riches of God's grace that he lavished on us.*
> Ephesians 1:7-8a

When we allow this truth to penetrate our hearts, and receive God's forgiveness through Christ the weight of guilt and shame and condemnation is removed from us. We start to live a new life, truly free of our past mistakes – no wonder it is called the Good News.

Reflection Questions:

1. What ideas or images come to your mind when you think about the cross?

2. How does knowing Jesus dealt with your sin on the cross change the way you live your life?

3. Are you living in the freedom that comes from the cross if you are a Christian? If you are not a Christian, what do you think stops you from accepting the truth of the cross?

Challenge:

Spend time meditating on the cross. You may wish to read the account of the crucifixion found in John 19. (If you haven't already done so, you may sense as you read through this chapter, the Holy Spirit inviting you to take the next step and seek salvation from God. If this is the case, then look ahead to day 4 and read through the invitation found there).

In him, we were also chosen, having been predestined according to the plan of him who works out everything in conformity with the purpose of his will, in order that we, who were the first to put our hope in Christ, might be for the praise of his glory.

EPHESIANS 1:11-12

WEEK 1 DAY 4

WEEK THEME:
Steps to Salvation

DAY THEME:
Choice

I remember very clearly the day I stood at the front of a church and was confronted with a choice. A choice that would forever change my life – a conscious, personal decision, entered into willingly and wholeheartedly. It was my wedding day and a day I will always cherish. The "I do" wasn't something someone else could do for me. I stood there next to my beautiful bride, I chose to say "yes" and have never looked back. That covenant decision has impacted every area of my life every day since.

Likewise in our relationship with Christ, it's not enough to know a set of truths, or for someone else, like our parents or society, to decide for us. We cannot be born Christian, nor become a Christian simply because our spouse has started following Jesus. No, we must choose to accept Christ, believing that he is who he claims to be or reject him, believing there is another, better way to find forgiveness for our sins. The Christian journey is one of covenant relationship and, as such, each one of us must come to that point of choosing to accept or reject Jesus. To accept him means to accept, in faith, the truths that we have been exploring over the last few days:

1. *God loves me.*
2. *I am sinful and separated from God.*
3. *Jesus is the only way to salvation.*

You may wish to go back to week 1 day 1 to remind yourself of these great truths. When we are in a place where we recognize these statements as true, the Holy Spirit will lead us to receive God's forgiveness and to accept Jesus as Lord. It is at that moment that we move from spiritual death to being made spiritually alive. This is salvation. At this moment, the whole of heaven rejoices and celebrates as we literally become children of God and are reborn in the Spirit. Paul lays this out in his letter to the church in Rome:

> *If you declare with your mouth "Jesus is Lord," and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved. For it is with your heart that you believe and are justified, and it is with your mouth that you profess your faith and are saved.*
> Romans 10:9-10

In the gospel of John, we are privy to a secret meeting between Jesus and Nicodemus, one of the Jewish teachers of the law. He asks Jesus how can someone be born again: "Surely they cannot enter a second time into their mother's womb to be born?" Jesus responds that this birth is of the Spirit, for it is only by the Spirit of God that we can declare that "Jesus is Lord." This is the process of being "born again." It is that simple and beautiful yet some still choose to reject Jesus' offer of salvation and remain in darkness. Jesus then sums up the state of those who reject him:

> *Light has come into the world, but people loved darkness instead of light because their deeds were evil. Everyone who does evil hates the light, and will not come into the light for fear that their deeds will be exposed. But whoever lives by the truth comes into the light, so that it may be seen plainly that what they have done has been done in the sight of God.*
> John 3:19-20

Friend, the choice is a simple one: you can either embrace the truth that scripture declares about your salvation or choose to dwell in the darkness by rejecting Christ, but you cannot live in both darkness and light. Right now, you may sense the Spirit of God leading you to move from darkness to light, from death to life.

Reflection Questions:

1. Have you accepted Jesus as your Lord and Savior or just trusted in being raised as a Christian?

2. If you haven't yet accepted Jesus, what are the things that are holding you back?

3. Are you ready today to accept Jesus as your Lord and Savior?

Challenge:

If you have already accepted Jesus personally in your life, spend some time in thanksgiving for the amazing gift of salvation that he has offered you.

If you haven't already believed and received Jesus as your Lord and Savior, but believe the four truths we have explored this week, then pray the prayer below. There is nothing magical about this prayer – it is simply a guide to help you declare the truths you now believe and to surrender your life to Jesus.

God our Father, I believe that out of your infinite love, you have created me. In a thousand ways, I have shunned your love and leadership but today I repent of my sins and my sinfulness. I turn away from my sinful past and turn to you. Please forgive me and receive me as your child. Thank you for sending your Son to die for me and to save me from eternal death. I choose this day to enter into a relationship with you as I surrender to Jesus as Lord over my whole life. I ask you now to flood my soul with the gift of the Holy Spirit so that my life may be transformed. Give me the grace and courage to live as a disciple and a child in the family of God, your Church for the rest of my days. Amen.

Date:

Signed:

I pray that the eyes of your heart may be enlightened in order that you may know the hope to which he has called you, the riches of his glorious inheritance in his holy people, and his incomparably great power for us who believe…And God placed all things under [Jesus'] feet and appointed him to be head over everything for the church, which is his body, the fullness of him who fills everything in every way.

EPHESIANS 1:8-19 & 22-23

WEEK 1 DAY 5

WEEK THEME:
Steps to Salvation

DAY THEME:
Our Past is Dealt With

"And the promise from Jesus is clear: he is the one who gives us eternal life and he will keep us to the end!"

The great architect Frank Lloyd Wright was given the challenge of building the Imperial Hotel in Tokyo, one of the most earthquake-prone cities in the world. Wright's investigation showed that a solid foundation could be "floated" on a sixty-foot layer of soft mud underlying the hotel, which would provide a shock-absorbing but stable support for the immense building. Shortly after the hotel was completed, it withstood the worst earthquake in fifty-two years while lesser buildings fell in ruins around it. The foundations we choose to build upon make all the difference. Frank Lloyd Wright understood this principle and because of this was able to ensure the Imperial Hotel would survive even serious earthquakes resulting in the saving of many lives.

The principle is the same in a person's life – the foundations we build our lives upon matter. When we find ourselves in times of trouble, the truths on which our lives are built will either help us to endure or they will be the reason for our utter collapse. One of the most important foundations of our faith is the assurance of our salvation. When those earthquakes of trials and tests hit, we can be faced with doubts about our relationship with God and the state of our salvation. This is not what God intended and the assurance of salvation is one of the promises he has given to all those who believe in him.

John the apostle realized this was a struggle for the early church and so under inspiration from the Holy Spirit wrote this:

> *And this is the testimony: God has given us eternal life, and this life is in his Son. Whoever has the Son has life; whoever does not have the Son of God does not have life. I write these things to you who believe in the name of the Son of God so that you may know that you have eternal life.*
> 1 John 5:11-13

We see three clear declarations about us having this new life and by which we can have the assurance that we are saved. First, in verse 11 we are told that "God has given us eternal life." That eternal life isn't just a future reality but something that starts the day we believe. Secondly, in verse 12 that "Whoever has the Son has life." Therefore, if you have accepted Jesus, you are now alive in him and, as you will see below, this life cannot be taken away. Finally, to make it entirely clear verse 13 states that "you have eternal life." This is good news indeed.

> *My sheep listen to my voice; I know them, and they follow me. I give them eternal life, and they shall never perish; no one will snatch them out of my hand. My Father, who has given them to me, is greater than all; no one can snatch them out of my Father's hand. I and the Father are one.*
> John 10:27-30

Friend, doesn't this declaration of Jesus fill your heart with confidence in his ability to see you through this life and into the next, firmly in his loving grasp? Such confidence that our salvation is secure is what we mean when we talk about the assurance of salvation.

And the promise from Jesus is clear: he is the one who gives us eternal life and he will keep us to the end!

The implications of this are enormous! Fear and uncertainty about the future lose their grip in our lives for when we know our foundations are solid then, no matter what we may see coming on the horizon, we are aware we will endure. After the Imperial Hotel survived that initial devastating earthquake, bookings at the hotel went up dramatically. People had seen it had weathered the shock and had confidence it could survive earthquakes in the future. Likewise, when we rest on the truth of God, we can be assured our salvation will endure all that the world and the devil can throw at us!

Perhaps you have come to faith in Christ this week (or even before). If so, your eyes were opened to the truth of your need for a Savior and that only Christ can be that Savior. So the Holy Spirit has been drawing you and when you surrendered in faith, it meant that you *HAVE* been *FORGIVEN*, you *WERE ACCEPTED* and *YOU ARE, NOW AND FOREVER, SAVED*.

The journey you have embarked on was never promised to be an easy one but God has promised he will never leave you or forsake you. In him, you have someone in whom you can take refuge, someone who will be your stronghold and your shield; this is the greatest foundation that anyone can build their lives on.

Reflection Questions:

1. What are some of the other things (apart from God) that you have built your life upon?

2. How does knowing that "all things [are] under his feet" help you to trust God?

3. What areas of your life do you find hardest to surrender to God?

Challenge:

Spend some time asking the Holy Spirit to show you any area of your life which hasn't been surrendered to God and then pray through that list placing each one of them under his feet.

Praise be to the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who has blessed us in the heavenly realms with every spiritual blessing in Christ. For he chose us in him before the creation of the world to be holy and blameless in his sight. In love, he predestined us for adoption to sonship through Jesus Christ, in accordance with his pleasure and will – to the praise of his glorious grace, which he has freely given us in the One he loves.

EPHESIANS 1: 3-6

WEEK 2 DAY 1

WEEK THEME:
In Him

DAY THEME:
Chosen



MEMORY VERSE:
"For he chose us in him before the creation of the world to be holy and blameless in his sight."
EPHESIANS 1:4

Over the last week, we have examined the steps of salvation and this week we will explore some of the consequences of making that decision. For in that moment, when we recognize Jesus alone is our Lord and Savior, everything changes: our identity, our relationship with others, the world, and God. The starting point is that we must take hold of our new identity in Jesus. The challenge for the next two weeks is to linger and fully consider the implications of what Christ has accomplished for us without rushing into obedience. I remember someone using the idea of painting on a canvas to illustrate this. The artist first paints a base layer, and then he has to wait for it to dry. If the artist impatiently starts with the colors of the painting while the base is still wet they will mix or run. The way is to let the base layer dry fully before starting the rest of the painting. Well, our new identity in Christ (base layer) and our life of obedience (the colors that will be added) are like that.

For Paul, this was a big deal and throughout his letter to the church in Ephesus, he keeps reminding his readers of who they are. He does this by reminding them of the different aspects of their new identity found "in him" (Jesus). This week, we will unpack five of these different "in him" statements and explore what they mean for us in our new identity:

We are CHOSEN *(Ephesians 1:4)*
We are REDEEMED *(Ephesians 1:7)*
We are MARKED *(Ephesians 1:13)*
We are BUILT-UP *(Ephesians 2:21)*
We can APPROACH GOD *(Ephesians 3:12)*

What does it mean to be "in him"? This question is vital because once we understand this we can start to unpack the five wonderful truths Paul presents. One of the best ways to understand what it means to be "in him" is the idea that our identity is no longer associated or determined by the brokenness of the world around us, but instead, it is based upon the hope and promises of Jesus. We get to experience the fullness of life that can only come from God as we are no longer bound to the world but united with Jesus.

The first of the five promises we will explore is that "in him, we are chosen." In a world full of brokenness, hurt, and rejection, the idea that God has chosen us is actually remarkable. The word "chosen" in the original Greek is eklégomai: it means to pick out, to select, or to choose for one's self.

This is relational language; it wasn't some random selection as if God was sticking his hand into a bag and grabbing whoever he could. Instead, it speaks to the fact that God has carefully and personally chosen you. This is the ultimate counter to a world that speaks a word of rejection and brokenness over so many of us.

Paul then goes on to say that not only are we chosen but we have, in fact, been adopted into his family through Jesus. In many cultures around the world today, when a child is adopted by a set of parents they are issued with a new birth certificate, bearing the names of their new parents. This certificate of adoption affords them all the legal rights and privileges of a biological child. In the eyes of the law, there is no difference between those who are adopted and those born into the family. This is the language that Paul uses when talking about a new identity in Jesus. We now get to share in all the rights and privileges that come from being a child of God. It is this truth that gives us the security and surety of our salvation. Our new identity can never be taken away from us.

What is essential to remember is that you were not chosen because of your

merit, good works, or holiness – but by God's grace. This is incredibly liberating because it means that you cannot do anything that will make you more, or less, chosen. It is simply a truth you need to accept and believe and live in the light of. All of this is the result solely of God's goodness and grace toward us. The impact on us today is whether or not we are prepared to live our lives like we have been chosen and have been adopted as God's son or daughter.

Reflection Questions:

1. How do you feel knowing you have been "chosen" by God?

2. What are the implications for your spiritual journey knowing you are "chosen?"

3. How does being "chosen" change how you see your spiritual brothers and sisters in Christ?

Challenge:

You may struggle with the truth that you are "chosen" especially if you have faced rejection or hurt. If you find this difficult, then spend some time asking the Holy Spirit to give you a revelation deep in your soul so that the truth moves from your head to your heart. God will respond and will show you what it means for you to be chosen in love by him.

In him, we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of sins, in accordance with the riches of God's grace that he lavished on us. With all wisdom and understanding, he made known to us the mystery of his will according to his good pleasure, which he purposed in Christ, to be put into effect when the times reach their fulfilment – to bring unity to all things in heaven and on earth under Christ.

EPHESIANS 1:7-10

WEEK 2 DAY 2

WEEK THEME:
In Him

DAY THEME:
Redeemed

In him, we are redeemed. This is at the heart of the gospel message proclaimed in scripture. In the first week, as we journeyed through the steps to salvation, we explored the idea that we are sinful and that it is only through the death of Christ, who took our place on the cross, that our sin could be dealt with. Today, we explore this idea more deeply and ask "what does it mean to be redeemed and how should this play out in the day to day of our lives?"

The story is told of a gentleman visiting a slave market, who was deeply touched by the mental agony of a slave-girl. The gentleman inquired about her price, paid it to the slave-trader, then placed the bill of sale in her own hands, telling her that she was free, and could now go home. The slave-girl could not comprehend the change at first, but, running after the man who had redeemed her, she cried, "He has redeemed me! He has redeemed me! Will you let me be your servant?"

In Paul's letters to the Ephesians, we see there are three key elements that we must grasp to fully understand redemption. Firstly, redemption can only take place when we are "in him" or united with Christ. This is simply because we have no power to redeem ourselves. It's like an impoverished slave hoping to buy his freedom when his life comes up for sale at the market. Because he doesn't have the asking price, someone else has to redeem him and thus, free him from bondage. We were "powerless" to free ourselves from our own sin – it was out of God's actioned love for us that we were redeemed.

Secondly, Paul highlights that the price of this redemption was "his blood." God couldn't simply declare that we were redeemed, he first had to pay the ransom price so that we can be set free from the slavery of our sin. The only way to do this is through the shedding of blood. This is what the Temple sacrifice system was designed to teach. Three times a year people would come to the Temple and present a "spotless" animal that could then be sacrificed and offered as an atonement for sins (atonement simply means an action/sacrifice that removes the basis for separation – it can be easily remembered by saying it creates at-one-ment). The problem was that as soon as they stepped out of the Temple, they were very quickly back in the same sinful state and needed to make a sacrifice again which they did year after year after year! The peace purchased at the Temple was only ever temporary for it fell short of what was necessary to actually redeem humankind. Only a perfect, sinless sacrifice could do that.

> *Day after day, every priest stands and performs his religious duties; again and again, he offers the same sacrifices which can never take away sins. But when this priest [Jesus] had offered for all time one sacrifice for sins, he sat down at the right hand of God, and since that time he waits for his enemies to be made his footstool. For by one sacrifice he has made perfect forever those who are being made holy.*
> Hebrews 10:11-14

Lastly, Paul highlights that not only does his blood redeem us but also that through his blood, our sins are forgiven. We have not just been bought back – the past sins that brought us bondage and separation from God have now been forgiven and so has our future sin, therefore, there will never be a basis for our re-enslavement. Being redeemed transforms our relationship with God and with each other because we have been liberated not just from sin's penalty but also from its control.

While the sacrifice was made at a single moment in history, two thousand years ago, the ability to access it and allow it

to transform our lives is a daily choice. It is actually a choice of relationship – are we prepared to see ourselves as being "in him"? Only when we proclaim and believe this truth are we able to benefit from the redemption that comes from being counted in him.

Reflection Questions:

1. What does redemption mean to you?

2. Are there areas of your life that stop you from embracing the truth that you are fully redeemed? If so, what are they?

3. How does being redeemed change your life?

Challenge:

Spend time today in prayer thanking God that you have been redeemed and asking him to reveal to you how this should change the way you approach life.

And you also were included in Christ when you heard the message of truth, the gospel of your salvation. When you believed, you were marked in him with a seal, the promised Holy Spirit, who is a deposit guaranteeing our inheritance until the redemption of those who are God's possession – to the praise of his glory.

EPHESIANS 1:13-14

WEEK 2 DAY 3

WEEK THEME:
In Him

DAY THEME:
Marked

MEMORY VERSE:
"When you believed, you were marked in him with a seal, the promised Holy Spirit, who is a deposit guaranteeing our inheritance until the redemption of those who are God's possession."
EPHESIANS 1:14

"The assurance of our salvation is a promise and gift that each and every believer is able to experience."

When I say the word "sealed," what comes to your mind? For some, it may be those scenes from a TV show where a king or nobleman seals a letter with red wax and his signet ring. Or for others, it may be the revolution that is Tupperware – suddenly all those leftover food items can be sealed shut so they won't spoil. For me, I think of Christmas presents. My sister and I tried to see which gifts we could secretly unwrap to get an early peek, then re-seal them so our parents wouldn't know. After several years, we became masters of carefully removing the sticky tape and opening the paper to get a glimpse and then, with such precision, placing everything back as we had found it. This was until one year when we got caught. From that moment on, everything was double bagged and large amounts of tape were used to make it impossible for us to break in. Our parents were determined that these gifts would be sealed and kept safe until the appointed time.

Paul reminds the church in Ephesus that one of the markers of being "in Christ" is that we are now marked and sealed with the Holy Spirit. This is one of the great privileges that comes with being a follower of Christ and one that Christians can too easily forget. So let's explore what it means to be sealed with the Holy Spirit.

The steps that lead up to us being marked in the Spirit are quite simple. First, we "[hear] the message of truth, the gospel of your salvation" or to put it another way, are presented with the good news. The second step is "when you believed." In other words, we take what we have heard and receive it in faith and the result of these two steps is that we then are given the seal of the Holy Spirit. A seal that carries with it a particular weight and authority.

SECURITY

The king's seal was used as a mark of security. When delivering important documents from the king, his seal would be placed on the letter with wax and his ring. As such, only the person who was meant to receive the letter could break the seal. If it had been tampered with along the way, then this would clearly be visible. The seal was designed to secure what was being contained within. In the same way, when we are sealed by the Spirit, we are secured by God – a sign to all those in the heavenly realms that we are not tampered with and that the integrity of the contents will not be compromised.

OWNERSHIP

Being sealed with the Holy Spirit is also a sign of ownership. We are God's

holy possessions twice bought – first at creation and second at the time of salvation. We will remain his treasured possession until the end of time. The seal of the Holy Spirit is, in this sense, the confirmation of our salvation, who we belong to, and a truth that no one can now dispute.

AUTHENTICITY

The seal is also a mark of authenticity. As each person traditionally had their own seal and it was a way to assess the authenticity of a document to make sure it wasn't forged. In the same way, the seal of the Spirit marks us out as being an authentic member of God's kingdom and his family.

AUTHORITY

Being sealed with the Spirit allows us to carry the authority of God. As believers, we now can pray for healing, cast out demons, proclaim God's kingdom, and teach the mysteries of faith. When we do these things, marked with the Holy Spirit, we are doing them with God's blessing and authority.

Finally, for Paul, the most important part of being sealed with the Holy Spirit was the fact that it provided the guarantee that all the other promises made by God to his children can be relied upon. The Holy Spirit is the "deposit guaranteeing our inheritance." That should give us a great deal of peace, especially in a world that is quick to break its promises. The Holy Spirit reminds us that the salvation we have received (which we explored back in week 1) cannot be taken away from us. The assurance of our salvation is a promise and gift that each and every believer is able to experience.

Reflection Questions:

1. Out of the four areas that being sealed in the Holy Spirit confirms, which area resonates most with you? And why?

2.Which area do you find hardest to believe? And why?

3. How does knowing that you are sealed with the Holy Spirit change how you live out your faith?

Challenge:

Today spend time asking God to confirm his seal upon your life and showing you what it means for you to be secured in him, owned by him, authenticated by him, and given his authority.

Consequently, you are no longer foreigners and strangers, but fellow citizens with God's people and also members of his household, built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets, with Christ Jesus himself as the chief cornerstone. In him, the whole building is joined together and rises to become a holy temple in the Lord. And in him, you too are being built together to become a dwelling in which God lives by his Spirit.

EPHESIANS 2:19-22

WEEK 2 DAY 4

WEEK THEME:
In Him

DAY THEME:
Built Together

Have you ever stepped back to consider just how amazing our bodies are? Over the course of 24 hours:

your heart beats 103,689 times
your blood travels 168,000,000 miles
you breathe 23,040 times
you inhale 12 cubic metres of air
you eat 1.5 kilograms of food
you drink 2.7 litres of liquids
you lose 400 grams of waste
you speak 4,800 words (including some unnecessary ones)
you move 750 muscles
your nails grow 0.0012 mm
your hair grows 0.44 mm
you exercise 7,000,000 brain cells

All of this has been perfectly knit together by God and it's this picture of the master builder's work that Paul uses when explaining what it means to be "in him."

In a building, each part is vital and has been carefully crafted to fulfil a particular function. When we are "in him," we lay down our own agenda and we are able to fulfil the purpose God has crafted for us. This is no ordinary building and Paul explains that this building of which we are a part is a holy temple. This holy temple is the place that God has chosen to make his dwelling place or, to put it another way, we are to become the place in which God lives. The central outcome of being "in him" is that he chooses to dwell in us. This is one of the great paradoxes of the Christian faith but one that should give us immense joy and provoke profound wonder! Let's take a step back for a moment and consider the magnitude of this – the God of the universe, the One who put the stars in their place, who formed the mountains and the seas; the God who was, and is, and is to come has chosen to make his dwelling in us! When we lay down our own lives, plans, and agendas, we may feel we are giving up a lot but what we receive is far more than we could ever imagine.

Paul is careful to point out that while this is a personal promise to us as individuals, there is also an important corporate aspect to it as well – "in him, the whole building…" This building work that God is doing isn't something that happens in isolation but, instead, unity with fellow believers. Together, we "rise to become a holy temple." In our everyday walk, it is so easy to miss the fact that we are called to journey with our Christian brothers and sisters. Together we are strengthened, encouraged and spurred on to run the race. Something mystical takes place when we join with those around us – God shows up and dwells within us.

The central truth is that "in him" we become the bearers of his presence no matter where we go or what we face. In the darkest moments of our lives, when all those around us feel far away, God is in our midst. Even in those moments of hopelessness and despair, when the darkness feels like it is about to overcome us, the light of the world is in us. No darkness, despair, or tragedy can change the truth that when we are "in him," we carry his presence into every situation. And if God is in the middle of it all, then so is his love, his strength, his purity, and his hope. The challenge for us, as with every other promise from God, is whether we will believe it and work in it by faith.

Reflection Questions:

1. What does it mean for you to know that you are God's holy temple?

2. What are the patterns of thoughts, actions, or attitudes in your life that pollute his temple?

3. How does knowing that God dwells within you change how you approach difficult times in your life?

Challenge:

Spend time today in prayer reflecting on your life and asking God's Holy Spirit to reveal to you times where, in the past, you may have felt in darkness but you realize now that God was in fact dwelling in you. Use these thoughts and memories to give thanks to God for his presence and to strengthen you for today and tomorrow.

In him and through faith in him we may approach God with freedom and confidence. I ask you, therefore, not to be discouraged because of my sufferings for you, which are your glory.

EPHESIANS 3:12-13

WEEK 2 DAY 5

WEEK THEME:
In Him

DAY THEME:
Free to Come to Him

"...in him and through faith in him, we may approach God with freedom and confidence."

Over the last week, we have been exploring the "in him" statements found in Ephesians 1-3. We discovered that in him:

We are CHOSEN *(Ephesians 1:4)*
We are REDEEMED *(Ephesians 1:7)*
We are MARKED *(Ephesians 1:13)*
We are BUILT-UP *(Ephesians 2:21)*
We can APPROACH GOD *(Ephesians 3:12)*

These speak directly to the new identity we receive at the moment of salvation. When we can understand our new identity and amazing privileges that come along with expressions of it, we can start to unlock the full realities of the Christian life. The final truth we will explore is the notion that because we are "in him," we are able to approach God with freedom and confidence.

One of the key themes in the Old Testament is the holiness of God. Every time God interacted with humankind, barriers had to be erected and procedures followed to make sure that sinful humans would not perish when they came into direct contact with God's holiness. When God is about to meet with Moses on Mount Sinai and give him the Law, he lays out careful instructions:

> *Go to the people and consecrate them today and tomorrow. Have them wash their clothes and be ready by the third day because on that day, the Lord will come down on Mount Sinai in the sight of all the people. Put limits for the people around the mountain and tell them, "Be careful that you do not approach the mountain or touch the foot of it. Whoever touches the mountain is to be put to death. They are to be stoned or shot with arrows; not a hand is to be laid on them. No person or animal shall be permitted to live." Only when the ram's horn sounds a long blast may they approach the mountain.*
> Exodus 19:10-13

The holiness of God meant anyone or anything contaminated with sin would die in his presence. Even later on, in the Temple, only the high priest was allowed to enter the holy of holies to minister before God and only once a year.

This is the terrifying power that accompanies God's holiness and yet Paul declares to the church in Ephesus that "in him and through faith in him, we may approach God with freedom and confidence." How can this be? What has changed? This gets to the very heart of what it means to be justified before God.

To be justified means more than to be declared "not guilty." It means to be declared righteous before God. It means God has imputed or charged the guilt of our sin to his Son, Jesus Christ, and has imputed or credited Christ's righteousness to us. Jerry Bridges

During the period of the Old Testament, the people of Israel had no means to deal with the guilt of their sin. Therefore, whenever they encountered God, they were standing before God as unrighteous people. His holiness and their unrighteousness were incompatible and death would follow. However, on this side of the cross, believers have been marked as "in him" and it is not our sinful nature that God sees when we stand before him but, instead, Christ's righteousness. Everything has changed – we no longer approach God with fear and trembling like the Israelites out in the desert who had to approach the mountain, or the high priests entering the holy of holies. Now we can approach God with freedom and confidence because at the moment of salvation we were justified. The barrier caused by our sin that once separated us from a Holy God has been removed.

What hope and peace is ours, knowing that we can now approach God confidently expecting to find acceptance and grace. We can rest in his presence and call him "Abba Father." This is the good news of the gospel.

Reflection Questions:

1. What are the things in your life that make you feel like you can't approach God?

2. What does it mean to you to know that when God looks at you, he sees Christ's righteousness?

3. What does being able to approach God mean to you?

Challenge:

Spend time today giving thanks that you have been justified by Christ and now can be found "in him."

As for you, you were dead in your transgressions and sins, in which you used to live when you followed the ways of this world and of the ruler of the kingdom of the air, the spirit who is now at work in those who are disobedient. All of us also lived among them at one time, gratifying the cravings of our flesh and following its desires and thoughts. Like the rest, we were by nature deserving of wrath. But because of his great love for us, God, who is rich in mercy, made us alive with Christ even when we were dead in transgressions – it is by grace you have been saved.

EPHESIANS 2:1-5

WEEK 3 DAY 1

WEEK THEME:
Transformed by Grace

DAY THEME:
Grace that We Don't Deserve



MEMORY VERSE:
"For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith – and this is not from yourselves, it is the gift of God."
EPHESIANS 2:8

I don't know about you but I can be terrible at receiving gifts. When someone gives me something unexpectedly, I go into a panic when I realize that they are expecting me to open it in front of them. It seems ridiculous but I worry that somehow I will offend them by not showing enough excitement or gratitude – so I draw out the process as much as I can, slowly removing the wrapping paper and neatly folding it before throwing it away. I keep thinking "game face, I need to get my game face on." Then, I can show them just how appreciative I am. It truly is ridiculous, I know, but it comes from a place of not wanting to disappoint and if I am honest, a place of feeling that I don't deserve what I am about to receive.

Many of us struggle with the idea of only receiving. When invited for dinner, before leaving, we cannot help but say "you must come to ours" or when someone buys us coffee, "I will get yours next time." To truly receive humbles us because we can't do anything to earn a gift and in the case of God's gift to us, to even be worthy of it. Gift-giving is about wanting to bless the person who is receiving.

This week we are going to be exploring what this amazing gift of grace is that God has given each and everyone of us who believes in Jesus and how it changes our relationship to God. Grace is the unmerited favor of God – and that is the point! We have no merit or goodness that makes us worthy to receive this gift. It is God shouting from the heavens "I love you" and is perfectly seen in the greatest act of love ever: Jesus sent by the Father to die on the cross so that we can be saved. Grace is the Father fully knowing what the prodigal son has been up to and yet running towards him with his arms wide open, ready to welcome him back (go and read Luke 15, it's a great story).

The gospel of the grace of God awakens an intense longing in human souls and an equally intense resentment because the truth that it reveals is not palatable or easy to swallow. There is a certain pride in people that causes them to give and give, but to come and accept a gift is another thing. I will give my life to martyrdom; I will dedicate my life to service, I will do anything. But do not humiliate me to the level of the most hell-deserving sinner and tell me that all I have to do is accept the gift of salvation through Jesus Christ.
Oswald Chambers

For the Apostle Paul, God's grace is the central theme of the good news – so he spends a good chunk of his letter to the church in Ephesus expanding on its importance. He talks about how we can only receive God's gift of forgiveness through faith and that, before this, we were dead in our sin and slaves to the desires and cravings of our flesh. Paul is quick to remind us that "all of us" were in this state.

Not one of the millions and millions of Christ's followers through the ages was able to save themselves and all of us were deserving of God's wrath. This is a hard truth to accept for those who have not yet received God's forgiveness but this is the message of scripture. While this is the beginning of the story for every person, it doesn't have to be the end. Paul goes on to say that even in that place of hostility towards God, he still reaches out to us and seeks to "[make] us alive with Christ." The gift of salvation came as a result of God's love and desire "that none should perish." This is indeed good news! This is grace!

No matter what shameful sins have been a part of your journey, know that you are not beyond the grace of God. This is why it is so important that it's a gift and

not something we earn. If it were ours to work for, we all would fall short; if it were ours to work to keep, we would quickly lose God's favor.

Salvation is simply receiving God's gift. Can you see that the enemy, Satan, wants to sow confusion and doubt – making you believe that God could surely not be this good and kind, or that you ought to repay God for his goodness towards you. There is no way you could even if you wanted to. The gospel demands humility, surrender, and receipt of his salvation. There is no gift more wonderful.

Reflection Questions:

1. Do you struggle to accept God's grace in your life? If so, why?

2. Do you wrongly think "I deserve to be forgiven" or have you come to see how dead / lost you were because of your sin?

3. How does God's grace change how you now see yourself?

Challenge:

Today, knowing that you are only saved by God's grace, spend some time in worship thanking God for this and asking him to write this truth on your heart. Reject the lie that says because you aren't worthy, you aren't accepted.

But because of his great love for us, God, who is rich in mercy, made us alive with Christ even when we were dead in transgressions – it is by grace you have been saved. And God raised us up with Christ and seated us with him in the heavenly realms in Christ Jesus, in order that in the coming ages he might show the incomparable riches of his grace, expressed in his kindness to us in Christ Jesus.

EPHESIANS 2:4-7

WEEK 3 DAY 2

WEEK THEME:
Transformed by Grace

DAY THEME:
Grace Makes Us Alive

What does it mean to you to be alive? What at first may appear to be a simple question is, when we think about it, actually a very difficult one. Of course, there is the biological definition of being able to breathe and having your heart pumping blood around your body. But while those things may mean you are not dead, do they truly define being alive? To be alive means something much deeper. Maybe those moments when you sit out in the desert at night looking up at the stars or sitting in front of a fire cuddled up with the one you love. Is it those times after dinner with friends, sitting around and talking into the early hours or listening to a beautiful piece of music? Or is it the feelings of love that your child stirs up inside of you? When Paul says that we have now been made alive with Christ, he is not talking about biological or even emotional life, like we described above, but spiritual life.

> *But because of his great love for us, God, who is rich in mercy, made us alive with Christ even when we were dead in transgressions.*
> Ephesians 2:4

Paul, in one sentence, perfectly sums up the whole of the gospel message. You see, outside of God's grace, every one of us is dead. Well, not physically dead right at this moment but certainly spiritually dead. What causes this spiritual death? We see a clue in the verse above: "we were dead in transgressions." Spiritual death is caused by transgressing the law of God. Paul, writing to the church in Rome, explains the correlation between our sinfulness and our predicament when he says that "the wages of sin is death." Because every one of us has inherited a corrupt nature, we each have a death sentence hanging over us – but thankfully that is not the end of the story. For while we were still in this state, unable to do anything about it, God made a way.

> *But God demonstrates his own love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.*
> Romans 5:8

God's love opened up another way for us. All of us who are on the road that ends in death have been confronted by God's amazing grace and marvelously have the opportunity to choose life. Truly we deserve death, as the Bible says – that is the wage of our sin – but the same verse gives us the wonderful news that, as opposed to wages, God's gift to mankind is eternal life. When we receive what is freely offered through Christ, we are made alive and given a new heart. This is how comprehensive our new birth is – Paul writes of us being a new creation. While this may sound like an exaggeration, it is simply the reality of what takes place in that moment of salvation. It is all the more amazing, because there was nothing in us that merited Christ's death in our place – that is what grace is. As Paul puts it to the church of Collosea:

> *When you were dead in your sins and in the uncircumcision of your flesh, God made you alive with Christ. He forgave us all our sins, having cancelled the charge of our legal indebtedness, which stood against us and condemned us; he has taken it away, nailing it to the cross. And having disarmed the powers and authorities, he made a public spectacle of them, triumphing over them by the cross.*
> Colossians 2:13-15

The new life that Jesus promises us isn't just another version of what we are currently experiencing. It is, in fact, a more vivid, full, and abundant life then we could ever imagine. In John's gospel when Jesus is talking about being the

"good shepherd," he goes on to compare the difference between what the devil offers and what he alone can bring.

> *The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy; I have come that they may have life, and have it to the full.* John 10:10

The things of this world will only lead us to death; the life that Jesus offers us brings us joy and wholeness. One of the keys to being a mature Christian is to grasp the truly stupendous reality of God's grace. You were once dead but now you are alive. Nothing more profound will ever happen to you. The real challenge for any disciple of Christ is not just to understand this truth at an intellectual level but to allow it to ripple out into every part of your life. Every day you should be living your life as if you were someone who was previously on death row who has now received a full pardon and been set free. Only those who truly understand the reality of the death sentence that was over them can truly appreciate the gift of life they now have.

One of the ways this is lived out is through the act of water baptism. Baptism is the public declaration that we are placing our trust in God's saving grace alone. As we are immersed into the water, we demonstrate that we have died and been buried with our sin, but then as we rise up out of the water, we show to the world that we have been united with Christ's resurrection power, triumphing in him over sin and death.

Jesus commands all who believe in him to be baptized. In the same way that we have to make a faith choice to receive our salvation, we believe that we must make a personal choice of obedience to be baptized. This is not a decision that someone else (such as a parent) can make on our behalf.

Reflection Questions:

1. What does this new life in Jesus look like for you?

2. What are the things in your "former life" that you need to leave behind?

3. What are some of the things that hold you back from experiencing the full life that Jesus has made available to you?

Challenge:

If you haven't been baptized yet but have put your trust in God's saving grace, don't wait any longer to be baptized. This would be a great thing to chat through with your mentor, Connect Leader or an elder.

For he himself is our peace, who has made the two groups one and has destroyed the barrier, the dividing wall of hostility, by setting aside in his flesh the law with its commands and regulations. His purpose was to create himself one new humanity out of the two, thus making peace, and in one body to reconcile both of them to God through the cross, by which he put to death their hostility. He came and preached peace to you who were far away and peace to those who were near. For through him, we both have access to the Father by one Spirit.

EPHESIANS 2:14-18

WEEK 3 DAY 3

WEEK THEME:
Transformed by Grace

DAY THEME:
Peace

MEMORY VERSE:
"He came and preached peace to you who were far away and peace to those who were near. For through him, we both have access to the Father by one Spirit."
EPHESIANS 2:17-18

Walls have played a crucial role throughout history. Over two thousand years ago, the first emperor of China, Qin Shi Huang, oversaw the completion of the Great Wall of China. Stretching from the Gobi desert all the way to Korea, it was designed to stop Mongolian raiding parties from attacking China. In 1961, through the center of Berlin, the Soviet-run German Democratic Republic erected a giant wall separating the Russian controlled parts in the East of the city from the West. For 28 years, this wall stood as a separation between the East and the West and many people died trying to cross over from one side of the wall to the other. Humanity has always been very good at erecting walls to separate different people groups based on race, religion, ethnicity, or politics.

Paul is keen to remind the Ephesians that these distinctions no longer exist because those who believe in Jesus have been transformed into a new humanity. This has happened because Jesus came to be our peace. In week 1, we explored the idea that we were alienated from God due to our sin – in salvation, we received forgiveness so that our "vertical" relationship with God was restored. Paul now examines the "horizontal" consequences of being justified – we become a new humanity.

Until this point of Jesus' coming, the Jewish people had sharply separated themselves from the other nations – the Gentiles. While Jews were indeed God's chosen people and had been singled out, they missed a vital aspect of their distinctiveness: God had chosen them as a nation to be a beacon to the rest of the world, a nation through which all of humanity would one day know God. The Jews were hardly alone in this divisiveness – from time immemorial people have divided themselves based on differences like skin color, culture, etc.

This hostility between the Jews and the Gentiles was highlighted in the way the Temple in Jerusalem was designed. As you journeyed deeper and deeper into the Temple, who could enter became more and more restrictive and culminated in the fact that only the high priest could enter the holy of holies (and even then, only once a year!) where God's glory dwelt. Gentiles were only allowed into the first court and, above the doorway leading further into the Temple, there was a stone which read:

No foreigner may enter within the balustrade around the sanctuary and the enclosure. Whoever is caught, on himself shall he put blame for the death which will ensue.

This is what Paul is referring to when he talks about the dividing wall of hostility; the literal wall that separated Jews and Gentiles. Through Jesus, we no longer see ourselves in separate categories; as Jews or Gentiles, black or white… instead, we are to recognize everyone as a child or potential child of God.

Even in the Church, we are all too quick to divide, too quick to draw distinctions rather than reflect the unity that results from seeing all believers as brothers and sisters. Of course, there is a place for disagreeing over significant theological differences, but too often church divisions result from traditions or practices. This was never what God intended for the Church. He has one bride, one church and all of us together are members of that one church because we share together a new humanity paid for and brought about by Jesus, our peace.

Reflection Questions:

1. Are the people in your life, who you spend time with, reflecting the diversity of God's kingdom or are they people just like you?

2. Who are the people you allow to remain behind a wall of hostility?

3. Do you find yourself discriminating against others for any reason?

Challenge:

If there have been times in your life where you have been discriminated against, ask the Holy Spirit to help you extend forgiveness today. Also ask him to break off any sense of inferiority the enemy may have put on you from those experiences.

Consequently, you are no longer foreigners and strangers, but fellow citizens with God's people and also members of his household, built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets, with Christ Jesus himself as the chief cornerstone. In him, the whole building is joined together and rises to become a holy temple in the Lord.

EPHESIANS 2:19-21

WEEK 3 DAY 4

WEEK THEME:
Transformed by Grace

DAY THEME:
Family

"God, knowing who we were and everything that we had done, still chose to bring us near."

The Christian walk is often described as a journey and, like any good journey, it transforms us and the way we look at the world. Once we become Christians, the treasures we sought before no longer seem as important as we seek to live our lives in a new way. This is particularly true in how we relate to and view each other.

Yesterday, we explored the work of Christ as our peace and now we see that Paul develops this thought further by exploring what it means for us to share in a new humanity. He gets straight to the point by saying "you are no longer foreigners and strangers, but fellow citizens." This is the language of belonging. God, knowing who we were and everything that we had done, still chose to bring us near. But more than that, we are also brought near to each other – fellow citizens of this new kingdom and members of God's household!

The Greek word used for "household" is oikeîos and can be translated as "related by blood." At its heart, it is about becoming a family and this means entering a place of great intimacy with each other. The intimacy flows out of our adoption as children of God. We are now part of his family and a family, by its very nature, is meant to be intimate. In the New Testament, the family of God finds expression as the local church. Again and again, the authors use the words "together'' and "one another" to describe the life lived in a vital community. Gathering is important and should not be taken lightly but some in the early church ignored this:

> *And let us consider how we may spur one another on toward love and good deed, not giving up meeting together, as some are in the habit of doing, but encouraging one another – and all the more as you see the Day approach.*
> Hebrew 10:24-25

We can easily fall into a trap of seeing our relationship with God as an individual concern, thinking we can survive just fine without anyone else. But this is utterly inconsistent with scripture which even compares the Church to a body with all the mutual dependencies that implies. We were created to be relational; we were saved to be family. When we gather together to worship and celebrate God, we are showing off the work of God's grace in putting us into a family. We must also recognize that this is an opportunity to "spur one another on" and to be "encouraging one another."

The family is a gift to be treasured and worth protecting. While we do not need to strive to be in family – it is a result of our change in status at the moment of salvation – we do need to make sure we treasure our spiritual family. Our spiritual family should be a priority in our lives, something we make time and space for, and something we pray for. The more we are prepared to invest ourselves, our time, treasures, and talents in this family and the more we do these things, the more we will feel a sense of belonging. While the change in spiritual status is instant when we come to Christ, the full manifestation of it takes a lifetime as we learn to see each other not as strangers and foreigners but as brothers and sisters in God's household.

Reflection Questions:

1. Do you see yourself as a part of God's family? If so, why? If not, why not?

2. How can you seek to foster a culture of community and family?

3. What are the things that hinder you from experiencing the fullness of God's family?

Challenge:

One of the best ways we can grow in our love and appreciation of God's family is to spend time praying for it. Set time aside today to pray for those who are a part of God's family that you may not normally connect with. As you do this, ask God to guide you on what to pray and ask if he has a word for them. Over the week, reach out to them and share with them God's word of encouragement.

In him, the whole building is joined together and rises to become a holy temple in the Lord. And in him, you too are being built together to become a dwelling in which God lives by his Spirit.

EPHESIANS 2:21-22

WEEK 3 DAY 5

WEEK THEME:
Transformed by Grace

DAY THEME:
Raised to Become a Holy Temple

Today's reading may have felt familiar and that's because it was covered back in week 2 day 4 – I think it is such an important scripture that it is worth revisiting it again today. Over the week, we have been exploring how God's grace transforms us and brings us into our new identity in Christ. Today, at the end of Ephesians chapter 2, Paul makes the most shocking statement. God, in all his holiness, chooses us to be the place he dwells through his Spirit. We who were once objects of God's wrath, who couldn't be near God because of our sin, have now become the vessels of God's Spirit. All of this is possible only because Jesus' blood washes us white as snow. God's grace makes it possible for us to be his dwelling place. This is radical – the result of this is that we become holy. Jesus, in Matthew chapter 5, tells the disciples that this is the goal for all believers.

> *You therefore must be perfect, as your heavenly Father is perfect.*
> Matthew 5:48

The word Jesus uses for perfect is a really interesting one. In the Greek, it is the word téleios which means "fully grown, finished, complete, or wanting nothing." As we have explored again and again throughout this week, our justification is a one time act that takes place at the moment of salvation. It is not based on our ability or virtue, but only on God. To say that God is holy is to refer to the wholeness, fullness, beauty, and abundant life that overflows within the Godhead. God lacks nothing – he is unbroken, undamaged, unfallen, utterly complete, and entire within himself. He is the indivisible One, wholly self-sufficient, and the picture of perfection.

When we look at it from a human perspective, how can we ever measure up to God's holiness or perfection? We can't – we know we are stained by our own sin and rebellion. But through Jesus' atoning sacrifice, we are now clothed in his righteousness and holiness, so much so that the Holy Spirit now resides in us. Dr Martin Lloyd-Jones put it this way:

Holiness is not something we are called upon to do in order that we may become something; it is something we are to do because of what we already are.

This, my friend, is the most amazing revelation: you have been made holy through your salvation and justification. This is what God has accomplished in you and now your job is to learn to live it out. This isn't something that you need to attain and strive to reach; rather, it is something that you can live out in keeping with your new identity. It's, like being a toddler learning to walk, an exciting adventure to explore and discover who you already are.

In John 15, Jesus uses the example of a grapevine. He says that he is the vine and we are the branches. In other words, we are already part of the grapevine; we don't have to try to become vines – we already are! Jesus then says that if we remain in him, and he in us, then we will bear much fruit. This is how we become true disciples (or followers) of Jesus. However, if we do not remain "in him" (i.e. the branch becomes detached from the vine), we will wither and be burnt.

Over the next few weeks, we'll be looking closer at the process of maturing as a follower of Jesus and what this entails. This is based on what we have explored so far – that when you received the free gift of salvation, you were born again and entered a new life with Jesus. This was only possible because of the substitutionary death and resurrection of Jesus Christ. Last week and this week, we explored the exciting implications of this, the truth that you are no longer the same guilty enslaved person that came to Jesus

and has to be settled before you start the next part of your journey. Remember the illustration from week 3 day 1: you have to allow the base layer of God's grace to dry before you start adding all the colors of the rest of your salvation to the painting of your life.

Reflection Questions:

1. Have you fully grasped the nature of your new identity and that, through salvation, you have been "born again" of the Spirit?

2. What difference does the fact that you are a new creation and viewed by God as being holy make for you? What will you now do in order to live your life differently?

3. Do you know the difference between living according to the flesh (your old self) and living by the Spirit (your new man)?

Challenge:

Spend some time this week working through the key aspects of your salvation and what justification means according to the Bible. If need be, discuss this with your mentor to get some more insight. Make sure you establish a solid foundation of understanding your identity before moving on. This week, spend some time thanking God for what your salvation means, and for what his freely given grace has done in your life.

As a prisoner for the Lord, then, I urge you to live a life worthy of the calling you have received.

EPHESIANS 4:1

WEEK 4 DAY 1

WEEK THEME:
Worthy of the Call

DAY THEME:
Called to be



MEMORY VERSE:
"As a prisoner for the Lord, then, I urge you to live a life worthy of the calling you have received."
EPHESIANS 4:1

Over the last three weeks, we have explored what it means to become a Christian. We explored how our salvation was accomplished for us on the cross and how our identity has been forever changed. For some Christians, their journey with God can end up stalling at this point. They wrongly believe that this journey is simply about getting a ticket into heaven; the rest of the time here on earth is simply a waiting room to the adventure of heaven. They could not be more wrong. God's transformative work carries on throughout our whole life as we are transformed more and more into the likeness of Jesus. This process is called sanctification, which simply means "becoming holy." The process of sanctification reaches into every part of our life. This week we will explore some of the practical ways God calls us to grow and be changed in him.

Sanctification isn't something we can do by ourselves. If we had the ability to make ourselves holy, then there would be no need for Jesus. The adventure of sanctification is a journey we take together with the Holy Spirit. As he works in our life and we surrender more and more to him, he does the work of transforming us. Over the next three weeks, we are going to examine what this collaboration between God and ourselves looks like and some of the areas in our lives that he calls us to surrender to him. This is an invitation to actually become what God has called us to be, chosen sons and daughters of the king. It is a slow and progressive work done by the Holy Spirit that each and every day involves choosing to allow him to do his work in us.

In today's reading, Paul challenges us to live a life worthy of the calling we have received. In the ESV, it says this:

> *I therefore, a prisoner for the Lord, urge you to walk in a manner worthy of the calling to which you have been called.*
> Ephesians 4:1 (ESV)

Paul links everything that he is about to go and share – in terms of how we live our lives and are transformed by the Holy Spirit – with the change in status and our identity that he had been exploring in the previous three chapters. The word "therefore" is critical as it shows that our journey of sanctification rests upon the completed work of our salvation and justification. There will always be a significant link between what you actually believe about yourself and how you end up living your life. If, through salvation, we truly have become new creations, how can we stay the same as we were before we met Jesus? The Bible tells us we need to allow the knowledge of our calling and our new identity to transform the way we view every area of our lives. The problem many of us face on a day to day basis is that we forget the first part. We focus so much on the doing that we fail to embrace the transformative power of identity and calling.

The process of sanctification flows out of a dynamic relationship between God and us. As God reveals our new identity to us, in greater and greater measure, we are challenged to live out that new identity. This is why Paul, writing to the Ephesians, urges them to "live a life worthy of the calling [they] have received," and that is the same challenge that we face today.

Are you prepared to journey with God through this process of sanctification, allowing him through his Holy Spirit to transform you into the likeness of his Son? It is not always going to be easy and will mean having to make difficult choices to leave behind the things that are not of God, reshaping your life, your character, and anything else that does not conform to his pattern of holiness. However, when we choose to partner with God, we are

opening ourselves up to the adventure of a lifetime as he takes us further and deeper into his kingdom than we could ever have imagined. This week, we explore the different areas that God is wanting to work in us and through us, to help us step into our new identity with him.

Reflection Questions:

1. How do you stay rooted in God's grace even as you strive for holiness?

2. What are the areas that God is working on in you at the moment?

3. What are the things in your life that hinder that process?

Challenge:

Today, spend time recommitting yourself to this journey you have started with God. Ask him to show you the areas that he is working on in your life. Once he has done that, recommit yourself to the process of actively working with God to be transformed more into the likeness of your Savior, Jesus.

As a prisoner for the Lord, then, I urge you to live a life worthy of the calling you have received. Be completely humble and gentle; be patient, bearing with one another in love. Make every effort to keep the unity of the Spirit through the bond of peace.

EPHESIANS 4:1-3

WEEK 4 DAY 2

WEEK THEME:
Worthy of the Call

DAY THEME:
Kingdom Attitude

"Is your life lived in a way that represents the gifts of grace that God has poured out on you?"

If someone was to watch your life for 24 hours, what kind of person would they see? In the movie The Truman Show, Truman Burbank (played by Jim Carrey) is part of the world's most-watched TV show but doesn't know it. His life is broadcast 24 hours a day for the whole world to see. His first steps as a child, first day of school, and first kiss are all shown on TV for everyone to watch. If the world was to be watching your life in the same way, what would they say about you? How do you conduct your life? Is your life lived in a way that represents the grace that God has poured out on you?

Paul picks up this idea when he challenges the Church in Ephesus to "live a life that is worthy of the calling we have received." But what does this actually look like and how do we go about it? Paul, maybe anticipating that question, goes on to list core elements of Christian maturity. The first of these is allowing our attitudes to be shaped by the kingdom.

> *Be completely humble and gentle; be patient, bearing with one another in love.*
> Ephesians 4:2

This wasn't an arbitrary list of Kingdom attitudes, rather the list was drawn from the personhood and lifestyle of Jesus.

Paul's instruction to cultivate these qualities is a challenge: anyone who watches us should increasingly see us growing in the same qualities in us as they would see in Jesus. For Paul, the idea of putting on the virtues and qualities of Jesus and taking off the things of this world was key. This is a part of the journey of sanctification – this putting on and putting off. At the heart of becoming more Christ-like is the idea that in every part of my life, the nature of Christ breaks through and is displayed to the world. It is worth noting that this isn't the only list of kingdom attitudes that Paul gives: look at Colossians 3:12, Galatians 5:22-23, and 1 Timothy 6:11 for more examples.

So if the goal is becoming more like Jesus, how do we get there?

> *You were taught, concerning your former way of life, to put off your old self, which is being corrupted by its deceitful desires; to be made new in the attitude of your minds; and to put on the new self, created to be like God in true righteousness and holiness.*
> Ephesians 4:22-24

For Paul, it is simple. We need to "die" to our old self and become "new" men and women by putting on Christ. This involves

taking off – choosing to reject the old ways and values that were previously a part of our lives – by the power of the Holy Spirit. Are you prepared today to reject pride, harshness, impatience, and disobedience? For only when we actively choose to discard those things do we open up space for God to transform our minds. While this may sound like hard work, the outcome is amazing and, as I said above, it is the Spirit who gives us the power to see it through. The promise is that we are being "created to be like God in true righteousness and holiness." Obviously this transformation also involves "putting on Christ" which is Paul's picture language for surrendering to God and believing what scripture says about our new condition.

It's at this point that we have to give a major warning: this putting off and putting on is not something that can be attained in our strength or by our works. You cannot one day just decide that you are going to be more humble or more patient. You may succeed for a while but after a few hours, days, or even weeks, the fallen flesh (which is still a part of us) will at some point, rebel and we will blow it. That's why sanctification is about partnering with God; it's about surrendering, not striving.

Reflection Questions:

1. What are the "kingdom attitudes" you find difficult to embrace in your life and why?

2. What are the "kingdom attitudes" you find easy to embrace in your life and why?

3. Today, what do you feel God is challenging you to "put on" and "put off?"

Challenge:

Spend some time in prayer, asking the Holy Spirit to highlight to you the areas of your life that are not displaying the nature or virtues of Christ. Once he has done that, work through these by praying and surrendering them to God and choosing to pick up the alternative displayed in Christ. For example, if you have a problem with rage, surrender it to God and ask him to stir up, in you, self control, and peace.

There is one body and one Spirit, just as you were called to one hope when you were called; one Lord, one faith, one baptism; one God and Father of all, who is over all and through all and in all.

EPHESIANS 4:4-6

WEEK 4 DAY 3

WEEK THEME:
Worthy of the Call

DAY THEME:
Kingdom Truths

MEMORY VERSE:
"Then you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free."
JOHN 8:32

According to the Barna report that looks at faith in America, an estimated 74 percent strongly agreed that "there is only one true God, who is holy and perfect, and who created the world and rules it today." Yet, remarkably, an estimated 65 percent either strongly agree or somewhat agree with the assertion that "there is no such thing as absolute truth." We live in a world where truth is increasingly becoming a relative concept. A world where people are encouraged to arrive at what is "true" for them. Scripture, however, takes a very different approach, asserting that certain things are universally true regardless of our nature or what a person may or may not feel.

Paul was possibly borrowing from an early 1st Century hymn when setting out these kingdom truths. These are the tenets that united all Christians, regardless of race or background, and they are the key marker points of truth – a litmus test if you will – for the Christian faith today. Maturity in the faith is not the ability to recite these truths, but the ability to understand, embrace, and apply them to every part of our lives. When we allow them to penetrate every part of who we are and how we live, we can rest assured our lives are based on God's eternal truth alone.

Paul doesn't pull any punches when he lays out the core "kingdom truths" that ought to unite all who call themselves Christians.

There is:

one body and
one Spirit, just as you were called to
one hope when you were called;
one Lord,
one faith,
one baptism;
one God and Father of all, who is over all and through all and in all.

For Paul, the one body is the body of Christ, the universal Church that we are a part of, meaning we are united together both with Christ and with each other – this is done through the work of the Holy Spirit. It is the one Spirit that forms the body, that knits us together as both a local community within a local church, and also unites us together as God's global Church. Not only does the Spirit unite us, but he also places in our heart the hope of Christ's return. The hope that God's kingdom is being built around us and will one day be complete. Paul then reminds us that there is one Lord, Jesus. This is the central truth for all Christian unity, that regardless of what divides us – Jew or Gentile, slave or free, man or woman – together we share in the same faith founded on Jesus. This one faith means we participate in one baptism and declare there is only one God.

While this list from Ephesians is a summary, at its heart it contains all the marker points to which we should come into full agreement as we mature in Christ.

The challenge for us is to apply these truths to our lives. First and foremost, we need to ask ourselves: "do I believe all these statements?" We must affirm them and reject all competing "truths." Truth in our world has become relative, in part because people have conflated truth with opinion so what may be true for me isn't necessarily true for you. The question of truth is one of the great battles of our age and, unfortunately, even believers are ensnared when they turn their backs on the clear truth revealed in scripture. Paul warns the early Church again and again how dangerous this is:

> *Keep reminding God's people of these things. Warn them before God against quarrelling about words; it is of no value, and only ruins those who listen. Do your best to present yourself to God as one approved, a worker who does not need to be ashamed and who*

> *correctly handles the word of truth. Avoid godless chatter, because those who indulge in it will become more and more ungodly. Their teaching will spread like gangrene. Among them are Hymenaeus and Philetus, who have departed from the truth. They say that the resurrection has already taken place, and they destroy the faith of some. Nevertheless, God's solid foundation stands firm, sealed with this inscription: "The Lord knows those who are his," and, "Everyone who confesses the name of the Lord must turn away from wickedness."*
> 2 Timothy 2:14-19

Even at the very beginning of the Church, false teachers emerged perverting the truth of God. Paul is writing to Timothy to encourage him to stand firm on the "solid foundations" of what he has been taught. Today, we may not need to worry about Hymenaeus and Philetus, but their "gangrenous" false teaching persists, albeit in other forms. The greatest safeguard against the counterfeit is to recognize the real – the greatest safeguard against false teaching is to plant the truth in your heart. We need to acknowledge God as the author of truth, aligning ourselves to kingdom truths that bring life, produce fruit, draw us closer to God, and transform us increasingly into the likeness of Christ.

Reflection Questions:

1. How does absolute truth shape the way you live? How does it shape your decisions?

2. What does it mean to live in unity with other Christians?

3. How can you plant the truth in your heart?

Challenge:

Commit yourself every day this week to upholding the truth. Surrender your words and deeds to Christ at the beginning of the day and prayerfully examine your actions at the end of the day. Ask the Holy Spirit to strengthen and convict you when you are tempted to falter.

Then we will no longer be infants, tossed back and forth by the waves, and blown here and there by every wind of teaching and by the cunning and craftiness of people in their deceitful scheming. Instead, speaking the truth in love, we will grow to become in every respect the mature body of him who is the head, that is, Christ. From him the whole body, joined and held together by every supporting ligament, grows and builds itself up in love, as each part does its work.

EPHESIANS 4:14-16

WEEK 4 DAY 4

WEEK THEME:
Worthy of the Call

DAY THEME:
Kingdom Roles

I don't know about you, but I am not much of a gardener. Luckily, in my adult life, I haven't lived anywhere that I've had to tend to more than a little grass and at times, even that has seemed like a challenge. My grandparents, however, were avid gardeners and I remember as a child going to visit them and being in awe of the beauty of their pristine gardens and rows upon rows of vegetables and fruits. My favorite was the raspberry bushes – not because they were particularly lovely – but because I loved raspberry pie. I remember my grandmother once told me about growing raspberries. She said that if you wanted to plant raspberry bushes, the first thing you needed to do was dig in and erect several bamboo canes. As the bushes grow, they wrap around the bamboo cane and use it for support. The more it grows and the more fruit it produces, the more it needs the support to stop it from collapsing.

This principle also applies to us as we grow more like Christ – we need support. God helps us by bringing people around us who can guide and speak into our lives. The ultimate gardener of our souls is Christ – he is the one who plants us and waters us. We were not called to walk our Christian life alone; God has placed people in our life to help guide and support our growth.

> *So Christ himself gave the apostles, the prophets, the evangelists, the pastors and teachers to equip his people for works of service, so that the body of Christ may be built up until we all reach unity in the faith and in the knowledge of the Son of God and become mature, attaining to the whole measure of the fullness of Christ.*
> Ephesians 4:11-13

One of the ways that God has gifted us with people who will help us grow and mature is the local church. Here, through the leaders and other saints, God has placed people who will come alongside us and challenge us as we are transformed through the work of the Holy Spirit in our day to day lives. Like any help though, we must be willing to accept and embrace it. This means embracing the opportunities that come our way. Whether it is the regular gathering of believers together for worship and preaching, small groups, prayer meetings, or meeting up one on one with those in the Church, these are all opportunities and gifts given by God in the support of our growth.

The goal of sanctification is always to become more like Jesus – to be transformed not just into his likeness, but to take on his passion for reaching out into the world. But in order to do this we must first be built up in him. A few days ago we looked at the kingdom attitudes we are called to embrace and we made the point that these are kingdom attitudes precisely because they are displayed by Christ. The same concept applies to these roles: Christ is the ultimate apostle, prophet, evangelist, pastor, and teacher. So when we allow these gifts to minister in our lives, we are allowing Christ to speak to us. We have something to learn from and grow in with each one of these gifts. When we ignore them, we are cutting off the support structure that Christ has ordained for our Christian maturity.

Paul warns new and long time believers who lack maturity that it is all too easy to latch on to the "new thing" that appears within the Christian world. When we do that however, we can find ourselves on a slippery slope moving beyond orthodoxy and the truth of God revealed to us. We can end up with a faith that is built on "God plus" (God + good works or God + earthly worship)…you get the idea.

The way we avoid this is by allowing the kingdom gifts he has sent his church to lead, teach, and, at times, correct us.

Reflection Questions:

1. How do you know that you are growing in Christlikeness?

2. How can we support others in their walk with God?

3. What kind of service are we being equipped for?

Challenge:

Dedicate this week to seeking out what areas of growth are most needed in your life. Ask the Holy Spirit to reveal these to you in prayer and ask some trusted people in your life to hold you accountable to your growth.

So I tell you this, and insist on it in the Lord, that you must no longer live as the Gentiles do, in the futility of their thinking. That, however, is not the way of life you learned when you heard about Christ and were taught in him in accordance with the truth that is in Jesus. You were taught, with regard to your former way of life, to put off your old self, which is being corrupted by its deceitful desires; to be made new in the attitude of your minds; and to put on the new self, created to be like God in true righteousness and holiness.

EPHESIANS 4:17, 20-24

WEEK 4 DAY 5

WEEK THEME:
Worthy of the Call

DAY THEME:
Kingdom Actions

This past week we have explored the transformative work of Christ in our lives. We have seen that as we submit every part of our lives to him, he comes to work in us, by the Spirit, to make us more like himself. That work may relate to our attitude or character, what we believe, or just generally coming into kingdom maturity – as we have seen, every area of our life must be surrendered to the Holy Spirit. This can be a difficult task at times but God has given us people who walk alongside us in the journey.

Central to everything we have looked at over this week is the idea that this work of sanctification the Spirit has started in you, and with whom you co-labor, must manifest in change, transforming the way you live your life. In our reading today, we can see just how explicit Paul is about this.

> *So I tell you this, and insist on it in the Lord, that you must no longer live as the Gentiles do, in the futility of their thinking.*
> Ephesians 4:17

This isn't one of those texts which is ambiguous or where we need an understanding of the ancient Greek. Paul is insisting that we must no longer live our lives like the world around us does. In writing to the Church in Rome, he puts it like this:

> *So here's what I want you to do, God helping you: Take your everyday, ordinary life –your sleeping, eating, going-to-work, and walking-around life – and place it before God as an offering. Embracing what God does for you is the best thing you can do for him. Don't become so well-adjusted to your culture that you fit into it without even thinking. Instead, fix your attention on God. You'll be changed from the inside out. Readily recognize what he wants from you, and quickly respond to it. Unlike the culture around you, always dragging you down to its level of immaturity, God brings the best out of you, develops well-formed maturity in you.*
> Romans 12:1-2 (The Message)

I love how Eugene Peterson paraphrases it: "don't become so well-adjusted to your culture that you fit into it without even thinking." This is the same warning that Paul was giving to those in the Church in Ephesus: you should no longer live like the culture around you. Ephesian society was in a time of significant social, moral, and civil decay, and Paul insists this pattern should not be mirrored in the lives of the believer.

To continue growing in maturity, there needs to be an active putting off of our old selves and putting on of our new selves. To put it another way, it is throwing off the things that will hinder you from living a life worthy of the calling you have received.

When we are saved, not only is our identity changed but we are also commanded to count ourselves dead to our old nature, and then to embrace the new work of creation that God has started in us. What all this language points to is that we have to make an active choice day after day to leave the old life (our desires, passions, and ways of thinking) behind and embrace what God is doing in us. If you struggle with stealing, then do something good with your hands; if you are prone to gossip, then speak to one another in words of affirmation. While the power to change comes from God, our active surrender / participation is a critical part. Paul encourages us with really practical examples of what this looks like. When you read the Gospels, one of the most striking things is that Jesus is inviting people to follow him…he leaves the

decision to them! He never pushes his will on people or coerces them to do anything against their will – he simply invites them. This remains true today! Everything we have looked at this week is an invitation from God for you to partner with him so that he can transform you into the likeness of Jesus. The most important step is your willingness to allow him to do that. While the maturing process is not always easy, God will be with you every step of the way, encouraging and empowering you.

Reflection Questions:

1. In what ways are you still living in allegiance to your old way of life?

2. What is hindering you from wholeheartedly pursuing God?

3. How do you actively put off your old self?

Challenge:

Ask the Holy Spirit to show you what patterns of the world you've been following and then surrender them as they are revealed. Set new habits, informed by the kingdom values we've been exploring, and invite the Holy Spirit to be the agent of change in these areas.

Do not get drunk on wine,
which leads to debauchery.
Instead, be filled with the Spirit,
speaking to one another with
psalms, hymns, and songs from
the Spirit. Sing and make music
from your heart to the Lord,
always giving thanks to God
the Father for everything, in the
name of our Lord Jesus Christ.

EPHESIANS 5:18-20

WEEK 5 DAY 1

WEEK THEME:
Practical Spirit-Filled Living

DAY THEME:
Practical Wisdom



MEMORY VERSE:

"Be very careful, then, how you live – not as unwise but as wise, making the most of every opportunity, because the days are evil. Therefore do not be foolish, but understand what the Lord's will is."

EPHESIANS 5:15-17

Last week we explored the practical ramifications of our new identity in Christ. As we saw, there is a daily call to put off the things from the world and to put on the things of Christ. As we do this, empowered by the Holy Spirit, we are transformed into the likeness of Jesus. This week we will explore not just how this affects how we choose to live and interact with the world around us, but also how it impacts our relationships.

One of the greatest roadblocks most Christians face when it comes to growing in maturity is a wrong perspective of what "Spirit-filled living" actually looks like. Too often we simply associate it with being able to exercise the gifts of the Spirit, such as the ability to prophesy or perform miracles. While this is a wonderful blessing available to all, if we limit Spirit-filled living to simply that we miss the great gift that the Holy Spirit is to us as he works in our lives and empowers us to share the gospel. Every single one of us is called to live every aspect of our walk or life empowered and surrendered to the Holy Spirit.

Recall Paul's opening words that we are to be very careful, then, how we live – not as unwise but as wise, making the most of every opportunity. We need to examine our lives and evaluate how we are living: are our attitudes and actions consistent with God's will? This isn't something that happens to us like being justified when we come to Christ. Instead, Paul is calling us to choose each day to live a God honoring life. This is highlighted by the challenge that we are to "understand what the Lord's will is."

One of the traps many of us fall into is to become saved but then to go back to living our lives like before. When we don't allow our new identity, that comes from being in Jesus, to transform our actions, we can get stuck in a rut, failing to grow and quickly finding ourselves in a situation where we have extinguished the flame of passion for Jesus that we once had. So what does living out our identity practically look like?

1) We need to seek God's will about how we should live.

2) We need to cooperate with the Holy Spirit to live that out.

Paul often gives us very practical examples of what this should look like. In this instance, he uses the example of drinking alcohol.

> *Do not get drunk on wine, which leads to debauchery. Instead, be filled with the Spirit.*
> Ephesians 5:17

So the will of God in the area of alcohol is that we are not to be people who get drunk. So now that we know what God's will is on the matter, how do we live this out? Paul tells us that instead of getting drunk, we need to be people who are filled with the Spirit – this is the solution to the problem. For every area of our lives, we need to seek God's will and then ask his Spirit to help us live this out. We can do this in several different ways. The first and most important way is studying God's word to us, the Bible. On top of this, through the Holy Spirit and people he has placed around us, we can discover what God's will is on any given topic. The important thing to bear in mind though is the Holy Spirit or people's guidance should never contradict what we see in scripture but simply explain and apply what God has already laid out for us. The writers of The Expositor's Bible Commentary sum this up by saying:

"Living as children of the light calls for determined efforts by people who came out of the darkness into the light. Though believers have entered a new life in

Christ, they must work hard to jettison the former ways of darkness that cling so readily – and may still afflict some in the Church. Likewise, they need to be just as diligent in implementing the new behaviors and attitudes found in Christ. The pattern to follow is that of God himself, exemplified in Christ's sacrificial love for his people."

The call then is for us to take the actions necessary to "become what we are." You ARE a son or a daughter of the King, a child of the God of the universe. Is your life a reflection of that? Do you walk out your identity or are you still clinging on to patterns of behavior from your past? The only way to make the transition and live this out is to be empowered by the Holy Spirit.

Reflection Questions:

1. How can we seek God's will?

2. At the moment, what areas in your life are you needing to find out God's will?

3. What other examples are there in the Bible of how we should live?

Challenge:

Identify a specific area in your life that you are not walking in God's will and ways. This week, with the help of the Holy Spirit, actively make decisions, one by one, that reinforce his best for your life and are obedient to his ways.

Husbands, love your wives, just as Christ loved the Church and gave himself up for her to make her holy, cleansing her by the washing with water through the word, and to present her to himself as a radiant Church, without stain or wrinkle or any other blemish, but holy and blameless. In this same way, husbands ought to love their wives as their own bodies. He who loves his wife loves himself. After all, no one ever hated their own body, but they feed and care for their body, just as Christ does the Church – for we are members of his body. "For this reason a man will leave his father and mother and be united to his wife, and the two will become one flesh." This is a profound mystery – but I am talking about Christ and the Church. However, each one of you also must love his wife as he loves himself, and the wife must respect her husband.

EPHESIANS 5:25-33

WEEK 5 DAY 2

WEEK THEME:
Practical Spirit-Filled Living

DAY THEME:
Husbands & Wives (Part 1)

There was a couple that asked a pastor if he would perform their marriage ceremony and he proceeded to tell them that he likes to have several sessions of premarital counselling before performing weddings. They replied "we don't need counselling. We've both been married several times before." While this may be a joke, there is a sad truth revealed in it. For Paul, if there was anywhere that "Spirit-filled living" needed to make a difference, it was in the realm of personal relationships. The challenge was to "understand the will of God" in each of these relationships and then to apply it by the Spirit.

Paul lays out three examples of changed relationships – marriage, parent and child, and slave and master. In the first century, each of these three sets of relationships had one party that was dominant over the other. Yet, now in Christ, the role and responsibilities are to be guided, not by the wisdom of the world, but by the example found in God. Christ must affect not just who we are and how we act but, even more significantly, how we relate to each other.

Today and tomorrow we are going to explore what this looks like within the context of marriage. Now while every one of you reading this will be at different stages of your life, some married, some single, some remarried, and some divorced or widowed, there is still profound truth for everyone so please don't just skip over these days. Leadership and submission, as well as love and respect, are aspects of most relationships at some level so it is important to all of us. We will be looking at the text backwards, examining the role of the husband first and then tomorrow considering the role of the wife. What is important to remember is that while each role is born out of the context of the other, it is not dependent on it. Paul is quick to remind us that these are to be understood in terms of duties to one another rather than our rights. All godly personal relationships are not to be about "what I can get" or "how I can benefit," but "what can I give" and "how can I serve?" This is the example, after all, that we see in Jesus.

In Ephesians 5:25, Paul uses an interesting word for love when he tells husbands to love their wives just as Christ loved the Church. You may know that throughout the Bible there are different words in Greek for "love." There is eros which means "passionate or physical love," and phileō which means "brotherly or family love." Here, however, Paul chooses to use the world agapáō – this word for love is often used in the New Testament to describe the love that God has for his people. It is sacrificial love, a love that puts the needs of others first, regardless of the cost. It is the same word used when Paul describes the love Jesus had for us when he chose the cross. Agapáō is costly love and yet this is the word that Paul wants to use when describing the love that a husband is to have for his wife.

Paul then takes it a step further, not only does he use this word agapáō, but he then directly links the love that the husband should have for his wife to the love that Christ has for us, his Church. This analogy is the foundational context for marriage and it is from here that the other roles and duties flow – which is critical to recognize if we are to properly understand Paul's instruction that "the husband is the head of the wife."

Throughout scripture, we see a pattern of God ordering human relationships around the concept of guarding and sacrificially serving others so that order can be protected. Nowhere is this more evident than in the dynamics of the local church. God lays out the roles of elders,

deacons, and saints with the express purpose of seeing order and leadership within the Church – and likewise is this pattern established within the confines of marriage. God has created order and leadership so that chaos does not rule. Paul reminds his readers that God has created the husband to be the leader or head in the marriage. Like any leader though, the purpose is to guard and protect the well-being of the other; it is not for their own advantage. This is why Paul draws a parallel between the husband and wife, and Christ and the Church. Christ is the head of the Church, yet he serves and guards the Church's well-being, and this is the model of what biblical headship should always look like within marriage.

Reflection Questions:

1. How should a husband handle conflict / disagreements in his marriage?

2. What does it mean to lead with sacrificial love?

3. How have unbiblical marriages you have seen in your life affected the way you see marriage?

Challenge:

Spend time praying over your marriage or the marriages of those you care about. If you are a married man, ask the Holy Spirit to show you where you are not walking in God's purpose and plan as a husband. If you have struggled in the past with sacrificially living out your love for your wife, ask the Holy Spirit to change your heart. Allow him to empower you, this week and beyond, as you cooperate with the Holy Spirit in practical expressions of practical love. As the Spirit leads you, write down some of these practical expressions and check back with this list at the end of the week.

Submit to one another out of reverence for Christ. Wives, submit yourselves to your own husbands as you do to the Lord. For the husband is the head of the wife as Christ is the head of the Church, his body, of which he is the Savior. Now as the Church submits to Christ, so also wives should submit to their husbands in everything.

EPHESIANS 5:22-24

WEEK 5 DAY 3

WEEK THEME:
Practical Spirit-Filled Living

DAY THEME:
Husbands & Wives (Part 2)

MEMORY VERSE:
"However, each one of you also must love his wife as he loves himself, and the wife must respect her husband."
EPHESIANS 5:33

Yesterday, we examined the role of the husband within the context of marriage. At the heart of what we saw was this idea that Christ needs to have an impact on every part of our lives, including our relationships. This is exemplified in the challenge Paul gives the husband to be one who leads and guides his wife with costly, sacrificial love, following the model of Christ's love for the Church.

Today, we explore the role of the wife. First, it is important to point out that, scripturally, the wife – and, for that matter, women – are equal to men in their standing before Christ. In his letter to the Church in Galatia, Paul goes to great lengths to point out that all Christians, regardless of race, gender, or social standing, are spiritually equal in Christ and have equal access to God.

> *So in Christ Jesus, you are all children of God through faith, for all of you who were baptized into Christ have clothed yourselves with Christ. There is neither Jew nor Gentile, neither slave nor free, nor is there male and female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus.*
> Galatians 3:26-28

The collective term for the group of people referred to in this text is "the Church." As the Church, we are seen as one by Christ. All have sinned and fallen short of God, all need salvation which can only be obtained through Christ, and all who choose to believe in Jesus have access to the promise of becoming a son of God. There is nothing that marks us out when it comes to the gospel and nothing that gives one group an advantage or disadvantage when it comes to being children of God. This would have been revolutionary at the time – no other religion or political system held up the dignity and equality of womanhood like this. But (and this is an important but), we do have different roles to play. This is part of what Paul is reminding the Church in Ephesus when he is teaching about husbands and wives. While we are equal in Christ, our roles and the way we relate to each other are different, though Paul's first instruction in all interpersonal relationships is to be in a relationship of mutual submission (vs. 21).

According to Paul, the role of the wife toward her husband is marked by two key attributes:

1) Submission
2) Respect

In today's culture, the word submission has almost become a dirty word but as Christians, we must reclaim this word and display what it is meant to look like to the world. In the Greek, the root for the word "submit" is made up of two words, hypo and tássō It takes its use from within a military context where one would be under the appointed leadership of a general or army captain. The idea is that the military leader would set the course or strategy and then the soldiers would help to make this happen. This is similar to how submission is to function within marriage – the husband is to set the vision or direction,and then the wife helps to make this happen. John Piper puts it like this:

Submission is the defined calling of a wife to honor and affirm her husband's leadership, and so help to carry it through according to her gifts.

The second of these then is respect. Submission without respect simply becomes obedience, but submission with respect becomes a desire to work together to achieve what God has called you together to accomplish. Submission becomes the action and respect becomes the attitude. As we are transformed by Christ, we realize that he works not just

on our actions, but also our attitude which ensures lasting change.

We can see that seeking God's will for marriage means raising the bar drastically for both the husband and the wife regarding the role they are to play. At the heart of both is a desire to mirror the relationship of the Church and Christ, with love at the center of everything.

We are still called to live out the role that God has given us, regardless of whether our spouse is living out their God-given role in marriage. For some, this is a great challenge and will need greater dependence on the Holy Spirit.

Reflection Questions:

1. What is the practical difference between submission and obedience?

2. How does this play out in marital decision-making?

3. Are there areas in your marriage that you are waiting for your spouse to "fulfil their role" before you fulfil yours?

Challenge:

Spend some time prayerfully examining your marriage and asking the Holy Spirit to reveal areas that you are not walking in and living out the key attributes. If you have struggled in this area in the past, give the Holy Spirit permission to change your heart. Allow the Spirit to empower you, this week and beyond, as you cooperate with him in practical expressions of joyful submission. As the Spirit leads you, write down some practical ways you may express respect and submission and check back with this list at the end of the week.

Children, obey your parents in the Lord, for this is right. "Honor your father and mother" – which is the first commandment with a promise – "so that it may go well with you and that you may enjoy long life on the earth." Fathers, do not exasperate your children; instead, bring them up in the training and instruction of the Lord.

EPHESIANS 6:1-4

WEEK 5 DAY 4

WEEK THEME:
Practical Spirit-Filled Living

DAY THEME:
Parents & Children

In our quest to allow Christ to transform every area of our lives, we turn to an important part of any community: the parent-child relationships. While not every one of us is or will be parents, we are all someone's child. Importantly also, the way that we relate to God, as a loving parent who must be obeyed, is deeply impacted by our own family life. The way that our mothers and fathers loved and disciplined us will impact how we see the heavenly Father and how we react to his love, leadership, and discipline.

Of course, being a part of a family brings us face to face with significant relational challenges and allowing Christ to transform our family dynamics can often be met with resistance rooted in our status quo or our culture. If you are facing that resistance, talk to your mentor about some of the excellent resources that are available to help fathers and mothers parent the way God wants us to through every stage of life. As we have seen with marriage, this alignment is simply part of living a Christ-imitating life which always brings the fruit of peace and joy.

In writing this instruction to children in today's scripture reading, Paul draws from the Ten Commandments found in Exodus 22. Within the Christian home, even young children can know in their simple way what it means to obey the Lord. Learning this at an early stage sets them up for the rest of their lives. While we are called children of God and have access through Jesus to the Father, this is not a democratic relationship of equals but one of hierarchy and obedience, framed in love and discipline. When this is learnt first in the home, through consistent, courageous and patient parenting, children have a biblical framework for relating to God that works.

The message to children is simple – obey your parents! The message to parents is just as simple – make sure they do! But this is not an easy task, and there is much more to this than robotic obedience from children to the whims of their parents. Raising children requires parents to walk the radical middle-road of training in obedience and responding to the need for children to enjoy greater and greater independence as they grow older. Paul's instruction is very apt:

> *Fathers, do not exasperate your children; instead, bring them up in the training and instruction of the Lord.*
> Ephesians 6:4

This is not an impossible task however. In the same way that the Holy Spirit must be a part of our marriage, he should also be a central part of our parenting. The Holy Spirit teaches us how to parent through the scriptures and the community of faith we are planted into. He teaches us that "loving our children" too much to discipline them or loving them more than we love God is a grave mistake. Having rules, and discipline to ensure they are followed, is a normal part of training in any area of life. To be Christ-like however, it should build only upon the foundation of unconditional love.

Tragically, parents can get this completely wrong: on the one hand they may "spoil" or coddle their children by allowing them to grow up without discipline, or endure any hardship; on the opposite extreme, they may be harsh and abusive, withholding the love and protection parenting should give. If you have grown up in a home where the parenting was damaging, please know that the Spirit can and wants to bring healing, and help you break destructive cycles.

One of the greatest obstacles many Christians have to overcome is the difficulty of seeing God being a father as a good thing. If your father (or mother)

failed to parent you in love, that can ripple out into every sphere of your life, from who you choose to date and marry, to what you think healthy masculinity and femininity looks like.

Obviously, the role of both the mother and father is vital, but Paul gives this instruction specifically to fathers because they bear the ultimate responsibility for how leadership will be exercised in the home. It's also no small matter, as we have already said, that God is our heavenly Father, and how our father directly impacts that relationship. Raising our children to know God as he actually is, is a sacred responsibility and one not to be taken lightly. On our own, we will fail more often than not, and this is why it is critical that we look to God the Father, as revealed in scripture, and seek to imitate him in the power of the Spirit. Only by doing this can we raise our children in the same way God relates to us.

As young children practice obedience to their parents, they practice the virtue and character that they are also called to display towards God – as they grow in one, they will grow also in the other. The same is true for us who are parents. When we seek to parent our children in the same way that God fathers us, not only do we raise children who will know and love God, but we also discover a deeper picture and understanding of what it means to be children of God.

Reflection Questions:

1. Do you have thoughts or feelings about your heavenly Father, shaped by your upbringing, that do not line up with what the Bible says about him?

2. Are there areas from your upbringing that do not align with what the Bible says about parenting – perhaps even areas where you need the Holy Spirit to heal past wounds?

3. If you are a mother or father, are there any adjustments that you need the Spirit to make to help you parent like God the Father?

Challenge:

If you have answered yes to any of the questions above, commit to talking to your mentor about them. Ask them to help you walk in forgiveness either towards those who have hurt you, or asking God to forgive you where you have failed to parent God's way.

Slaves, obey your earthly masters with respect and fear, and with sincerity of heart, just as you would obey Christ. Obey them not only to win their favor when their eye is on you, but as slaves of Christ, doing the will of God from your heart. Serve wholeheartedly, as if you were serving the Lord, not people, because you know that the Lord will reward each one for whatever good they do, whether they are slave or free.

And masters, treat your slaves in the same way. Do not threaten them, since you know that he who is both their Master and yours is in heaven, and there is no favoritism with him.

EPHESIANS 6:5-9

WEEK 5 DAY 5

WEEK THEME:
Practical Spirit-Filled Living

DAY THEME:
Masters & Slaves

"We are called to be people who are not defined by our work or our circumstances, but we are defined by who we are in Christ."

So far, this week, we have seen how Paul has been working his way through the family and redefining how these personal relationships should look for those saved by Christ. At the heart of every relationship is a change of perspective. We are now a new creation, empowered by his Spirit and, as such, we are called to live out our new wonderful identity! The last area he addresses in this section is that of slave and master. Now while none of us have slaves or are ourselves slaves, there is still a great deal that this text has to say to us – for many of us are either employer or employee, and just as he should in our household, Christ should reign and transform our work life.

Paul doesn't use this letter to address the question of slavery's legitimacy, in part because it was a common (accepted) practice in the first-century and in part because some of the slavery was more like indentured labor, an economic servitude. We need to be clear that elsewhere Paul emphatically states that slave traders will not inherit the kingdom of God, and we must also recognize that by revolutionizing the roles of economic master and servant, as he does here, Paul still lands a fatal blow to the idea that God endorses the practice of slavery. At the heart of it is an understanding that slaves are not property to own and control, but people whose dignity as humans created in the image of God is recognized, celebrated, and protected.

Paul's message confirms the idea that Jesus is truly the master of both the slave and the earthly master. Therefore, the way we act and conduct ourselves – regardless of our earthly position – is as mutual servants of Jesus. For the master then, Paul states that they are to be a slave to Jesus and to look to him for the example of what it looks like to be a master. At the very core of Jesus' character, both as master and king, is self-sacrificial love. Jesus rules by serving and loving others and, in the kingdom of God, this is the model for all those in power, whether husbands, fathers, or masters – they must rule through the medium of self-sacrificing love. This is the ultimate check and balance of power, for no one can be abusive when the dignity of those he / she rules over is put first. For those of you who are employers, this is the model for you to, if necessary, allow Christ to transform your business and how you treat your staff, where you put the dignity and humanity of others first. When we take the example of Jesus and ask his Spirit to empower our

living, then we see our lives coming into alignment with God's kingdom.

For slaves, Paul's instructions are simple:

> *Serve wholeheartedly, as if you were serving the Lord, not people, because you know that the Lord will reward each one for whatever good they do, whether they are slave or free.*
> Ephesians 6:7-8

The implication for us today is that it is not your boss you are serving but, in fact, Jesus. Now for many of us, we know this to be true. But when the rubber hits the road and we try to live it out, we find it's a different matter entirely. When your boss mistreats you, Jesus is your master. When your pay doesn't come in on time, Jesus is your master. When you are overlooked for that promotion, Jesus is your master. No matter the situation, Jesus is your master. When we choose to allow this truth to transform our thinking, our workplace suddenly becomes a vehicle for the gospel. For, ultimately, the reward we strive for is not to be found in this life, from human hands, but from Jesus. Now applying this mindset doesn't suddenly make everything easy or solve the issues you face but through the strength and empowering of the Spirit, you can endure all things. We are called to be people who are not defined by our work or our circumstances, but we are defined by who we are in Christ. This of course also means that where you are facing injustice in the workplace, your first and most important appeal should be to your ultimate "boss" - your master, and friend, Jesus.

The final and perhaps most important thing to bear in mind, whether you find yourself as an employer or employee, is that one is not contingent on the other – love doesn't work that way. We are called to perform these roles and functions in a manner that is worthy of Jesus regardless of whether the other party is or is not fulfilling "their role." This is what is so revolutionary about the gospel, for at the heart of it is putting others first.

Reflection Questions:

1. How can we practically live out these ideas in our workplaces?

2. What does servant-hearted leadership look like?

3. How can we lift up and celebrate the people around us?

Challenge:

This week, spend time in prayer asking the Holy Spirit to transform your heart to sacrificially love and serve those around you. Then practically put this into action by serving someone each day of the week.

Finally, be strong in the Lord and in his mighty power. Put on the full armor of God, so that you can take your stand against the devil's schemes. For our struggle is not against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the powers of this dark world and against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly realms.

EPHESIANS 6:10-12

WEEK 6 DAY 1

WEEK THEME:
Spiritual Warfare

DAY THEME:
Be Strong in the Lord



MEMORY VERSE:

"For our struggle is not against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the powers of this dark world and against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly realms."

EPHESIANS 6:12

In the Greek Orthodox tradition, the day after Easter is devoted to telling jokes. This is because telling a joke was an imitation of the cosmic joke that God pulled on Satan through the Resurrection. Satan thought he had won, and was smug in his victory, having had the last word when Jesus died on the cross – or so he thought. Then God raised Jesus from the dead, so that life and salvation became the last words. The more serious side of this Greek Orthodox tradition was to show the cosmic battle that had taken place between the kingdom of God and the dominion of darkness and that while the war has been won through Jesus' death and resurrection, the implications of this battle are still being worked out today. As Paul comes to the end of his letter to the Church in Ephesus, he devotes the last section to remind his readers of the reality of this spiritual battle. This week, we will explore how we are to live out the charge to "be strong in the Lord and in his mighty power" even when the battle rages around us.

Paul's first instruction is to be strong and he continues by exploring the idea of what Spirit-empowered living looks like. In the same way that it transforms our personal relationship, it strengthens us to take a stand against battles that often war around us. Paul is quick to point out that while it may seem like the battles we face are against people and situations, this is actually not the case. When you look behind the curtain, it is in fact spiritual (go back and read verse 12).

One of the greatest lies that the devil has told the world is that he doesn't exist. In the age of reason and enlightenment, the concept of spiritual evil and a personal devil has become very unfashionable. With the search for empirically testable scientific answers for everything, all "supernatural" ideas have been discarded. This approach means that we have lost an essential piece of truth about the spiritual dimension around us. Jesus, by contrast, treated the devil as a real, personal entity and enemy. In all three of the synoptic gospels we read about an encounter with the devil. In Matthew 4:1-11, we see that it was a real face-to-face encounter. This wasn't some ancient myth or metaphor for human evil, but a personal spiritual force. This is what Paul is talking about when he reminds his readers that their battle is against "the rulers, against the authorities, against the powers of this dark world and against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly realms."

In Matthew 4, we read about some of the tactics used by the devil in spiritual battle along with the tools we need to overcome such tactics. The devil tempts Jesus in three areas:

1) his personal needs / situation (verses 2-3)
2) his identity (verses 5-6)
3) his purpose / ministry (verses 8-9)

The tactics the devil used to try to tempt Jesus are the same he uses on us today. First, he will attack us based on our needs, whether they are physical, financial, or medical. Secondly, he will attack us based on our identity, trying to get us to question who we are, sowing doubt about our new identity as sons and daughters of the King. Lastly, he will attack us on our calling and sense of purpose in life. If he can cause us to stumble in any one of these areas, then he weakens our ability to be vessels for God's kingdom and to live in the freedom Christ won for us.

Paul was keenly aware of the battles that surrounded the lives of the believers – battles which continue to this day. While we know that Christ has won the victory, we should not downplay the seriousness of spiritual warfare that we face today. We will dive deeper into this idea tomorrow.

Reflection Questions:

1. How does the reality of spiritual warfare change the way you interact with the world?

2. What are some of the ways you have experienced a spiritual attack in your own life?

3. What difference does it make that Christ has already won the victory?

Challenge:

Identify the areas in which you are naturally more vulnerable to attack and actively pray against the lies of the enemy, calling them out by name. Half the battle is being able to call the enemy on his bluff and rebuking his tactics by proclaiming God's truth over the situation.

Therefore put on the full armor of God, so that when the day of evil comes, you may be able to stand your ground, and after you have done everything, to stand. Stand firm then, with the belt of truth buckled around your waist, with the breastplate of righteousness in place, and with your feet fitted with the readiness that comes from the gospel of peace.

EPHESIANS 6:13-15

WEEK 6 DAY 2

WEEK THEME:
Spiritual Warfare

DAY THEME:
Armor of God (Part 1)

Yesterday, we established that the battle we face as believers is not against "flesh and blood," but against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly realms. Paul instructs his readers to put on the "full armor of God" to be able to be victorious in the battle and goes into detail about the various pieces. Today and tomorrow, we will examine each of these pieces and look at what it means to "put on the full armor of God."

Belt of Truth

In the NIV, as well as most contemporary translations of the Bible, the Greek gets translated as "the belt of truth buckled around your waist," and while this translation makes sense in today's world, it misses some of what Paul is trying to teach us. The King James Version does a much better job, translating it as "having your loins girt about with truth." The girding of one's loins was the first thing someone would do when preparing for action. In Paul's time, both men and women would have worn long tunics which were impractical for moving quickly, and even less practical for battle. To prepare themselves to move or to fight, they needed to gird their loins.

As seen in the diagram to the right, girding the loins allowed the person to be in a state of readiness for what was about to come. Paul says that this is the first part of the armor of God. We need to allow the truth of God to prepare us so we are in a state of readiness. Lies and deceit will slow us down, making us unable to run or fight. The truth will always lead us to a place of freedom, where we are unrestricted and able to move in the will and means that God has for us in our lives.



1.
The tunic wouldn't allow you to do heavy labor or fight in battle, necessitating the "girding" of one's loins.



2.
First, hoist the tunic up so that all the fabric is ablove your knees. This will give you mobility.



3.
Gather all the extra material in front of you, so that the back of the tunic is snug against your backside.



4.
Once the excess fabric is gathered in front, pull it underneath and between your legs to your rear. This feels much like a diaper.



5.
Gather half of the material in each hand, bringing it back around to the front.



6.
Finally, tie your two handfuls of material together, and you're all set for both battle and some hard labor. Go forth, be ye men, and gird up your loins!

Breastplate of Righteousness

The breastplate is probably the most critical part of the armor that any soldier puts on. Again and again on TV and in films, we see police officers entering dangerous situations wearing Kevlar vests which, like the Roman breastplates, protect the most important part of the body, the lungs and the heart. A blow to the heart without a breastplate will often be fatal, and the same is true when it comes to the spiritual battles we find ourselves in. The righteousness of the Lord becomes our breastplate as it's the one thing which is able to fend off any spiritual blow or attack - such as accusation or questioning our identity while keeping our spirit and soul preserved. Our own righteousness or goodness will never be enough because often those accusations are true. That's

why, at the moment of salvation, we are issued with a breastplate of Christ's righteousness. Christ's righteousness brings with it a purity of heart that over time helps conform us into the likeness of Christ.

Sandals of the Gospel of Peace

Sandals may seem out of place when compared to the helmet or shield, but it's an important part of a soldier's gear. They provide sure footing that allows the soldier to fight. The gospel of peace is the foundation on which we stand as we engage in the spiritual battle that rages around us. Back in week 3, we looked at the gifts of grace and peace that are ours as a result of our new position in Christ. The gospel or good news is a message of peace; a message of hope that says we no longer need to live as enemies of God, or in a broken relationship with each other or the earth. Not only is the gospel the foundation on which we stand but it is also the greatest weapon we have in our spiritual battle against the dominion of darkness. The gospel proclamation brings the light (revelation and life) of God to individual lives and communities. So, as we prepare ourselves for the battle, we must make sure that we are always ready to share the gospel with those along our path.

Think about it for a moment – if you have accepted Jesus into your life, it is because someone took the time to share the gospel of peace with you. You are now a part of God's kingdom, because as Isaiah puts it:

> *How beautiful upon the mountains are the feet of him who brings good news, who publishes peace, who brings good news of happiness, who publishes salvation, who says to Zion, "Your God reigns."*
> Isaiah 52:7

Paul quotes this scripture in his letter to the Church in Rome to remind them of the importance of sharing the gospel - how can people be saved if they haven't heard the gospel preached to them? We now have the opportunity to be the one who wears the sandals of the gospel of peace and brings good news.

Reflection Questions:

1. How can we put on the armor of God?

2. In what way is Christ's righteousness protection against the enemy's attacks?

3. How can we make sure we're always ready to share the gospel?

Challenge:

Share the gospel with someone this week. Tell them the story of how you found new life in Christ – about the hope, peace, and purpose that you have found in him. Look back over week 1 to explore the steps to salvation.

In addition to all this, take up the shield of faith, with which you can extinguish all the flaming arrows of the evil one. Take the helmet of salvation and the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God.

EPHESIANS 6:16-17

WEEK 6 DAY 3

WEEK THEME:
Spiritual Warfare

DAY THEME:
Armor of God (Part 2)

MEMORY VERSE:
"Submit yourselves, then, to God. Resist the devil, and he will flee from you.
JAMES 4:7

Today, we continue to examine "the full armor of God," which Paul encourages us to put on to fight the spiritual battle which, as believers, we are engaged in until Christ returns.

Shield of Faith

For Paul's readers as soon as he mentions "shield," the image that would have come to mind was the large rectangular shield used by Roman soldiers. This shield, about the size of a man, helped to create a significant tactical advantage for the Romans against any oncoming enemies. It was large enough to protect those carrying it from a front-on attack, and could also be positioned against other shields to form a "box" protecting all sides and, including the top, against arrows. For this to happen, the soldiers must be part of a regiment and work as a team. The shield of faith works similarly. Our faith in God not only provides protection for us against the fiery darts of the enemy but when united with those around us, can provide protection for the whole group. Faith works like a muscle, the more we exercise it in different situations the more it develops and increases.

By the time David became king, he was well accustomed to war. In one of his later Psalms of praise, he declares that God alone is able to be the shield that can withstand the attack of the devil.

> *Praise be to the Lord my Rock, who trains my hands for war, my fingers for battle. He is my loving God and my fortress, my stronghold and my deliverer, my shield, in whom I take refuge, who subdues peoples under me.* Psalm 144:1-2

Faith is simply trust and reliance on God above all else. In our own strength, we can do nothing, but with God we can overcome any attack that may come our way.

Helmet of Salvation

Being on our head, the helmet speaks to the assurance of salvation. If the enemy can get us to believe lies about our standing with God or our eternal destination, we will lose confidence and be vulnerable in battle. The helmet of salvation reminds us of our true identity in Christ and the security that comes with that. It is important to remember that our security is a fact, but assurance is a feeling and that's why it must be protected.

The protection of our mind is an active choice. The more we choose to dwell and think about the things of God, the easier it becomes, when the whispers of the enemy cross our mind, to surrender them to God and move on. While it is God who transforms and renews our mind, it is up to us whether we feed it with lies from the world or truth from God.

Sword of the Spirit

Finally, Paul moves to the sword of the Spirit. Everything else we have looked at is primarily defensive; the sword not only allows the user to defend themselves, but it also can be used to attack and advance. It is important to realize that this is not our sword to brandish and fight with but is, in fact, the Holy Spirit's sword. Through the Holy Spirit, the word of God becomes a powerful weapon for tearing down and destroying the enemy. The author of Hebrews puts it like this:

> *For the word of God is alive and active. Sharper than any double-edged sword, it penetrates even to dividing soul and spirit, joints and marrow; it judges the thoughts and attitudes of the heart.* Hebrews 4:12

When used correctly, the sword of the Spirit can destroy all that comes against us. This was the weapon that Jesus used during his time of temptation in the desert and it is still the best tool we have at our disposal to fight off temptation

and to disarm the enemy. However, the responsibility lies with us to make sure we are arming ourselves with the word of God. This way whatever situation we may face, the Holy Spirit can bring to mind the right scripture to help us overcome.

As we have seen in each of the six pieces of the armor of God, while the responsibility we have is to make sure we put on and correctly use each of these pieces, it is God who fights the battle, protecting us from all that the devil may throw at us. Like the Roman soldier whose weapons Paul is referencing, we must also go through training, to learn how to carry and use each piece of armor. A soldier would train to such a point that when he was in battle, he would not have to think about his helmet or shield. He would be so accustomed to wearing them that they would simply feel like an extension of his body. He could rely on them to serve their purpose so he could defend himself and fight. So, too, must we get to the point where we are so in tune with our spiritual armor, and so used to wearing it, that when we face attack we can easily rely on its strength and use it to overcome the enemy. This should give us great peace, as well as the courage we need to step out and engage in the battle that rages around us. As Jesus puts it:

> *I have told you these things, so that in me you may have peace. In this world, you will have trouble. But take heart! I have overcome the world.*
> John 16:33

Reflection Questions:

1. Why is it important to have all six pieces of the armor of God?

2. What habits can you form to make this armor an extension of yourself?

3. Do you remember our deep dive into our new identity in Christ and its implications - well how can you continually keep that in your mind to serve as a helmet protecting you from the enemy's "identity attacks"?

Challenge:

Memorize the six pieces of the armor of God, and meditate on a verse for each one. Pray through them each day this week and ask the Holy Spirit to equip you with them.

And pray in the Spirit on all occasions with all kinds of prayers and requests. With this in mind, be alert and always keep on praying for all the Lord's people.

EPHESIANS 6:18

WEEK 6 DAY 4

WEEK THEME:
Spiritual Warfare

DAY THEME:
Spirit Led Prayer

"When we lose our sensitivity to the spiritual reality around us, we not only let our guard down but we also become ineffective in fighting the battle for those around us."

Dr. Helen Roseveare, a missionary to Congo, told the following story:

> *A mother at our mission station died after giving birth to a premature baby. We tried to improvise an incubator to keep the infant alive, but the only hot water bottle we had was beyond repair. So we asked the children to pray for the baby and her sister. One of the girls responded. 'Dear God, please send a hot water bottle today. Tomorrow will be too late because by then the baby will be dead. And dear Lord, send a doll for the sister so she won't feel so lonely.' That afternoon a large package arrived from England. The children watched eagerly as we opened it. Much to their surprise, under some clothing, was a hot water bottle! Immediately the girl who had prayed so earnestly started to dig deeper, exclaiming, 'If God sent that, I'm sure he also sent a doll!' And she was right! The heavenly Father knew in advance of that child's sincere requests, and five months earlier he had led a ladies' group to include both of those particular articles.*

As Paul now moves on from the armor of God, he draws this section to a close with a final instruction to "be alert."

There is a real sense that Paul is challenging his readers to live their lives permanently ready to do battle. Two of the most dangerous "spirits of the age" we must guard ourselves against is apathy and complacency. When we lose our sensitivity to the spiritual reality around us, we not only let our guard down but we also become ineffective in fighting the battle for those around us. Paul's challenge to "be alert" is directly linked to his instruction to "always keep on praying for all the Lord's people." Thankfully, we are not called to fight this battle alone – in this final section, Paul lays out the two support structures God has given us.

The first support that God has given us is other Christian believers. Paul instructs us that we must be praying for the rest of the Church and so, in turn, the rest of the Church is also praying for us. This mutuality in prayer is what strengthens the whole Church.

This is exactly what Dr. Helen Roseveare testified to. Because the church back in the UK was praying for her in the midst of her battle, it meant that the right solution was at hand. But how were these ladies able to anticipate what would be required five months earlier? They were

praying in the Spirit – this is the second support structure that God has given us.

Paul, writing to the Church in Rome, puts it like this:

> *In the same way, the Spirit helps us in our weakness. We do not know what we ought to pray for, but the Spirit himself intercedes for us through wordless groans. And he who searches our hearts knows the mind of the Spirit because the Spirit intercedes for God's people in accordance with the will of God.*
> Romans 8:26-27

Prayer without direction is simply noise. Paul is challenging us to enter into a much deeper reality when it comes to prayer – prayer guided by the Spirit. Now, to be clear, this takes place both through using the gift of tongues, as well as praying in our own native language. Both these kinds of prayers help us in different ways. Praying in tongues, for example, allows us to bypass our "reasoning" and pray from our spirit as we are led by the Holy Spirit. There will be times when we simply do not know what or how to pray but as we pray in tongues, we are led into divine intercession. This is why Paul encourages all believers to grow in this gift. At the heart of both types of prayer is us allowing ourselves to be led by the Spirit. This may mean responding and praying for a particular person or situation that comes to mind or as you pray, you may feel a leading to pray in a specific way. This is what the church in the UK was doing as they prayed for Dr. Roseveare – allowing the Spirit to lead them. This led them to inquire about what was needed and so God was able to orchestrate the response.

We must never forget about the battles that rage on around us but we must also never forget the charge and challenge we have been given in helping to fight it. "With this in mind, be alert and always keep on praying for all the Lord's people."

Reflection Questions:

1. What are some of the ways in which you have felt led to pray for someone for something specific?

2. Why is it important to pray with other believers?

3. How can we follow the Spirit's leading in prayer?

Challenge:

Practice following the Spirit's leading in prayer. Take some time during your daily devotions or your commute to pray specifically for other churches around the world, upholding fellow believers and their needs.

Pray also for me, that whenever I speak, words may be given me so that I will fearlessly make known the mystery of the gospel, for which I am an ambassador in chains. Pray that I may declare it fearlessly, as I should.

EPHESIANS 6:19-20

WEEK 6 DAY 5

WEEK THEME:
Spiritual Warfare

DAY THEME:
Ambassadors in Chains

Hugh Lattimer once preached before King Henry VIII. Henry was greatly displeased by the boldness in the sermon and ordered Lattimer to preach again on the following Sunday and apologize for the offence he had given. The next Sunday, after reading his text, he began his sermon like this: "Hugh Lattimer, do you know before whom you are this day to speak? To the high and mighty monarch, who can take away your life if you offend. Therefore, take heed that you speak not a word that may displease. Hugh, do you not know from where you come – upon whose message you are sent? By the great and mighty God, who is all-present and who sees your ways and who is able to cast your soul into hell! Therefore, take care that you deliver my message faithfully." He then preached the same sermon he had preached the previous Sunday – and with considerably more energy.

Paul closes his section on spiritual warfare with a personal petition for prayer. Paul is in the midst of the battle, in prison as a result of proclaiming the gospel, yet his prayer is not that he may be freed or delivered from this situation, but that nothing would stop him from preaching the gospel. For Paul, this was the sole purpose of his ministry – to proclaim the gospel at all times and in all situations. Like Hugh Lattimer, anything else was simply a cop-out and despite recognising the life or death reality of the situation, he only asks for boldness and courage to carry on with his mission.

Paul calls himself an "ambassador in chains," which seems to be a contradictory picture. Being in Rome, Paul would have been accustomed to ambassadors visiting the city to have meetings with Caesar. Each one carried a message from the king or tribe they represented. During their time in Rome, they would have enjoyed diplomatic privilege, meaning that they had the freedom of a citizen while in the city. Here is Paul describing himself as an ambassador but one who is in chains; whose very freedom has been stripped away from him yet he still bears the responsibility and honor of bringing forth a message from the King of kings. That is why Paul's prayer is not for a change of circumstance but, instead, for the boldness to use the circumstances he finds himself in as a means for him to proclaim the gospel.

The battle we find ourselves in today may restrict our freedom or ability to do things in the natural but in the spiritual, whatever we face can be the platform for us to proclaim the gospel. Whatever loss or suffering we may be going through, whatever pain or discomfort has been inflicted, these may be vehicles for the hope and goodness of the gospel and we must be prepared to see them as such. So often our prayer should not be for deliverance from a particular situation but:

Lord use me at this moment and give me the courage and boldness to proclaim your gospel.

When we have this attitude of heroes like Paul and Hugh Lattimer, we will find a fresh boldness to preach the good news no matter what the cost may be. Ultimately, this is what the armor of God allows us to do.

Reflection Questions:

1. How can you see past your current situation or trial to focus on your calling to proclaim the gospel?

2. How often do you pray for deliverance from hard times instead of praying for God to use them for his gospel purposes?

3. What does being an "ambassador in chains" look like for you in your current context?

Challenge:

Reorient your prayers so that, instead of focussing on what you lack, they focus on fully living in what you have. For example, pray that God will give you boldness to speak into difficult situations rather than removing you from them.

For our struggle is not against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the powers of this dark world and against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly realms.

EPHESIANS 6:12

WEEK 7 DAY 1

WEEK THEME:
Strongholds

DAY THEME:
The Spiritual World is Real



MEMORY VERSE:

"For our struggle is not against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the powers of this dark world and against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly realms."

EPHESIANS 6:12

Last week, we spent time exploring the spiritual landscape that every believer finds themselves in. We looked at the wonderful gift that God has given us - spiritual armor to stand firm in the battle. But what happens when we fall? What happens when sin takes hold in our lives and we end up struggling to deal with spiritual roadblocks? This week, we will explore how spiritual strongholds can form in our lives and the tools that God has given us to overcome them.

Scripture claims that the spiritual world is real – God is spirit, the angels are spirits, and we believers are, in part, also spirit. Despite the fact that it is invisible to us and cannot be touched, the spiritual world profoundly impacts the physical world we live in, not least of all because we are struggling against a spiritual enemy.

Satan, who is a created being, rebelled against God with other angels that the Bible calls demons and these "spiritual forces of evil" war with God and continually seek to undermine his saving work here on earth. The thing is that the biggest battleground is not in front of a castle on a hill somewhere, but actually inside of you and I. Simply put, Satan knows that the most effective strategy against the child of God is to influence and if possible, control our minds (our thinking) and our hearts (our emotions).

When Jesus was being questioned about foods regarded as ritually unclean, he said in Matthew 15:18 that it's not what goes into a man's mouth that makes him unclean but instead what comes out of a man's mouth. Why? And this is important! Jesus said the things we say, either righteous or wicked, flow from the heart that is either righteous or wicked. The state of the inner man (you could call this our roots) is what determines our attitudes, behavior and words (our fruit). So, when Satan wants to bring believers into bondage, he starts by attacking the inner man – what we think about and what we desire – that way he can get us to yield our will to evil instead of good.

The diagram alongside illustrates the component parts of a person: body, soul and spirit (though it's important to realize these indivisibly make up the whole person). When you were born again, a profound and objective change took place in your life even if it couldn't be measured with an MRI-scan. If there were such a thing as a spiritual scanner, it would, however, be able to show a truly radical change.

Your spirit was brought to life, your heart of stone (formerly unresponsive to God) was replaced by a heart of flesh imprinted with God's will, and wonderfully your will (which was once enslaved to evil and thus Satan), has been set free to follow God!



It's from that regenerating work of the Holy Spirit at salvation that the new Christian life flows. We start with this radical change at rebirth, and we learn how to submit our newly liberated will to righteousness instead of sin. As we have seen over the last few weeks, that is an ongoing process which is empowered by the Holy Spirit and impacts every area of

our lives. That's why Paul in writing to the Corinthian believers tells them that they are literally a *NEW CREATION!*

Now, remember God's enemy and our enemy Satan? Well, he knows he cannot undo the work of regeneration in us but he has figured out that if he can control certain territory in our inner man, (our soul) he can negatively impact how we live.

Tomorrow, we will talk about how the enemy seeks to establish strongholds in our soul if we give him an opportunity. Of course, it can only happen if we allow it because Jesus has triumphed over Satan on the cross and as we learnt last week, has armed us to withstand all his attacks.

Reflection Questions:

1. Have you experienced the reality of the spiritual world in your life – think about times you've engaged with God in worship or prayer?

2. What changes have you experienced in your inner world (thoughts, feelings, etc) since you met Christ?

3. How have you experienced the attacks and temptations of Satan in your life since becoming a Christian?

Challenge:

Invite the Holy Spirit to have full control of your inner world, bringing the deep and wonderful assurance into every part of your inner world that you are a child of God.

In your anger do not sin: Do not let the sun go down while you are still angry, and do not give the devil a foothold.

EPHESIANS 4:26-27

WEEK 7 DAY 2

WEEK THEME:
Strongholds

DAY THEME:
Satan's Foothold in our Lives

"...we have also been set free from an obligation or slavery to sin."

One of the pictures the Bible uses to describe our salvation is redemption, which we explored in week 2 day 2. Basically, it means that not only have we been forgiven for the sins we have committed, but we have also been set free from an obligation or slavery to sin. When Paul writes to the believers in Rome, he speaks to them about how they should live now that they are free! There is a need for him to do this because although we are free from slavery to sin, we can still sin. We, therefore, need to be wise about how we live. How crazy would it be if a slave was set completely free, but the next day went back to living just like he did when he was still in chains?

The apostle Paul says that we who are free must embrace our new freedom by rejecting the old allegiance to sin and establishing a new allegiance to righteous living. Now, of course, we will still sin from time to time but how we deal with that sin determines whether we remain fully free. For example, if we sin and then blame others, or find excuses for our sin, instead of repenting, we will eventually allow Satan to gain a foothold in our lives. This means we allow him to get just enough access in our lives that he can use to establish a stronger and stronger position until he's exercising illegitimate influence over us.

It is not just the sin we don't deal with biblically that opens doors to our soul. We can also give the enemy access to our lives when we carry "baggage" of our past life beyond the cross – holding on to past hurts, believing lies about ourselves or about who God is, or never properly surrendering sinful habits we were engaged in before we met Jesus!

In his second letter to the church in Corinth, Paul introduces the idea of strongholds. Imagine an enemy fortress set upright in the middle of the landscape of your soul. Although your soul belongs to Christ and you are free, in this specific area of your life, Satan has established a base of illegitimate control – that is a stronghold. In other words, faulty thinking patterns based on lies and deception are areas in your heart or mind where Satan has the power to exercise real influence.

Reflection Questions:

- Do you have difficulty in giving or receiving love?
- Do you come from a proud family? Are you proud?
- Are you rebellious or angry? Or stubborn?
- Do you have unforgiveness, resentment, bitterness or hatred towards a person? Who is that person?
- Are you anxious or depressed?
- Have you ever contemplated or attempted suicide?
- What fears or phobias do you have?
- Have you visited temples? Been into witchcraft?
- Have you carried charms? Do you have idols?
- Has heavy metal or punk rock "turned you on?"
- Do you fantasize and lust? Masturbate?
- Have you been sexually molested? At what age?
- Do you suffer from chronic illnesses?
- Do you have times of heavy doubts about the existence of God, or your own salvation?

If there are areas in your life that you answered yes to and they are causing you anxiety or fear, take a moment to pray to ask God to give you peace and confidence that he is in the process of setting you free. If necessary, you can contact your mentor and talk this through with him or her today.

Challenge:

Meditate on the truth that the Christian walk starts with an inner change that rests on the finished work of Christ and is enabled by the power of the Holy Spirit. Think about how by giving in to sin and being careless with our new life, we can open the door to Satan's influence in that inner part of our lives.

The weapons we fight with are not the weapons of the world. On the contrary, they have divine power to demolish strongholds.

2 CORINTHIANS 10:4

WEEK 7 DAY 3

WEEK THEME:
Strongholds

DAY THEME:
Strongholds

MEMORY VERSE:
"The weapons we fight with are not the weapons of the world. On the contrary, they have divine power to demolish strongholds."
2 CORINTHIANS 10:4

Yesterday, we finished by looking at some possible ways we can give Satan a foothold in our lives which he can use to establish a stronghold in our soul. One thing we did not talk about was the fact that someone else can open a door to demonic oppression in our lives. This can happen if you are, for example, the victim of sexual abuse or if your parents were engaged in occultic practices.

When serious sin is not dealt with or where we come into agreement with a lie, Satan begins his attack. He seeks to keep us from dealing with the sin / lie, knowing that a pattern becomes an addiction so that no matter how much we "want" to be free, even repenting with seemingly deep sincerity, we find ourselves unable to break out of a destructive cycle. That is a stronghold in our soul and the bondage is illustrated below by the lock in our soul.



I knew a young man who was addicted to pornography before he got saved. After coming to Christ, he walked in freedom from that addiction to lust for only a short while. No matter how many times he repented with tears, he found himself back in that sin. The inner conflict between his new God-honoring nature and the inner compulsion to sin became so traumatic that he became suicidal. Fortunately, God provided a godly man to come alongside him, who led him through a prayer of deliverance. He was set free from that demonic oppression and from that day on, he was free from the control of that sin.

We ought to be so grateful to God that he has put us in a community. One of the things that should have become obvious to you as you've gone through this discipleship guide is that you cannot journey the road to sanctification by yourself and in your own strength. You need the Holy Spirit. You need a faith community.

Only the Holy Spirit can truly know what is in your heart. As you worked through that list of questions yesterday, it was the Spirit of God that was searching your soul and bringing to mind things that you need to deal with – past hurts, unforgiveness, lies and deception and also sins we haven't dealt with. The thing about his work in us is that it never feels like he is humiliating or condemning us – this is because the Spirit is continuing / completing the redemptive work of the Father which Jesus started. God wants us free of sin and shame!

The Spirit will often work in our life through other believers, especially leaders and mature believers God has put in our lives. Often believers try to deal with strongholds on their own because they think they're the only person in the world who thinks or behaves as they do. You are not and you cannot do it alone.

Tomorrow, we will look at the first step we need to take in pulling down the strongholds. As you work through this material, you may find you really need someone to talk it through with. If so, don't wait until your end-of-week meeting with your mentor – contact them today and set up a time to talk and pray through this part of your journey.

Reflection Questions:

1. How can we learn to spot destructive or addictive cycles in our lives?

2. How could you harden your heart to the Holy Spirit's work of highlighting areas in your inner life that he wants to deal with?

3. What do you think happens if we try to change the fruit (your attitudes and behaviors) without changing the roots (breaking down the stronghold)?

Challenge:

Prayerfully prepare yourself to talk to someone, preferably your mentor, and commit yourself to have an honest conversation with them about the areas in your life that the Holy Spirit has brought to your attention over the past two days.

We demolish arguments and every pretension that sets itself up against the knowledge of God, and we take captive every thought to make it obedient to Christ.

2 CORINTHIANS 10:5

WEEK 7 DAY 4

WEEK THEME:
Strongholds

DAY THEME:
Pulling Down Strongholds

We started this week with the reminder that the spiritual world is even more real than the physical world. It is real but just as we cannot see or touch the spirit realm, we cannot affect that realm with physical "weapons." That's why Paul says in the verse above that we need weapons from another world – weapons which have divine or spiritual power.

It's not that there isn't a place for things such as medication or psychology – there certainly is and we can be very grateful for the doctors and psychologists that God has given to help us. But what happens if the "symptoms" we are experiencing stem from a demonic stronghold in our lives rather than from a diagnosable physical ailment or chemical imbalance? In that instance, spiritual weapons need to be employed to bring about freedom. We must be careful we don't find ourselves just medicating the symptoms and learning to live with the bondage instead of finding the freedom Christ won for us. As Tony Evans so emphatically puts it:

Those fortresses don't need to be remodelled. God doesn't tell us to capture them, change the locks, and use them for him. Satan's fortresses must be torn down.

We want to be free and Jesus said the truth will set us free – that means knowing and putting into practice the truth. The non-negotiable starting point for freedom is to accept Christ as your Lord and Savior. If you're not yet a Christ-follower, that's where you need to start. Please take time now to revisit week 1, especially day 4.

If you are already a Christ-follower, the first step in pulling down Satan's strongholds in your life is rejecting the lie and embracing the truth about two people in your life. If you don't do this, you will continually battle the consequences of wrong thinking and the influence that it gives Satan in your life. Who are these two people?

1) God

It's not enough to know / accept that God is God – ie: almighty, all-knowing and everywhere present (that's important but I suppose the easiest part to accept). We need to go to the Bible to get a complete, accurate picture of God the Father. In the book of Romans, it says God is both "just and the justifier" and being both is everything. To be just means that God is righteous and that he cannot lie. To be the justifier means that he is the loving, gracious, kind God who forgives us.

Satan wants us to believe these traits of God are at war with each other but actually, God's justice and love are always fully satisfied and expressed in ALL his works. He is a good Father who loves His children enough to give his only Son to pay the just (correct) penalty for our sin.

2) You

Before you were born again, you were the enemy of God – an outsider and a slave to your own wicked and sinful nature. But the wonder of salvation is that your status before God has changed and despite occasional evidence to the contrary and the accusations of Satan, you need to accept that you are a new creation! You are a LOVED son or daughter of God; you are FREE and no longer obligated to the sinful nature; you are righteous and fully accepted by God. Can you see that when we fail to understand and believe this, it opens us up to manipulation by Satan?

For example, too many men spend their lives proving their dad wrong when he viciously said they'd never amount to anything. That performance mentality opens us up to do things because we care more about what others think of us than what God thinks. Or what about

a young lady who has endured deep rejection, now engaging in casual sexual relationships, because they promise to fulfil her deep need for acceptance and love.

When we come to accept who God says we are, however, Satan's power to control us through these lies is broken. Read these statements about who the Bible says God is and who you are:

God is:	I am:
...a father	...a son / daughter
...loving	...loved
...all powerful	...protected
...gracious	...righteous
...forgiver of sin	...forgiven
...just	...innocent
...truth	...accepted

Reflection Questions:

1. What lies about your identity have you believed in the past?

2. How do God's thoughts about you differ from your own?

3. Are there areas in your life where you haven't accepted the truth of who God is?

Challenge:

Write out the statements about who God is and who you are on a separate piece of paper. Place it somewhere that you'll see it every morning when you wake up (next to your bed, on your mirror, the dashboard of your car, etc). Start each day praying through these statements, asking God to plant them deep within your heart. Release your own ideas of your identity and replace them with these truths.

The weapons we fight with are not the weapons of the world. On the contrary, they have divine power to demolish strongholds.

2 CORINTHIANS 10:4

WEEK 7 DAY 5

WEEK THEME:
Strongholds

DAY THEME:
Pulling Down Strongholds

Divine weapons are spiritual practices that God has given to us to destroy strongholds. Yesterday, we spoke about the weapon of truth. As we come into agreement with what the Bible says about who God is and about our new identity in Christ, it is like an explosion going off in Satan's stronghold bringing down the walls.

Other divine weapons include confession (repentance / admitting), calling upon God (prayer), and community (accountability).

1. Repentance is basically coming to the place where we see our sinful thoughts and actions the way God does. It is us truly recognizing that all sin is destructive, damaging to us and those in our community as well as to our intimacy with God. True repentance doesn't sugar-coat our sin or shift the blame to others or our circumstances. True biblical repentance can only come if there has been godly sorrow because we sincerely accept that our attitude or action is contrary to who God is! Sometimes repentance needs to take place by confessing our sin to other believers as Jesus' brother instructs us in James 5:16.

2. Prayer is powerful and when ordinary people like us pray, extraordinary things happen because God has chosen to run his kingdom by acting upon the prayers of his people. Often the roots of our issues (our strongholds) are in the spiritual world, even if the fruits manifest in the physical world – so prayer becomes the most important tool we have. I used this prayer from another discipleship course to help overcome a stronghold of anger in my own life when I was a young believer. I prayed it daily, inserting my baggage of anger into the prayer:

Lord Jesus, this baggage has been with me for a very long time. When I've tried to get rid of it before, I have always failed. I don't carry this baggage in my hands. It is deep inside me. It is as much a part of me as my skin and bones! I am helpless before it. I want to be released from it. I confess to you that I cannot even help you with the process. I believe in you, and I believe you have the power to release me. You have come to live in my life. Now I invite you to work in my life. I cannot give this baggage to you but if you will take it from me, it is yours! Thank you for being my deliverer.

3. Finally, the community of believers and the gift of encouragement and accountability. Once the stronghold has been broken in our lives, we are no longer under the demonic influence in that area but that's not the end of the road. Over the years, we have gotten so used to thinking and feeling a certain way when we are triggered that a discernable impression has been left on our lives. This can continue to affect, but not control, how we think or feel when facing that trigger again. That's why in the same passage dealing with strongholds, in the very next verse, we are told to "take every thought captive" (2 Corinthians 10:5).

The Holy Spirit uses time we spend reading the Bible, praying, worshipping, and participating in a faith community to recalibrate our thinking to align with God's ways. It's during this time of recalibration that we need mature believers to encourage us and to hold us accountable. There will be times when we are tempted and having others pray with us is vital. And when we fail and fall into sin, having others call us to repentance and exhort us to get up again is so important. As Solomon said, pity the man who falls and has no one to help him up.

Friend, if you have been through these five days and feel that there are internal issues that you need help resolving, please talk honestly and courageously to your mentor. If necessary, they will

connect you with a trusted counselor who can help you go deeper until you are walking in complete freedom in Christ!

Reflection Questions:

1. Which of the divine weapons listed above seems most challenging to you and why?

2. Have you experienced godly sorrow that leads to repentance?

3. What are some ways in which you can "take every thought captive"?

Challenge:

Write your own "baggage" prayer, making it specific to any strongholds you've found in your life. Commit yourself to daily prayer until you are walking in freedom. Make specific plans to spend time with your mentor this week and start cultivating a relationship of accountability and encouragement.

But if it is preached that Christ has been raised from the dead, how can some of you say that there is no resurrection of the dead? If there is no resurrection of the dead, then not even Christ has been raised. And if Christ has not been raised, our preaching is useless and so is your faith. More than that, we are then found to be false witnesses about God, for we have testified about God that he raised Christ from the dead. But he did not raise him if in fact the dead are not raised. For if the dead are not raised, then Christ has not been raised either. And if Christ has not been raised, your faith is futile; you are still in your sins. Then those also who have fallen asleep in Christ are lost. If only for this life we have hope in Christ, we are of all people most to be pitied. But Christ has indeed been raised from the dead, the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep.

1 CORINTHIANS 15:12-20

WEEK 8 DAY 1

WEEK THEME:
Glorification

DAY THEME:
Suffering & Glory



MEMORY VERSE:

"God's dwelling-place is now among the people and he will dwell with them. They will be his people and God himself will be with them and be their God.

REVELATION 21:3

As we draw this discipleship guide to a close, we move onto our final doctrine in this journey together. We started off by looking at salvation and how, as sinful humanity, we needed a Savior to free us from sin and death. That salvation includes the reality that we have been justified. We move from guilty to innocent and our identity is forever changed by God. We then explored sanctification, the ongoing work of transformation taking place in our lives, as we cooperate with the Holy Spirit to live as the new creation God ordained us to be. This week, we will explore the final part of the journey every believer can look forward to in joyful expectation: glorification.

Glorification is the final step in the application of redemption. It will happen when Christ returns and raises from the dead the bodies of all believers for all time who have died, and reunites them with their souls, and changes the bodies of all believers who remain alive, thereby giving all believers at the same time perfect resurrection bodies like his own.
Wayne Grudem - Systematic Theology

Glorification is an essential truth in the life of the believer for two reasons – it allows us to put what is happening in our world today in perspective, therefore, transforming how we live, and it also brings us hope for what is to come.

On his deathbed, British preacher Charles Simeon smiled brightly and asked the people gathered in his room "What do you think especially gives me comfort at this time?" When they all remained silent, he exclaimed, "The creation! I ask myself, 'Did Jehovah create the world or did I?' He did! Now if he made the world and all the rolling spheres of the universe, he certainly can take care of me. Into Jesus' hands, I can safely commit my spirit!"

Death in our day has become a taboo topic. So focused are we on extending life as much as possible that we too often ignore the reality of our own mortality. The amazing advances in modern medicine and changes to the way we live, especially in modern nations, means death can seem to have been banished except for the very aged. This is a radical departure from only 100 years ago, when the threat of death was a constant reality for most. Maybe as a result we have lost perspective of the truth that death is not the end. The Bible assures us that all will experience resurrection – the vital question is whether we will be resurrected to eternal life or eternal death.

One of the great debates that gripped the early Church was how to understand the resurrection of Jesus. For Paul, Jesus' resurrection was intricately linked with the promise of future glorification for all who believed in Jesus. Christ's resurrection was not only the declaration that death had been beaten, but also the assurance of being reunited to our resurrection body in the world to come.

Paul is strong in his language. If the resurrection of Christ hasn't taken place, then we can't say we are free from sin's penalty. Then when we die, we are lost, our faith is pointless, and the world should laugh at us. But because we know that Christ has indeed risen, we can hold on to the promises of God. The resurrection of Christ was the sign that Christ's sacrifice was accepted and that sin, and therefore death, have been defeated. It was also the ultimate guarantee that when we die, those who have come in faith to Christ will follow him, also be resurrected, and will one day be reunited with our glorified bodies. As Paul puts it, Christ is the "firstfruits" of what is to come.

This is what gave Charles Simeon such strength and peace as he lay dying. Christ is the proof and the guarantee of what awaited him on the other side of death. As

Christians, we should not attempt to avoid thinking about death but, rather, actively meditate on the glories that await us when our promotion one day comes.

When our identity changed and we became sons and daughters of God, our citizenship also changed. We become citizens of heaven and our time on earth is a temporary, expat existence (which we all understand well) until one day when we enter into the new heaven and new earth promised to us.

Jesus has defeated death and we no longer have to live in fear of what is to come, nor ought we invest our lives this side of heaven in building what won't last.

Reflection Questions:

1. How have you viewed death in the past?

2. How does the reality of resurrection affect your life today?

3. What practical impact is there on the lives of those who live without fear of death?

Challenge:

Talk to someone about the reality of death, using it as an opportunity to discuss the hope you've found in Christ.

Then I saw a great white throne and him who was seated on it. The earth and the heavens fled from his presence, and there was no place for them. And I saw the dead, great and small, standing before the throne, and books were opened. Another book was opened, which is the book of life. The dead were judged according to what they had done as recorded in the books. The sea gave up the dead that were in it, and death and Hades gave up the dead that were in them, and each person was judged according to what they had done. Then death and Hades were thrown into the lake of fire. The lake of fire is the second death. Anyone whose name was not found written in the book of life was thrown into the lake of fire.

2 CORINTHIANS 10:4

WEEK 8 DAY 2

WEEK THEME:
Glorification

DAY THEME:
Judgement

"To define ourselves by the present, rather than eternity, is to forsake the present joy of the great inheritance that awaits us."

If I find in myself a desire which no experience in this world can satisfy, the most probable explanation is that I was made for another world.
C.S. Lewis - Mere Christianity

Deep in our hearts, we all know this desire C.S. Lewis describes is in fact a yearning to be home. As Christians who have the answer to this longing, we can tragically still choose to exchange the reality of our heavenly citizenship for the temporary unsatisfactory substitute of earthly pleasures. To define ourselves by the present, rather than eternity, is to forsake the present joy of the great inheritance that awaits us.

Revelation, written by John on the island of Patmos, sets out to encourage and warn the early Church about what to expect in the end times. John realized that the way the young Church would overcome the difficulties it faced was by setting its challenges in the context of eternity. The same message is as relevant for us today as it was two thousand years ago. While often misunderstood or poorly taught, we must not be afraid of it or ignore it.

One of the key themes that appear throughout Revelation is God vanquishing evil and establishing his eternal kingdom on the foundation of truth and love. Though, to do this, there must be separating out those that are of God and those that are not. This is commonly known as Judgment Day and it is what our reading today focuses on. As Robert H. Mounce puts it:

With this, we are closing the chapter on sin and stand ready to enter the eternal state of glory.

The concept of judgement, especially by God, is unpopular in today's tolerance-culture. However only God can judge us fairly and the criteria on which we are judged is simply our sin and rebellion against him. All of humanity stands guilty based on those standards but those of us who put our faith in Jesus are clothed with his righteousness and our names are now to be found in the book of life. God no longer sees our sin and rebellion but, instead, sees Christ's righteousness. Tomorrow, we will explore more about why and how God judges those who have put their faith in Jesus. The question we must ask ourselves is this: have we allied ourselves with God or chosen a life that rejects him? If the latter is the case, we will not inherit the kingdom. Judgment awaits all of humanity because God is just and will one day close all accounts, meaning

that all who have sinned will receive their just deserts (wages).

The final judgment that awaits all people will end the corruption and rebellion that heaven and earth have been subjected to. God will finally deal with sin, death, and the devil and will usher in the new age with a new heaven and new earth.

Is your name in his book of life? If you are unsure about your salvation, go back to week 1 day 4 and ask Jesus to reveal himself to you and right now put your faith in him as Lord and Savior.

Reflection Questions:

1. Knowing what awaits those who reject God, what is holding you back from sharing the gospel with those around you?

2. How are God's standards for judgment different from the world's?

3. Is your name in the book of life?

Challenge:

Read Revelation 20 throughout the week, meditating on the reality of the last judgment and the radical mercy of God.

The Spirit himself testifies with our spirit that we are God's children. Now if we are children, then we are heirs – heirs of God and co-heirs with Christ, if indeed we share in his sufferings in order that we may also share in his glory. I consider that our present sufferings are not worth comparing with the glory that will be revealed in us. For the creation waits in eager expectation for the children of God to be revealed. For the creation was subjected to frustration, not by its own choice, but by the will of the one who subjected it, in hope that the creation itself will be liberated from its bondage to decay and brought into the freedom and glory of the children of God.

ROMANS 8:16-21

WEEK 8 DAY 3

WEEK THEME:
Glorification

DAY THEME:
Life After Death

MEMORY VERSE:
"I consider that our present sufferings are not worth comparing with the glory that will be revealed in us."
ROMANS 8:18

Yesterday, we explored the revelation that John had of the final judgment of all humanity. In it, we saw that each and every person would stand before the throne and their lives would be assessed based upon what they had done and whether their name was found in the book of life. Back in week 1, we explored the confidence every believer can have in their salvation and so for us who have put our faith in Jesus, we can approach this day with hope and certainty. What sort of judgment will we believers face, given that Paul in his second letter to the church in Corinth reminds the believers that they will stand before God?

> *So we make it our goal to please him, whether we are at home in the body or away from it. For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ, so that each of us may receive what is due to us for the things done while in the body, whether good or bad.*
> 2 Corinthians 5:6-10

Yet the judgement we face as believers is not whether we will enjoy heaven or suffer hell, for that has already been decided and secured in Christ, rather one that focuses on the rewards we will receive or perfect in heaven. Paul uses a really interesting picture when he writes to the church in Corinth about the judgment seat of Christ. Corinth was famous for many things including the Isthmian Games. This was a series of competitions similar to those over in Olympia. Men would compete in various contests – chariot races, wrestling, boxing and even musical and poetry contests. After each game, the competitors who had prevailed would line up before the judgment seat where they were awarded prizes and recognition. Paul uses the same language when talking about the judgment seat that we will one day stand before. This is a place where good works and service towards Jesus are rewarded and celebrated, but consequently also where "bad" works and neglect of the believer's call is called to account, by the loss of rewards!

The knowledge that we will one day stand before Jesus and have our lives examined should spur us on to run the race God has determined to overcome the trials and tribulations for his glory. It is evident Paul believed this doctrine was critical and that rightly understanding it helped him persevere when times got tough. Having the hope that comes from knowing one day Jesus will return to establish his kingdom and reward us for the part we have played, helped Paul and ought to help us today endure suffering and frustration for the sake of the gospel.

We are to be people who keep in mind the future glory and reward we will enjoy as a result of faithfully serving Jesus. This gives us the strength and endurance needed to face the suffering and resist the temptations of our day.

In Romans 8:17-21, which we read above, Paul goes to great lengths to remind the Church that when we share in the sufferings of Christ, we also share in his glory. Paul is talking here about suffering for the gospel. You see, Paul understood that whenever someone suffers persecution, hardship, or sacrifice for the sake of the gospel, not only did Jesus go through infinitely worse but also that, through suffering, we are helping the gospel to go out to the ends of the earth. This allows us to know our suffering is not meaningless. Therefore, whatever we might have to endure (and please know we are not minimizing the real pain that many people face) pales in comparison to the glory that will be received when Christ returns.

This is the hope and promise that the doctrine of glorification brings to us today. The sacrifices and suffering that we are

called to make and endure for the gospel seem easier and lighter when we know not only do we have a God who shared in that suffering but more importantly, we also get to share in the reward Christ will one day give to his faithful followers.

Reflection Questions:

1. How does knowing that we as believers will also face judgment change how you live your life today?

2. What can you do to keep an eternal perspective of the situations and suffering you are experiencing today?

3. How can you lovingly comfort fellow believers when they go through times of suffering?

Challenge:

Next time you're going through a hard time, praise God and thank him for his work in your life. Pray with eternity in mind, acknowledging the present but holding fast to the future glory. Use this principle to remind yourself that your values are not based on current comfort but coming crowns / rewards.

I did not see a temple in the city, because the Lord God Almighty and the Lamb are its temple. The city does not need the sun or the moon to shine on it, for the glory of God gives it light, and the Lamb is its lamp. The nations will walk by its light, and the kings of the earth will bring their splendour into it. On no day will its gates ever be shut, for there will be no night there. The glory and honor of the nations will be brought into it. Nothing impure will ever enter it, nor will anyone who does what is shameful or deceitful, but only those whose names are written in the Lamb's book of life.

REVELATION 21:22-27

WEEK 8 DAY 4

WEEK THEME:
Glorification

DAY THEME:
New Heaven & New Earth

In this text pointing to the future we see God will make his dwelling-place in the middle of his people which was the plan all along – no barrier between Creator and creature, between God and man, between Father and children. This was what was being modelled in Leviticus through the tent of meeting and was the kingdom that the God incarnate, Jesus, came to usher in. And now, it is finally here. God's desire throughout all eternity to be with his people has now been fulfilled. But this isn't a do-over just for humans to mess it up again. God will fully reverse the curse that came from the fall.

> *It is done. I am the Alpha and the Omega, the Beginning and the End. To the thirsty, I will give water without cost from the spring of the water of life. Those who are victorious will inherit all this, and I will be their God and they will be my children.*
> Revelation 21:6-7

That phrase "it is done" echoes throughout all eternity and picks up the same language we see in the Gospel of John – Jesus' final words on the cross were "it is finished." As he cried out and gave up his spirit, the wrath of God was once and for all satisfied. The penalty of sin was paid and no longer was there a barrier between humanity and God. As God remakes heaven and earth, sin is no longer a component and can no longer set the tone or corrupt the rhythm of life.

In the world to come, we can rest on the certain truth that, in this new heaven and earth, there is nothing else to be done to ensure freedom: we can live in the perfection of settled creation. The invitation is to live today in the hope of what is to come, fixing our eyes on the prize as we run the race. When we hold in tension that which is to come with what we face in our today, we walk in Christian maturity.

The moment all of eternity has been leading up to is the bride becoming the wife and being united with the Lamb. We the Church, the children of God, are forever and completely united with Jesus. This is what the cross was all about, and now, in this glorious vision, John gets to see the future reality that every Christian will share in. As he looks, he sees the new Jerusalem descending from heaven to earth and then goes on to describe it in great detail. We could spend days examining every component of what John saw at that moment but sadly we don't have time, so we will just focus on a few of the key details.

Firstly, there will no longer be a temple where God dwells. During the time that John was writing down his revelation while on Patmos, the temple was still being used in Jerusalem. As the central focus point of Jewish worship, it was unimaginable that the temple would not exist. God now dwells both with his people and in his people. The temple was only ever designed to allow the holiness of God to be in the midst of his people in a way that would not destroy them due to their sinful nature. Now that sin has been dealt with, this need is no longer there. Secondly, our light will no longer come from the sun or the moon but from God directly. John is revealing, in picture language, that humankind will no longer seek its wisdom and understanding from other sources but from God alone.

The glory of God will now stretch out to the whole of the world. God's holy presence will allow all nations to come into his presence. Heaven isn't exclusively for one particular race, group, or people in history but for everyone who has called upon the name of the Lord and been saved. The gate of the city is never closed – gates no longer serve the purpose of providing defence for the city but stand merely in decoration. In times of peace, gates could be open to allow for the free

movement of people and trade. They would be closed at night, though, and access restricted. In times of war, they would be sealed shut to make sure the invading army could not gain access. In this new city, however, peace reigns and the enemies of God have been defeated. Nothing that is not of God, will enter this city, or as John puts it, "nothing impure will ever enter it, nor will anyone who does what is shameful or deceitful."

Now, while it's incredible having a description of heaven, how does this apply to me today? Earlier in this discipleship guide, we looked at how we are already citizens of heaven and that this should impact how we live our lives. It should spur us to live lives that reflect the fact that we are no longer residents of the kingdom of darkness but, instead, citizens of God's kingdom. Having a deeper understanding of the prize ahead of us should make us want to run the race well today.

Reflection Questions:

1. How does knowing what awaits us encourage you to grow in maturity in this life?

2. How would you describe the prize that awaits us?

3. What are the implications of God dwelling amongst his people without a barrier?

Challenge:

Spend some time using these scriptures to imagine the city of God, a place of deep intimacy, unrestrained joy, and eternal peace.

"Behold, I am coming soon, bringing my recompense with me, to repay each one for what he has done. I am the Alpha and the Omega, the first and the last, the beginning and the end." Blessed are those who wash their robes, so that they may have the right to the tree of life and that they may enter the city by the gates. Outside are the dogs and sorcerers and the sexually immoral and murderers and idolaters, and everyone who loves and practices falsehood…He who testifies to these things says, "Surely I am coming soon." Amen. Come, Lord Jesus! The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all. Amen.

REVELATION 22:12-15 & 20-21

WEEK 8 DAY 5

WEEK THEME:
Glorification

DAY THEME:
Return of Jesus

"Behold, I am coming soon…" These words should fill us with great hope and longing. These are the final words spoken to John in his vision of what is to come. They are also the final words of Jesus to us, his Church, found in scripture. They are a reminder to us that the story isn't finished yet. The theologian Robert H. Mounce puts it like this:

At the very close of the book is the confession that the answers to the problems of life do not lie in people's ability to create a better world but in the return of the One whose sovereign power controls the course of human affairs. Redemptive history remains incomplete until Christ returns. It is the final act in the great drama of redemption that the Church awaits with longing.

How should we live if we know Jesus is coming back? Too many of us live as if this was simply some future we will never have to deal with. Each new generation of Christians need to deal with the possibility that they may be the last and, in fact, live as if they were! This will motivate us to fulfil the Matthew 28:19-20 mandate that Jesus gave us with diligence and urgency.

Jesus calls us to play our part in the final chapter of redemptive history. Every day until he comes, we have the opportunity to proclaim the good news. We are the means by which other people get to hear the gospel and the Holy Spirit empowered living will always lead us to invite others into this cosmic adventure. We need to realize that we may be the vessel that God chooses to use to reach that particular person.

While this may be the end of the discipleship guide, it is, in fact, the start of the rest of your life. Everything you have learnt, wrestled with, and applied has all been designed to help you be transformed into Jesus' likeness. Are you prepared to walk each day surrendering yourself to God, resting in his grace, and advancing his glorious kingdom? The world is desperate for this message of hope and salvation – you are called to be the gospel, proclaim the gospel, and enjoy the gospel. Amen!

Reflection Questions:

1. How can we keep the urgency of Jesus' return on our hearts and minds?

2. How can you be a further part of God's redemptive history?

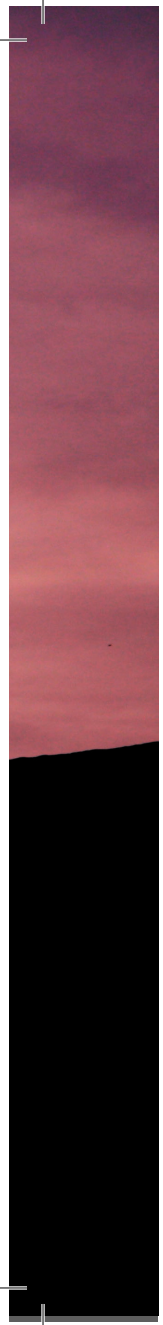
3. What impact has The Discipleship Guide had on your life and your relationship with God?

Challenge:

The challenge we leave you with is simple — are you prepared to live your life pursuing the things of God as you seek to live out the amazing truths we have explored together? As we have discovered, unpacking and applying the wonderful truths of our Justification, Sanctification, and Glorification is a task that lasts a lifetime. Go for it!

"...are you prepared to live your life pursuing the things of God as you seek to live out the amazing truths we have explored together?"





LEADERS GUIDE

Overview & Introduction

Tell me and I forget, teach me and I may remember, involve me and I learn.

Benjamin Franklin

I've always loved this quote from Benjamin Franklin, one of the founding fathers of the United States and one of the greatest thinkers of the 18th century. While I'm sure this saying isn't exclusive to him and has been expressed in various forms throughout the centuries, its truth is constant. People learn and grow best when they are actively involved and participating. Think back to when you were a child and mastering the basics in life like tying your shoes, reciting your alphabet, and doing simple arithmetic. As your parents guided you through these key growth moments, they didn't simply read you instructions and leave you alone to complete the task. They joined you in the adventure of discovery as you explored, played, and were involved in acquiring these new skills or lessons. This way of learning and growing isn't just the domain for the under 5's but it is the method that Jesus used to teach, equip, and prepare the disciples for what lay ahead of them. He didn't just hand them a manual and tell them to get on with it, instead, he invited them into his life and ministry. Ever since then, generation after generation have been helped to grow in their relationship with God through being invited to journey with each other and getting involved in the process of becoming more like Jesus. This baton has now been passed onto you as you walk alongside someone else through the Discipleship Guide. The role of a mentor is not to have all the answers or to teach the foundations of the faith but simply to be a step or two ahead of the disciple and explore with them the wondrous difference that the gospel of Jesus makes in our lives.

The Discipleship Guide is broken into four main sections following the four stages that we as believers go through over our lifetime when we come to Jesus. The first being salvation — the act of recognizing that we are sinners, separated from God and that Jesus is the only source of our salvation. When we choose to trust him alone as Lord and Savior, we are clothed with his righteousness and become children of God in relationship with God the Father. Next we explore justification — this is the status change that takes place at the moment of salvation and as we start to unpack this, we will

see the new identity that is given to each and every believer and the implication this has as to how we live out our life. Next, we will spend time exploring the ongoing process of sanctification — this is the journey of being made holy through partnering with the Holy Spirit. This journey is only completed in death but requires a daily choice to lay down our old nature and to embrace the new person Jesus has made us to be. Finally, we will look at glorification — the final stage every believer must go through at death. Here we will explore the future hope that awaits us and how what lies ahead of us transforms how we live today. As a mentor, you have the privilege of helping the disciple discover and explore these new truths and then apply them directly to their lives.

Over the next few pages, we have provided you with answers to the different daily questions. These help to steer your conversation when you chat weekly with the disciple and provide a reference if you or they get stuck. We have also included relevant scriptures that can be used if you want to dive deeper into any of the days — additionally, twice a week, there are memory verses provided for the disciple to memorize. As a mentor, we are asking you to do three main things:

1. Pray regularly for the disciple.
2. Meet weekly (either in person or online) with the disciple to go through the material covered in the previous week. More information about what this time will look like can be found discipleshipguide.com.
3. Help the disciple connect with others, as needed, if issues arise.

We hope that as you take on this role as a mentor, not only will you have the joy of seeing the disciple grow and develop but you will also see your relationship with Jesus flourish.

WEEK 1 **Doctrine:** Salvation **Week Theme:** Steps to Salvation

In week 1, we will explore the truths that one must wrestle with in order to be able to make a response to salvation in Jesus:

1. God loves all people.
2. Sin and sinfulness separate us from God.
3. God made a vow for us to be forgiven and reconciled to him in Christ.
4. We have to make a personal choice to either receive or reject Christ's offer of eternal life.

The key to this week is helping the disciple understand and process the truth and outcome of each of these statements. This should lead to one of two conclusions: first, an affirmation and assurance of the salvation decision that was made previously in their life; or secondly, the realization that they in fact have not put their faith in Jesus and made a personal choice to accept his forgiveness. If this is the case, you will have the opportunity to walk them through the process. Day 4 deals with this specifically and would be a good day to revisit based upon your discussion, if needed. The assurance of one's salvation is the foundation that the following seven weeks is built upon, so you may feel the need to "camp" on this week for a little longer before moving onto the next — specifically discussing the day 5 challenge:

"Spend some time asking the Holy Spirit to show you any area of your life which hasn't been surrendered to God and then pray through that list placing each one of them under his feet."

This challenge will be a good indicator as to where somebody is in their faith journey and what are some of the themes and areas they may be struggling with. You may wish to repeat this challenge with them when you meet, joining them in praying for God's revelation and handing them back to God.

WEEK 1, DAY 1

1. Do you believe God loves you? If not, what prevents you from believing?

There are two common hurdles people face in believing God's love toward them. Firstly, in a world where we work hard and rely on ourselves to get what we "deserve," it can be difficult to understand that God's love is not earned. Secondly, the disciple's upbringing — perhaps distant, absent, or even abusive parents — might distort their view of God. If this is the case, assure them that we will cover this in a deeper way in week 5.

Here you have an opportunity to allow the disciple to explore their past and see how it can color their perception of God and prevent them from fully receiving the love so freely available to them. Perhaps they had to work hard to get the approval of their earthly father or he was just cold and uncaring. Help them see that their heavenly Father is not a reflection of their earthly one.

Supporting Scripture —
Romans 5:8, Psalms 86:15, Romans 8:37-39

2. How does knowing that God loves you change how you see yourself?

When I think about the creator of the whole universe sending his son to die for me, it makes me feel safer, gives my life meaning, I feel accepted, I feel there's a purpose for my life, and I feel valued. But so often, we assign a value to others or even ourselves based on our achievements or possessions. God assigns value to us because we are his image bearers and are meant to reflect his glory.

Due to the fall of man and the entry of sin, this image was marred. However, as an act of grace through Jesus, God restores that to us in an ongoing work called sanctification (we will learn more about that later). My legal status in the eyes of God is that I am justified and righteous but throughout this life, I am also cooperating with the Spirit of God to become more like Jesus.

Supporting Scripture —
Genesis 1:26-28, Romans 8:29, 1 Corinthians 15:48-49, 2 Corinthians 5:21

3. How does knowing that God loves you change how you see other people?

The ultimate act of love was a sacrificial one - God loved us so much that he gave his son as a sacrifice to "buy" us back. Additionally, we have just seen that all of us are image bearers of God. This is how we relate to others. When we consider the grace (God's unmerited favor) that we received, we are able to extend that to others. We are able to see past caste, creed and color; to see the image of God in all people.

Supporting Scripture —
1 John 4:19

WEEK 1, DAY 2

1. What do you think your response would be if you were to encounter the Holy God face to face?

Most people might respond to this with a careless "I don't know" or a casual "I've got some questions for him" attitude. The key to this question lies in the word HOLY. Were it not for the work of Jesus, we dare not enter into the presence of the Holy God — it will destroy us. But because we are his children, we can come into his presence with confidence. However, this is not to be taken lightly. Encountering the holiness of God is a sharp reminder of our own weaknesses and frailty and must evoke a response of gratitude for the cleansing work of Christ's blood.

Supporting Scripture —
Ephesians 3:12, Hebrews 4:14-16

2. How do you see the effect of your sinful nature play out in your life?

Help the disciple see those "little" things that we can often overlook or try to justify — the one white lie, impatience, or bad temper. These are often overlooked since they are not "big" sins. However, they carry weight and influence in our daily lives and impact our witness and testimony. This is a moment of soul-searching. Encourage the disciple to take a moment and reflect on those areas in their lives that need to be submitted to God. Perhaps there's some area of hidden or previous sin that needs to be addressed. Encourage them to invite the Holy Spirit to bring conviction and repentance.

Where appropriate, you may wish to recommend that they follow one of the several courses that could help (Freedom in Christ, Parenting, Financial Freedom, etc) ask for pastoral care / counseling via our website or even seek the counsel of an elder.

Supporting Scripture —
1 Corinthians 6:19-20

3. What does repentance, declaring "Woe to me! I am ruined! For I am a man of unclean lips," look like for you?

So often we get away with our mistakes by saying a simple "I'm sorry" and often, "my bad" is a common enough expression. Help the disciple to see that repentance is something much deeper than that. The key fruit of repentance is a transformed life. It is not merely to appease anger or escape consequence — rather, it is a recognition that our sin is against God and when we repent, we remind ourselves again of the need for our savior.

Help the disciple see that at its very root, sin is rebellion against God — we stand opposed to God and are his enemies. However, God desires a relationship with us and through the cross, Jesus made that possible. The way we step into that relationship is through repentance (this will be explored further on day 3).

Supporting Scripture —
1 John 1:9, Romans 3:10, Psalms 51:4, Psalms 51:17

WEEK 1, DAY 3

1. What ideas or images come to your mind when you think about the cross?

God is not just a God of love or holiness, he is also a God of justice. This requires that there be a penalty or consequence for sin and we are reminded in scripture that it is death. Perhaps the disciple sees the cross either as a piece of jewelry worn around the neck or dangling from the ears or a form of extreme cruelty. Help them see the cross as the altar on which Christ sacrifices his life in order that the just requirement of God is met. There was a debt owed by my sin — it is this debt that was paid by Jesus on my behalf. The cross is also a revelation of a sovereign God who is merciful and treats us better than we deserve.

Supporting Scripture —
Romans 3:25, Isaiah 53:5, Colossians 2:13-14

2. How does knowing that Jesus dealt with your sin on the cross change the way you live your life?

Jesus went to the cross to pay the penalty of our sin, not to take the cross away from us entirely. In fact, he invites us to take up the cross daily as part of our Christian journey. There's so much we gain from the cross — forgiveness, acceptance, and holiness — but we must also be deliberate in making sure that our old selves don't impact this new life. We are meant to walk in freedom from sin and not as slaves. This means that we diligently crucify our own sinful desires and live in a way that reflects the new life we have received.

Supporting Scripture —
Luke 9:23, Romans 6:6

3. Are you living in the freedom that comes from the cross if you are a Christian? If you are not a Christian, what do you think stops you from accepting the truth of the cross?

To walk in freedom does not give us license to do whatever we wish to. Rather, as John Stott puts it "Christian freedom is freedom from sin, not freedom to sin." This does not mean that none of us will fail from time to time — but it does mean that we are quick to repent and that there is a pattern of holding up our lives before scripture, allowing the Holy Spirit to bring conviction and change.

Where the disciple is not a believer, this would be the time to gently encourage them to consider surrendering their lives to Jesus. If necessary, encourage them to have a conversation with one of the elders to resolve any questions they

may have (you will have an opportunity to explore this further in tomorrow's reading too).

Supporting Scripture —
Romans 6:1, 15, Galatians 5:13-15, John 6:37, Romans 10:13, Ephesians 2:8

WEEK 1, DAY 4

1. Have you accepted Jesus as your Lord and Savior or just trusted in being raised as a Christian?

This is a pivotal moment for the disciple. Help them understand that this is a personal decision — the faith of our parents, growing up with Christian traditions, or even regular church attendance doesn't make you a Christian. The only way we obtain salvation is by receiving Jesus as our Lord and Savior by faith.

Don't add pressure to this moment or try to force a decision — this must come from a Holy Spirit inspired conviction. The biggest challenge we face is to see that God accepts us as we are. Many people feel that they are beyond redemption or need to "fix themselves up" before coming to God. Help them see that the work of the cross is for all, regardless of the depth of our sin. We come as we are and if we TRULY believe, he will save.

Supporting Scripture —
Romans 10:13, 1 Corinthians 6:9-11

2. If you haven't yet accepted Jesus, what are the things that are holding you back?

At its root, most people struggle with this because they think it is a loss of their freedoms or that they have to now follow a set of "rules." What God does really sets us free — in the same way that we take a little child's hand in ours when crossing the street or put a small gate at the top of a stairway to prevent harm to toddlers, God puts certain boundaries in place that are meant to be for our protection. Similarly, without proper guidance, a body of water is just a marsh or a flood that is unhealthy, unproductive, and even destructive. With riverbanks to guide it, that same water can produce life and fruitfulness. God's desire is to protect us and have us be fruitful by placing boundaries in our midst — they are never meant to restrict but rather help us to live in true freedom.

Supporting Scripture —
John 8:34, Galatians 5:1, Romans 6:6, 2 Peter 2:19, 1 Peter 2:16

3. Are you ready today to accept Jesus as your Lord and Savior?

This would be a good place to summarize everything that the disciple has been learning until this point. Perhaps prompt them and help them do it in their own words.

Today has been about making choices and this is the most important one they can ever make — it is more important than their choice of career, spouse, car, home, etc. Challenge them to look at their life in the context of the three truths that we have been exploring (found in today's teaching) and gently encourage them to make a choice.

Supporting Scripture —
John 1:12, Romans 10:13, Revelations 3:20

WEEK 1, DAY 5

1. What are some of the other things (apart from God) that you have built your life upon?

At our very core, all of us want to feel loved, valued, and that we have a purpose. So often we pursue those things

that we think can meet these deep needs only to find that they remain unfulfilled and they let us down. The biggest house, the newest car, the most successful / beautiful / handsome spouse, the ideal family — these dreams that we pursue so often let us down. At the root of it is the lie that our possessions and our achievements will meet those needs. Even when we achieve some of those things we pursue, it might make us feel but that is often short-lived and we are driven to look for more. Help the disciple see that the only way our need for love, value, and purpose can be truly fulfilled is in Jesus.

Supporting Scripture —
Genesis 1:26, Romans 5:8,
Hebrews 29:11, Ephesians 2:10

2. How does knowing that "all things [are] under his feet" help you trust God?

To know that sin and death are defeated on the cross and that God has put all things under the feet of Jesus must give us the confidence to know that whatever our past or our sin, God is able to rescue and redeem us if we ask him. It means that the one who created the whole universe is on our side. To know this is to surely know that all the resources of heaven in Christ Jesus are ours. This is not meant for selfish gain but, rather, for the fulfillment of God's greater redemptive plan. In that, however, is also to be seen that God cares for us and provides for us in our day to day needs.

Supporting Scripture —
1 Peter 5:7, Romans 8: 28, 31-37,
Philippians 4:19, 2 Corinthians 9:8,
Matthew 7:7-11

3. What areas of your life do you find hardest to surrender to God?

By now you should have had the opportunity to build trust with the disciple. Gently encourage them to explore any areas of their lives in which they are struggling to see God being honored. You might find that the disciple is struggling with some habitual sin or battling with something from their past. Perhaps they are struggling in their marriage or an unhealthy relationship — they might be dealing with debt or a myriad other things. Encourage them to bring it before God in repentance and, where appropriate, point them to one of the elders. If necessary, you can seek clarity yourself — there are several channels through which a person can be brought through to victory and freedom.

Supporting Scripture —
1 John 1:9, James 5:16,
2 Corinthians 10:3-5,
1 Corinthians 10:13, Hebrews 4:15-16

WEEK 2 **Doctrine:** Justification **Week Theme:** In Him

This week, we move from salvation to justification. We will be exploring justification both this week and next. The important truth you will want to make sure the disciple has grasped is that everything we will explore happens instantaneously when we come to salvation and is achieved not by our own works or effort but simply by the grace of God. The goal is to choose to live our lives based on what we now know to be true. Imagine that you suddenly found out you had a billion dollars deposited into your account — the way you saw your life and the problems you faced would change even if you had never actually seen the cash itself! Just knowing that truth would change everything. Justification is an even more amazing truth that should transform the way every believer thinks. In this week, we explore five different elements to this new identity we have received.

We are chosen (Ephesians 1:4)
We are redeemed (Ephesians 1:7)
We are marked (Ephesians 1:13)
We are built up (Ephesians 2:21)
We can approach God (Ephesians 3:12)

Each day focuses on one of these truths and unpacks the reality of what they mean for us. For the disciple, some of these may be easier to apply and believe than others. The key to this week will be to celebrate and to help them embrace those they find easier and then help them dismantle the roadblocks for the ones they find more difficult. Along with this, each of these five truths will have a direct impact on how they live and so through the questions, help them explore what this looks like in their own context. Remember to check in specifically with the daily challenges — you may want to chat around the challenge from day 1 in more detail:

"You may struggle with the truth that you are "chosen" especially if you have faced rejection or hurt. If you find this difficult, spend some time asking the Holy Spirit to give you a revelation deep in your soul so that the truth moves from your head to your heart. God will respond and will show you what it means for you to be chosen in love by him."

This would be a great thing to spend time together praying over and asking God to help the disciple embrace the truth that they are "chosen" and that they have been sealed with the Holy Spirit (day 3).

WEEK 2, DAY 1

1. How do you feel knowing you have been "chosen" by God?

I remember when we used to play as little children how it felt when I was chosen to be on a particular team — the sense of value and importance which filled me. You could ask the disciple if he can recall a similar moment in his life. To know that you have been chosen by the God of all creation must help to affirm and settle your sense of value — you are valuable in God's eyes. Not just because he designed and created you, not just because you are his image bearer but also because he desires to reveal his glory through you.

Supporting Scripture —
John 15:16, Galatians 1:5, Ephesians 1:4-5

2. What are the implications for your spiritual journey knowing you are "chosen?"

If the previous question was one of value, then this is one of purpose. While salvation is a wonderful gift to us and we live in the confidence of an eternal security, God has a task for us in this world. At the most foundational level, God calls us to exercise the gifts / talents he has placed within us for the benefit of the body (the Church). Challenge the disciple to engage in community by serving on one of the many volunteer teams (crews) that are a crucial part of our gathering.

Supporting Scripture —
1 Peter 4:10, Romans 12:3-8, 1 Corinthians 12:4-7

3. How does being "chosen" change how you see your spiritual brothers and sisters in Christ?

At the very least, the disciple should be able to see all people — regardless of caste, color, or creed — as being made in God's image and carrying huge potential. But when it comes to fellow believers, it should inspire a sense of shared purpose /mission. Help the disciple see that they are part of something bigger than any one person. Keeping in mind that the disciple is a recipient of grace, it must challenge them to extend grace to others and to recognize that we are all imperfect but chosen by God to function together for his glory.

Supporting Scripture —
Colossians 3:12, Romans 8:28, Ephesians 4:1-4

WEEK 2, DAY 2

1. What does redemption mean to you?

Redemption is such a big, rich, freeing, life-giving word. Allow time for the disciple to express what it really means to him. The message for today highlights the fact that we are "in him" — this doesn't just mean that salvation has been placed in our hands but more importantly, that we have been placed in Jesus' hands. This must also mean that we no longer belong to ourselves and, as such, must live for the pleasure of the one who rescued us from our slavery to sin.

Supporting Scripture —
Galatians 2:20, Titus 2:14, 1 Corinthians 6:20

2. Are there areas of your life that stop you from embracing the truth that you are fully redeemed? If so, what are they?

Something that we can struggle with is that we don't always "feel" redeemed. Some of the same old habits and weaknesses continue to remain a part of us. Remind the disciple that being redeemed is now a heavenly reality — it is how God views us. How we respond to this remarkable gift is explored fully in the next question. However, help the disciple to think through this — redemption is not merely a matter of how I "feel" (though there is a joy and excitement that can overtake us when we give our lives to Jesus) but rather a truth that we cling onto in faith.

Supporting Scripture —
Hebrews 9:12, Ephesians 1:13-14

3. How does being redeemed change your life?

Being redeemed is just the first step of a journey that culminates with Jesus (either his return or us joining him at the end of our lives). There is another part to the redemption story — that is, for the rest of our lives, we cooperate with God in the work of transformation. We are being transformed. In six months time, I want to look back at

my life and see how I have changed / grown. The same is true even if I gave my life to Jesus twenty years ago. This process is never complete until Jesus returns or I go to be with him. While redemption is entirely an act of grace requiring no effort from us, transformation needs effort on our part. Encourage the disciple to take an honest look at his own life and see where he needs to allow God to bring changes and make them more Christ-like.

Supporting Scripture —
Ephesians 2:8-9, Romans 8:29-30, 1 Timothy 4:7

WEEK 2, DAY 3

1. Out of the four areas that being sealed in the Holy Spirit confirms, which area resonates most with you? And why?

While one of these may hold a greater significance to a disciple, all of them are equally true. This is a moment of celebration and thanksgiving. The wonderful gift of God, the Holy Spirit and his presence, is a guarantee — this means that all the promises of God for us in Jesus are surely available to us.

Supporting Scripture —
Ephesians 1:14

2. Which area do you find hardest to believe? And why?

Our past experiences will almost certainly color the way in which we receive these truths.For someone who grew up in an abusive environment, the truth of security can be a difficult one to grasp. As they wrestle with these four areas, be alert to things in the disciple's past that may surface and help them to prayerfully deal with and surrender those to God. Wonderfully, we are no longer under the sway of sin and can walk in the power and freedom available to us through the indwelling Holy Spirit.

Supporting Scripture —
Romans 5:1-2, 2 Corinthians 5:17-21

3. How does knowing that you are sealed with the Holy Spirit change how you live out your faith?

This is a great place to help the disciple see that our Christian journey is a progressive one. When the Holy Spirit comes to live in us, there is evidence of it — these are the fruit of the spirit; love, joy, peace, patience, etc. Every believer's life is intended to be marked by the fruit they bear, but fruit takes time to grow. The Holy Spirit begins a work of transforming our character and we should see these fruits appear as we become increasingly more like Jesus.

Supporting Scripture —
Galatians 5:22-23, 2 Corinthians 3:18

WEEK 2, DAY 4

1. What does it mean for you to know that you are God's holy temple?

Think about it — the God of all creation, the one who put the stars into place and created galaxies, the one who designed and created you, wants to take up residence in you. This must be a humbling thought and cause us to look at ourselves and our lives carefully to make sure that he is a welcome and honored guest. Knowing this, we make every effort to keep the temple clean. With help from the Holy Spirit, we remove ungodly things in our lives that mar our relationship with God. There is meant to be an easy ebb and flow to our conversation and walk with God but it is strained when sin remains a dominant

part of our lives. Common evidence of this is found in those areas that we feel shame about or seek to hide.

Help the disciple see that we don't aim for perfection but, instead, actively seek to grow in our walk with God and persist through confession and prayer to gain victory in areas of life that still succumb to the effect of sin.

Supporting Scripture —
Romans 8:11, Galatians 5:16, Titus 2:11-14

2. What are the patterns of thoughts, actions, or attitudes in your life that pollute his temple?

This is an extension of the previous question and by now, your disciple should be feeling stirred to see how they can walk faithfully as a child of God. Encourage the disciple to explore his relationship with God — are there any areas of sin, shame, or guilt that they feel can hinder it? Where there is a serious ongoing issue, point them to an elder in church for further conversation. If you, as a mentor, are uncertain of how to deal with something, you too should communicate with an elder and seek guidance.

Supporting Scripture —
2 Corinthians 7:1, 1 Thessalonians 4:7, Proverbs 28:13

3. How does knowing that God dwells within you change how you approach difficult times in your life?

Loneliness and isolation are such terrible things to deal with and are even worse when we are faced with one of the many challenges of life. Whether it is in making key life decisions, struggling with a failing marriage, battling financial insecurity, or worse, isn't it wonderful to know that you will never ever be alone again?! Not only is it good to know that God will always be with us but he has now put us into a family that we can draw from. There is a collective wisdom and experience in the church, those who have come through similar situations in victory that we can now draw from. This is not just the wisdom of the world but, rather, something that is deeply rooted in the truth of God's word.

Challenge the disciple to see those areas of their lives in which they have victory and can encourage someone else. Perhaps they have an area in their lives where someone else from the body can guide them. Encourage them to draw from the pool of God's wisdom so often presented in the words of ordinary men and women in the church.

Supporting Scripture —
James 1:5, Proverbs 12:15, Proverbs 11:14, 2 Timothy 3:16-17

WEEK 2, DAY 5

1. What are the things in your life that make you feel like you can't approach God?

This is an opportunity to help the disciple embrace the reality of what God has done for us in Christ Jesus. In his work on the cross, Jesus has offered up his life once for all — we do not need to make regular sacrifices for sin anymore. Instead, we offer sacrifices of praise from grateful hearts. To feel that we can't approach God now is to fail to recognize the full extent of the power of the cross. In one sense, at least it is to say that there are some sins too great to be dealt with by the cross or the sacrifice of Jesus — which is clearly not what we see in scripture.

Supporting Scripture —
Romans 8:35-39, Hebrews 7:27, Hebrews 10:19-25

2. What does it mean to you to know that when God looks at you, he sees Christ's righteousness?

The universal need of every human being is to be rescued from our sin, whether we recognize it or not. To know that God sees me through the righteousness of Christ is to know that my sins have been forgiven. It is a reason for gratitude and joy. Moreover, it means that we now live in such a way as to reflect that new status of having been rescued. Sin rejects and rebels against God. Now that we, through faith, have received Jesus as Lord and Savior, now that we are washed of guilt, we submit our lives to the ongoing work of sanctification by the Holy Spirit. Challenge the disciple to prayerfully see those areas of life that need to be submitted to God. We walk in a way that our desire for the things of God overtake our desire for the things of the flesh.

Supporting Scripture —
2 Corinthians 5:21, Galatians 5:25, Ephesians 2:5,10

3. What does being able to approach God mean to you?

To know that we can approach God because of what was accomplished for us through Jesus on the cross should give us a sense of confidence and joy. It should also stir in us a greater desire for holiness as we gaze upon him. When we fail, it reminds us that we can approach him as we are with our deepest darkest secrets knowing that God is able to cleanse us and keep us on the journey of making us more like Jesus.

Supporting Scripture —
Hebrews 4:16, James 4:8, Jeremiah 29:13, Ephesians 2:13

WEEK 3 **Doctrine:** Justification **Week Theme:** Transformed by Grace

In week 3, we carry on exploring the work of justification in the believers life. We will do this by building on the foundation established last week of the five "in him" sayings found in Ephesians. To do this we will unpack the amazing gift of grace that God has given us and Paul spends most of chapter 2 exploring. Many of us believe that when we come to Jesus, we have to bring something "to the table" and yet all he asks for us is to trust and obey him. This is such a radical message for a world that is so used to assigning worth and value only based on what you can give or do — but grace is the unmerited favor of God. Understanding this is important, so you may need to affirm this truth again and again. Once we realize and acknowledge the wondrous truth of God's grace, we must allow it to transform our lives both in how we see ourselves and how we relate to others.

There are two main challenges we are asking the disciple to process this week. The first is on day 2:

"If you haven't been baptized yet but have put your trust in God's saving grace, don't wait any longer to be baptized. This would be a great thing to chat through with your mentor, Connect Leader, or an elder."

Baptism is simply the outward sign of an inward grace. It is an important step for every believer to go through as they declare to the world the truth that the old person has died and that they are now a new creation. If the disciple hasn't been baptized, this would be an important step to talk through with them and either their Connect Leader or a leader they feel close to (maybe you?).

The second key challenge to draw the disciple's attention to is on day 5:

"Spend some time this week working through the key aspects of your salvation and what justification means according to the Bible. If need be, discuss this with your mentor to get some more insight. Make sure you establish a solid foundation of understanding your identity before moving on. This week, spend some time thanking God for what your salvation means, and for what his freely given grace has done in your life."

This will provide a good opportunity to review the last three weeks and to make sure they have grasped the key components of their salvation and justification.

WEEK 3, DAY 1

1. Do you struggle to accept God's grace in your life? If so, why?

The world we live in demands that we work hard to earn money, status, or to move forward in our chosen careers. While not necessarily a bad thing, it can overflow into our spiritual journey and prevent us from seeing and receiving the fulness of God's grace.

In many ways, the kingdom of God is contrary to the world. There is nothing we can do to earn his grace; it is given freely, and we just have to accept it. We cannot fully comprehend his grace but an appropriate metaphor would be comparing it to the unconditional love that caring parents show toward their children — no matter what their child

does, they will always love and accept them as their child. A newborn baby has done nothing to receive this unconditional love and acceptance but merely accepts it. Similarly, we must learn to receive our heavenly Father's love but so often our own pride can be a hindrance to this — we want to be self-sufficient and not depend on someone else. Another hindrance to this can be if we have not experienced the kind of grace and love that God offers from our earthly parents. These can be some of the challenges the disciple faces. Help the disciple explore this and pray through those things in their lives that may hinder them from experiencing the richness of God's grace.

Supporting Scripture —
Titus 2:11-12, Hebrews 4:16, 2 Timothy 1:9

2. Do you in some way think "I deserve to be forgiven" or have you come to see how dead / lost you were because of your sin?

One thing is very clear in scripture — we have all sinned and none of us are exempt. Any sense of entitlement around forgiveness stems from not seeing the extent of our sin and rebellion against God. To think that any of us "deserve" forgiveness is, in itself, an act of pride and is sinful.

If this disciple struggles with this, point them back to the previous question - our forgiveness is entirely an act of grace by God. Pride must be softened to realize that we are lost / dead without Him and deserve only wrath. In love, he made a way for us to be forgiven and reconciled through Jesus.

Supporting Scripture —
Ephesians 4:21-22, Acts 4:12 (see also references above)

3. How does God's grace change how you see who you are?

"You're useless, you're so stupid, you're so foolish, you'll never amount to anything" — I've heard parents say these words over their children many times and today, as adults, they are still held captive by them. Perhaps there are similar expressions that the disciple battles with. Help them to see that God's grace and redemption speak something different over their lives. It speaks of value and worth, of plans and purposes. Remind them of what they have already learned — they are dearly loved, utterly forgiven, fully accepted children of God.

Supporting Scripture —
Psalm 139:13, Jeremiah 29:11

WEEK 3, DAY 2

1. What does this new life in Jesus look like for you?

Perhaps the first and most obvious change is that we begin to see life from a new perspective. No longer are we motivated by the temporal but rather the eternal. This can be something hard to grasp for a very new / young disciple. At this stage, help them see that we are meant to bring God pleasure and glory in all that we do. The desire to bring him glory must influence every area of our lives; in church, the workplace or school, the way we love our family, the way we manage our finances — all must be done with a view to bringing God glory.

Life has an eternal purpose in Him; decisions and actions that we make and carry out are influenced by this. We may not get it right all the time but our heart attitude is different than before and we want to honor Him in all that we do. Encourage the disciple to prayerfully invite the Holy Spirit to reveal to him / her God's forgiveness and the fullness of their new life!

Supporting Scripture —
John 15:1-17

2. What are the things in your "former life" you need to leave behind?

God sees the heart, intentions, and motives that others may not see. Giving your life to him does not mean that things are necessarily going to change in an instant but what matters is your heart's desires and the steps that you take to leave behind those former things that you already know do not honor or please him. We come to God as we are — he already knows the deepest and darkest parts of our lives and he waits with open arms to help us overcome. Perhaps there are things that God is already stirring in the disciple — create an open and trusting atmosphere in which to discuss these and help the disciple lay them before God.

If there is a struggle to overcome habitual sin, a battle with unforgiveness or past actions that need to be dealt with, pray through those and encourage them to seek counsel from an elder.

Supporting Scripture —
Galatians 5:16-25, 2 Corinthians 5:17

3. What are some of the things that hold you back from experiencing the full life that Jesus has made available to you?

Perhaps the first step here will be to help the disciple understand what life in Jesus is not; it is not a life free from all trouble, it is not a life lacking challenge and difficulty. In fact, the opposite of this is true — in this world, we will have trouble.

The greatest hindrance to a full life is that we try to determine what that should look like. But God calls us to see that a full life is one full of purpose and meaning — not our own purposes and meaning but God's. In short, our own narrow perspective can be the greatest hindrance to experiencing a full life. A life of seeking purpose and meaning in the pursuit of pleasure and accolades from those around us can quickly lose meaning. A life spent pursuing God and his purposes leads to fulfillment in this world and for eternity.

Supporting Scripture —
Hebrews 12:1, 1 Corinthians 9:24-27

WEEK 3, DAY 3

1. Are the people in your life, who you spend time with, reflecting the diversity of God's kingdom or are they people just like you?

As humans, we are naturally drawn to what is familiar and comfortable, we prefer when people agree with our opinions and viewpoints, we like it when it is easy to refer to familiar cultural aspects and therefore, we tend to gravitate towards people who are like us. However, God wants us to accept and receive into our lives those who are different to us. There may be minority groups who feel isolated within our wider communities and he wants us to draw them in — his desire is that no one in his kingdom live alone. Jesus was a great example of seeking out those that were "different" to him, even those that he "wasn't supposed" to spend time with. His love for them transformed their lives and the lives of those around them.

This is a significant challenge to the disciple — to see the beauty, creativity, and diversity of God in all people and to receive them is to demonstrate something countercultural to the world around us. When they see that all people can be a part of this kingdom, that it is not reserved for an elite few, it serves to bring peace to us, because we too will never be excluded.

Supporting Scripture —
Psalm 104:24, Revelations 7:9

2. Who are the people you allow to remain behind a wall of hostility?

This question can have profound implications — perhaps someone has been affected by abuse, racial or religious discrimination, sometimes even their socio-economic circumstances may have been held against them. If someone has been exposed to this kind of environment, particularly at a young age, it can leave deep and lasting scars.

It would not be unusual to build a defensive wall of hostility in such circumstances. This is a place to remind the disciple that God is able to heal and bring about forgiveness. Allow the disciple to explore any feelings of bitterness that may be in their hearts and bring it before God. Where there is a difficulty in breaking away from unforgiveness, perhaps some deeper and more intentional counseling might be necessary.

Supporting Scripture —
Matthew 6:14, Colossians 3:13, Matthew 18:21-22

3. Do you find yourself discriminating against others for any reason?

This is simply to look at the previous question from the other side. If we are honest with ourselves, we will admit that consciously or unconsciously we all tend to "measure" people through the lenses of race, caste, education, social economic status, etc. and avoid or neglect some. Any form of discrimination is a heart attitude and the disciple would need to ask God to help see others the way that he does.

Remind the disciple of how God, in love and forgiveness, made a way for us to be adopted into his family. This is an exercise in humility — to know that all people carry the image of God and we should learn to accept and love them. Challenge them to bring it before God and take practical steps to avoid discrimination. This could be as simple an exercise as deliberately befriending someone that they would usually avoid or neglect.

Supporting Scripture —
1 Corinthians 12:13, 1 John 2:11, 1 Timothy 5:21

WEEK 3, DAY 4

1. Do you see yourself as part of God's family? If so, why? If not, why not?

Some people find it quite easy to see themselves as a part of God's family. Perhaps they have had a healthy family life as they were growing up and, as such, it is easy to relate to the idea of family. For some outgoing and extroverted people, fitting into a community comes easily and they can joyfully embrace the spiritual family. For some, it is more difficult and these are the ones that will need caring guidance. For a disciple coming from a broken home or one with an abusive or domineering father, the model of family is twisted. They will find the metaphor of family a hard one to grasp or fit into.

Help your disciple see that despite the weaknesses and failures that an earthly father may have, our heavenly Father is perfect and lovingly invites us to be a part of his family. Even our spiritual family consists of other, inherently flawed people just like us whom God has adopted. As such, it is not yet perfect but it is certainly redeemed and God continues to work in and through his family — the church.

Supporting Scripture —
Psalm 58:5-6, Romans 8:16-17, Ephesians 1:5

2. How can you seek to foster a culture of community and family?

This is one of the most practical areas of our journey. It is the challenge to explore the gift that God has placed in us and to use it effectively. Everyone has a gift — a particular ability or disposition that is designed to serve and minister to the larger body. Many look at the more visible gifts (preaching, leading a small group, leading worship, playing an instrument, etc) and feel that their contribution is not important. Help the disciple see that everyone has a role to play in the body and that faithfulness in the little things often lead to greater responsibility.

If the disciple is uncertain of the gift they carry, that's fine. It is an exploratory journey that is exciting. The best way is to just jump in and see where they find energy and traction. Encourage the disciple to join a crew or ministry team to begin with and see what God does from there.

Supporting Scripture —
1 Corinthians 1:10, 1 John 1:7, Romans 12:5, Hebrews 10:24-25

3. What are the things that hinder you from experiencing the fullness of God's family?

Though it may not appear so on the surface, this question can lead the disciple to share some deep-rooted fears. This can range from a sense of inadequacy / inferiority to simple shyness. Encourage them to step in and participate — the best way to experience the fullness of the family is to be engaged! Encourage them not to be mere spectators in church or just looking to feed and leave. Getting to know others and doing life together opens up a vast, multi-faceted community to everyone and we get to share our story and hear that of others. These moments can be greatly encouraging and uplifting.

Supporting Scripture —
Acts 2:44-47, Romans 12:3-13

WEEK 3, DAY 5

1. Have you fully grasped the nature of your new identity and that, through salvation, you have been "born again" of the Spirit?

This might be a little difficult for a new believer or the disciple to express — it is an understanding of our position and our status. It is to know that positionally, we are in Christ Jesus; we are a part of him and are meant to become more like him as we grow and allow the Holy Spirit to transform us. Our status is that we are declared holy and righteous in the eyes of God. It may not feel like that to us but it is a spiritual reality that we grow into in increasing measure as we become more Christ-like.

Supporting Scripture —
2 Corinthians 5:17, Isaiah 43:18-19, Romans 8:18-21

2. What difference does the fact that you are a new creation and viewed by God as being holy make for you? What will you now do in order to live your life differently?

Many people misunderstand holiness to be an outward expression of piety — like wearing white clothes or avoiding jewelry. But holiness has a very practical expression. To be holy means two fundamental things: to be sanctified and made clean as well as set apart for a specific purpose. This means that our holiness is seen in how distinct we are from those around us — our desires and passions are not for the things of this

world, but rather those of another kingdom and we live with a sense of purpose to glorify God and honor him in all that we do.

Supporting Scripture —
1 Peter 1:14

3. Do you know the difference between living according to the flesh (your old self) and living by the Spirit (your new man)?

The easiest way to answer this question is to look at our motives — is my desire for personal gratification or for God's glory? The Holy Spirit always points us to Jesus and if we are to be led by the Holy Spirit, it must mean that the way we live our life points to Jesus. In writing to the Galatian church (see supporting scripture below), Paul mentions four evidences of being led by the Spirit: walk by the Spirit, be led by the Spirit, bear the fruit of the Spirit, and live by or keep in step with the Spirit. Challenge the disciple to explore these and how they are reflected in life.

Supporting Scripture —
Galatians 5:16-25, Romans 8:4

WEEK 4 **Doctrine:** Sanctification **Week Theme:** Worthy of the Call

Now that we have laid the foundation of salvation and justification, we will explore the process of sanctification for the next four weeks. This is the journey we go on to become more like Jesus. The key thing to remember is that sanctification isn't something we can do in our own strength, but is rather something the Holy Spirit does in us as we cooperate with him, surrendering more and more of ourselves to him. The process of sanctification reaches into every part of our lives. This week, we will explore some of the practical ways God calls us to grow and be changed in him. It is important to help the disciple relate it back to their own personal context — the challenges on days 2 and 5 should help them do that. Now you know the disciple better, spend some time in prayer for them over these challenges and asking God to reveal to you how you can support and guide them in these areas.

For the challenge in day 2, this will be an important time to get into specifics. Don't just allow generic answers but get to the root of what the disciple is seeking to surrender to God (note: in week 7, we will deal specifically with how to tackle strongholds so that can be left for now).

"Spend some time in prayer today asking the Holy Spirit to highlight to you the areas of your life that are not displaying the nature or virtues of Christ. Once he has done that, work through these by praying and surrendering them to God and choosing to pick up the alternative displayed in Christ. For example, if you have a problem with rage, surrender it to God and ask him to stir up in you self-control and peace."

Finally, in day 5, there is a great opportunity to help the disciple align themselves with kingdom values and not those of the world. Ask them for a couple examples of where in the past they have followed the world, the conviction that God has given them, and the changes they are seeking to make.

"Ask the Holy Spirit to show you what patterns of the world you've been following and surrender them as they are revealed. Set new habits that are informed by the kingdom values we've been exploring and invite the Holy Spirit to be the agent of change in these areas."

WEEK 4, DAY 1

1. How do you stay rooted in God's grace even as you strive for holiness?

So often, holiness is a matter of examining our choices in the light of scripture. Does a decision honor God? Does my life reflect Jesus? This is a deeply practical element of our faith. In fact, the grace of God enables us to reject those things that hinder us from growing in holiness. To be holy simply means that we are set apart for his service. Our holiness (or sanctification) is God's will for us — to remain in his grace is to look at Jesus and become more like him.

Supporting Scripture —
Titus 2:11-12, 1 Peter 1:13-16, 1 Thessalonians 4:3, 7

2. What are the areas that God is working on in you at the moment?

This might be a difficult question to answer. A new believer, they may not yet have reached that stage of self-examination; and even someone who has been a believer for a while does not enjoy looking inward and seeing those ugly parts of our character that need to be dealt with.

Help the disciple to be honest before God. Create a sense of space and freedom to ask questions. Be vulnerable yourself — perhaps an illustration from your own life will help the disciple know that this is not a place of judgment but an opportunity to grow. Examining ourselves often (not just this once) is a key element of our growth in holiness.

Supporting Scripture —
1 Corinthians 11:28, 2 Corinthians 13:5, Psalm 119:59

3. What are the things in your life that hinder that process?

This can lead to the exploration of many things in the past that you should certainly allow the disciple to explore but two things are worth mentioning here. There are two areas that can have a significant impact in our lives and seriously hinder our growth — unforgiveness and sexual immorality.

Gently help your disciple to see if there's anything from their past that needs to be dealt with. Where there is a deep rooted issue, you may find yourself pointing them to an elder for prayer and ministry or even encouraging them to be part of a course like "Freedom in Christ."

Supporting Scripture —
Hebrews 12:14-16, 1 John 1:9

WEEK 4, DAY 2

1. What are the "kingdom attitudes" you find difficult to embrace in your life and why?

It should not come as a surprise that, as much as we may dislike admitting it, all of us have something in our attitudes that need adjustment. This is where you need to help the disciple to identify those attitudes that need to be submitted to God. In Matthew chapter 5, we find Jesus teaching the crowds on a mountainside in a passage of scripture titled the Beatitudes. Someone once referred to them as the "be attitudes" and it is a helpful grid to identify those attitudes that must set us apart from the rest of the world.

Supporting Scripture —
Matthew 5:1-12

2. What are the "kingdom attitudes" that you find easy to embrace in your life and why?

There are some attitudes that can be easier than others — if you're an easy-going person then it is possible that patience will be an attitude that is a part of your character makeup. This is a wonderful moment to help the disciple find and celebrate those attitudes that are easy to adopt or already evident in their life. Again, you can use the same scripture above as a frame of reference.

Supporting Scripture —
Matthew 5:1-12

3. Today, what do you feel God is challenging you to "put on" and "put off?"

This is not just a list to compare the findings between the first two questions and tick them off. This is a moment to bring all those attitudes before God; celebrating the ones that reflect the kingdom and prayerfully seeking the

guidance of the Holy Spirit for the others.

If you continue to read the teaching of the beatitudes beyond the verses we have referred to above, you will see that there is an outcome of influence when we adopt kingdom attitudes. Challenge the disciple to see where his "new" attitude can serve to influence others and bring glory to God.

Supporting Scripture —
Matthew 5:13-16

WEEK 4, DAY 3

1. How does absolute truth shape the way you live? How does it shape your decisions?

In war, there are what's known as the "rules of engagement." They are a framework that determines — among other things — when, where, and how a soldier engages with the enemy. In this world, we are in a constant battle against the enemy of our souls and the word of God sets the rules of engagement in place for us. To grow in maturity is to be able to unhesitatingly trust in the word of God and apply it to all situations of life. The first step in allowing the truth of God's word to shape how we live is to study it and be familiar with it. A perfect illustration of this is found in the temptation of Jesus — when he was at the end of a long time of fasting and prayer, at his most vulnerable, he was tempted. His response to each scenario placed before him? "It is written."

Supporting Scripture —
Matthew 4:1-11, Psalm 119:9-11

2. What does it mean to live in unity with other Christians?

Help the disciple see that this is not unanimity, nor is it that we will be without conflict or disagreement. To live in unity with other Christians is to recognize that we, who were once far from God, have all been adopted into his family — we are now brothers and sisters with a heavenly Father.

In the context of absolute truth, this means that even when we are not in agreement, we can agree to allow the Bible to speak into the situation and resolve it in a way that brings honor and glory to our Father. We are in agreement that his word is, without exception, the final authority in our lives and supersedes our own opinions or thoughts.

Supporting Scripture —
2 Timothy 3:16-17, Hebrews 4:12-13

3. How can you plant the truth in your heart?

There is no shortcut for this. If we are to be guided by the word of God, we must be familiar with it. We must devote time to studying the word of God in a disciplined manner and allow it to inform the way in which we live. In addition to our personal study of the Bible, regular participation in church and small groups help to develop a trust in and healthy understanding of scripture.

Supporting Scripture —
Acts 2:42, Psalm 119:11-12, Joel 1:8

WEEK 4, DAY 4

1. How do you know that you are growing in Christlikeness?

This might be difficult for a new disciple to answer — for someone who has given their life to Jesus recently, the opportunity to grow and reflect Jesus is still in its infancy. What does it mean to look like Jesus? It means that we reflect his heart, his compassion, love, and care. We make his mission our mission — to carry the good news of God's kingdom and it's Savior King to the world. Even the youngest disciple should be challenged to

look at what this means in their life and how they live it out.

Some simple tests are to examine our love for God (how is your prayer life / are you reading his word?), our love for his community (are you engaged and involved in your church?), and how we love the those people around us (are we extending love, grace and forgiveness / are we looking to serve and demonstrate love?).

Supporting Scripture —
John 15:7-8, Acts 17:11, 2 Timothy 3:16-17, John 13:34

2. How can we support others in their walk with God?

One of the central themes of church life is that of mutual encouragement and growth. A kind word here, an expression of care there, or a helping hand to someone in need are all ways in which we can support others. Often, even just a few minutes spent listening and praying can be a source of great strength to someone going through a difficult season.

Supporting Scripture —
Romans 1:11-12, 15:2, 1 Thessalonians 5:11, Hebrews 10:24-25

3. What kind of service are we being equipped for?

God has chosen to use people as part of his strategy to advance the kingdom. This is a wonderful adventure that he calls us to. Not only does he call us but he equips each one of us for different roles. The disciple may not fully understand what their gift might be right now but you should assure them that God has given everyone a gift — nobody is left out.

Encourage the disciple to explore scripture and discover what gift God has given them. The key thing to remember is this, the gift is meant for the service of others.

Supporting Scripture —
Romans 12:4-5, 1 Peter 4:10

WEEK 4, DAY 5

1. In what ways are you still living in allegiance to your old way of life?

The text for today refers to the mind or the way of thinking as the source of our actions — we are urged not to walk as Gentiles do in the "futility of their thinking" and encouraged to be made new in the attitude of our minds. In other words, the old way of life had a lot to do with an old way of thinking. It's impossible to live a life of victory if we don't have a new mindset. The desire of the flesh is not entirely removed. For example, lusts are still alive and we get tempted but with the new man, we have a new mindset and a new determination to obey God. Now we should be driven by the Holy Spirit instead of our own desires. We're no longer slaves to sin but instead, God can use me to carry out his will, to resist the sin in my flesh.

As the disciple explores this question, there might be deep things that need to be addressed — lies and strongholds that hold them captive, habits that are hard to break. Prayerfully submit these to God and ask for victory.

Supporting Scripture —
Galatians 5:16, 25, James 4:7

2. What is hindering you from wholeheartedly pursuing God?

There are many answers that can arise here — feeling like we must "fix" ourselves first, difficulty relating to God as father, a sense of shame or past rejections. Perhaps even setting God as a low priority — "I'll attend church / do more / give more / spend time alone with God more after

I have finished my studies / get that promotion / send the kids off to university / reach my savings goal."

The key to this is helping the disciple take their eyes off themselves to see the "value" of God. Unless God is central to every aspect of our lives, there will always be something that hinders us. This is not a one-time exercise but a series of ongoing choices that we need to make. It is to recognize that God is not first and foremost because we make him a priority but rather that we make him a priority because he is already first and foremost.

Supporting Scripture —
Matthew 6:33, 13:44-46, 22:37-40, Ephesians 1:22-23

3. How do you actively put off your old self?

This question is already largely dealt with in the two that precede it. As a summary, it can be said that we do this by deliberately choosing God first and making him a priority in our lives. This means that God has first say in our marriage, how we raise our children, how we manage our finances, our work ethic, church life — he speaks into our entertainment, extra-curricular activities, what we read, and what we watch.

Ask the disciple to examine themselves honestly and bring those areas that are still not under the lordship of Jesus to him in prayer.

Supporting Scripture —
Refer to previous two questions / references.

WEEK 5 **Doctrine:** Sanctification **Week Theme:** Spirit-Filled Living

Drawing on the themes explored last week, we now move to look at how we can have a Spirit-filled life and the outcomes that come with that. This week is highly practical and for some, will present difficult choices as they seek to bring their lives into alignment with scripture. At the heart of this week is helping the disciple to learn how to use scripture to find answers to questions they may have as they seek to live Christ-like lives. It is important to remember that while every day may not directly line up with the context they find themselves in — for example, if they are single and the section is about marriage — it is still important for them to go through it as not only does it help establish important principles for their future, it also speaks more broadly into varying relationships we are in. You may need to help them to see the relevance of some of these sections.

The challenges this week will help the disciple to drill down on the practicalities of what Spirit-filled living should look like. In day 2 and 3, they focus specifically on marriage. For those who are not married, on day 3, ask them to spend time praying about how they can cultivate this virtue now before they get married. In both day 1 and day 4, we ask the disciple to specifically identify ways in which they either need to grow or allow the Holy Spirit to adjust their thinking. These will be important days for you to walk with the disciple and to help them unpack what they feel that God is saying to them.

Day 1's challenge sets the tone for the rest of the week, helping the disciple discover what is God's best for any specific topic. As you discuss this with them, you may wish to suggest other areas that would be relevant for them and help them walk through the stages of discovering God's will on it.

"Identify a specific area in your life that you are not walking in God's will and ways. This week, with the help of the Holy Spirit, actively make decisions, one by one, that reinforce his best for your life and are obedient to his ways."

Day 4 will be highly dependent on the kind of family / relationship they had growing up. For some, they will have a great example of what a father is; for others, this will be a difficult task and sensitivity will be needed helping them walk through it. The key here is allowing God alone to define our concept of father based on who he is, not our own personal experiences.

"If you have answered yes to any of the questions above, commit to talking to your mentor about them. Ask them to help you walk in forgiveness either towards those who have hurt you, or asking God to forgive you where you have failed to parent God's way."

WEEK 5, DAY 1

1. How can we seek God's will?

God is always speaking to us — most notably through his Son, Jesus, who is God's perfect revelation to us. There is a difference between finding the direction God wants us to take (calling, career,

ministry, etc) and finding out how he wants us to live. There are a myriad of different callings but God's will for HOW we are to live is the same for all of us: "But now you must be holy in everything you do, just as God who chose you is holy. For the Scriptures say, 'You must be holy because I am holy.'"(1 Peter 1:15-16)

God has revealed his nature through his incarnate Son and we are to live lives that imitate him in holiness, purity, and love. Whenever an area of our life or lifestyle contradicts the nature of God as revealed in scripture, we need to repent and invite the Holy Spirit to give us the grace / strength to live in accordance with God's will for us.

Supporting Scripture —
Ephesians 4:1 & 17-32,
Galatians 5:22-25

2. At the moment, what areas in your life are you needing to find out God's will for?

Here we should be asking the disciple if there are any areas in their lives where they are not sure (or no longer sure) whether they line up with God's will — for example, sexual sin, greed, gossip, lying, drunkenness, etc. Be careful not to lead them into legalism by allowing them to impose man made rules on their own lives. But equally, where there are areas of their lives where they are sinning, help them to see that this is not God's will and God wants their lifestyle to align with their new identity in Christ as a new creation.

Supporting Scripture —
Romans 6:20-23, Galatians 6:1

3. What other examples are there in the Bible of how we should live?

In Galatians 5:19-21, Paul lists examples of the "works of the flesh" and if any of these are evident in the disciple's life, we should invite them to repent and ask the Holy Spirit to help them overcome these areas: "sexual immorality, impurity, sensuality, idolatry, sorcery, enmity, strife, jealousy, fits of anger, rivalries, dissensions, divisions, envy, drunkenness, orgies, and things like these. I warn you, as I warned you before, that those who do such things will not inherit the kingdom of God."

So, for example, our lives should be marked by sexual purity: sexual activity limited to marriage, and as Hebrews 13:4 says, the marriage is kept pure — meaning an exclusive, lifelong monogamous relationship between husband and wife.
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WEEK 5, DAY 2

1. How should a husband handle conflict / disagreements in his marriage?

With the best interests of Christ and Christ's daughter (the wife) in mind. The motivation should be love and the husband should be the initiator in ensuring the conflicts are resolved. You may want to ask the disciple what was modeled for him / her in their own upbringing and how they need to adjust that model because of what God teaches us in Ephesians 5.

Supporting Scripture —
Ephesians 5:25-33

2. What does it mean to lead with sacrificial love?

It means to follow the example of Christ and move in the opposite spirit — where you are rejected, offer acceptance; where you are accused, speak life. It means offering grace as we have received grace, knowing that grace means we get what we don't deserve. It means believing that love is the most powerful agent of change in a person's life and that no act of love is ever wasted.

It must be noted that this is not the same as allowing ourselves to be abused or expecting someone to stay in an abusive situation! There is a line of respect that must be honored by both parties and to ignore that is enabling selfish and ultimately destructive behavior in our partner.

Supporting Scripture —
Ephesians 5:25-33, 1 Peter 3:7

3. How have unbiblical marriages you have seen in your life affect the way you see marriage?

God may want to heal the disciple of past trauma related to marriages they have been exposed to — don't hesitate to invite the Holy Spirit in to minister healing if that is the case. If the trauma is deep set, consider asking them to see a counselor.

Sometimes the "wrong examples" create an alternative narrative that is contrary to scripture. This may simply need to be rejected and for the disciple to allow their thinking to be renewed by time in the Word and around couples that model godly marriage.

Supporting Scripture —
1 Corinthians 11:1, Titus 2:7, 3 John 1:11

WEEK 5, DAY 3

1. What is the practical difference between submission and obedience?

Submission is voluntary and limited, whereas obedience can be seen as absolute. Husbands cannot demand submission but wives can choose to freely partner with their husbands by allowing them to lead. This submission between a husband and wife flows out of the idea of partnering in the divine mandate they are called to as a couple. Unlike the submission of children or slaves, the wife is a partner, whose voice God wants to be heard and talents used within the marriage so that the couple together can fulfil God's call upon them.

Supporting Scripture —
Philippians 1:8-9, 1 Corinthians 1:10

2. How does this play out in marital decision-making?

Practically speaking there will be times when important decisions will have to be made (of course, we are not talking about the many decisions that are made every day that either the husband or wife can make independently on behalf of the couple), and after taking account of the counsel of the wife, the husband is charged with the final responsibility for the decision. Submission means that the wife owns that decision and the consequences along with her husband.

Supporting Scripture —
1 Corinthians 7:4-5 (mutuality in marriage), Ephesians 5:28

3. Are there areas in your marriage that you are waiting for your spouse to "fulfill their role" before you fulfill yours?

Wives can often hold back showing respect and walking in submission until they are satisfied that the husband is loving like Christ. That's also true in the opposite, of course — husbands holding back love until their wives submit but neither is correct. Christ, although he is indisputably greater than those he died for, was the initiator in love and expects us, both husband and wife, to initiate. The husband by loving his wife and the wife by respecting her husband. If the spouse fails to fulfill their role, while that will be worth discussing and even seeking out counselors to help with, ultimately we need to take the attitude that our sacrifice is unto God before it's sown to our partner.

Supporting Scripture —
John 3:16 (God initiates), Romans 14:19, Ephesians 4:3

WEEK 5, DAY 4

1. Do you have thoughts or feelings about your heavenly Father, shaped by your upbringing, that do not line up with what the Bible says about him?

The disciple may have had a godly, kind, strong, and attentive father who will then help them see God being Father as a positive image. The opposite may be true if their father was vindictive, ungodly, absent or weak, they may have a very negative response to the image of God as a father.

It's worth noting that all our fathers are imperfect and for many of them, even though they did the best they thought, they fell short of the mark (Hebrews 12:10). But Hebrews goes on to contrast our imperfect fathers with God as the perfect father.

Supporting Scripture —
Galatians 4:6-7, Colossians 1:21-22, Hebrews 12:10

2. Are there areas from your upbringing that do not align with what the Bible says about parenting – perhaps even areas where you need the Holy Spirit to heal past wounds?

While this question overlaps with question 1, there is another aspect to it – woundedness and unforgiveness. Sometimes we have been so hurt by someone that we no longer act in a Christlike way when we are triggered. Instead, like someone who has a very painful toe, we overreact or react in an ungodly way when we feel that we will be hurt again. Obviously if this is the case, pray with the disciple, inviting the Holy Spirit to heal them, and also lead them in a prayer of forgiveness towards the person or people who hurt/failed them. If this feels more serious then something you can deal with, ask their permission and reach out to one of the elders. Also note this probably will come up in week 7: Strongholds.

Supporting Scripture —
Refer to question 1 above.

3. If you are a mother or father, are there any adjustments that you need the Spirit to make to help you parent like God the Father?

There may be areas that they are convicted about by the Holy Spirit and they know what to do but have just never done it! Encourage them to walk in obedience. If they realize they are missing the mark but are unsure how to make the adjustment, ask the Holy Spirit to bring to mind scriptures that can help them. Also point them to the online resources for this week's material.

Supporting Scripture —
Ezekiel 16:6-14, Hosea 11:4, Luke 15:11-32

WEEK 5, DAY 5

1. How can we practically live out these ideas in our workplaces?

Whether we are the employee or the employer, the "boss" or the subordinate, this text should challenge us to ask God what does Christ-like living look like at work? How can I, as an employee, honor your name and work with integrity and diligence so that the name of Christ is honored? How can I, as a boss, work in a way that demonstrates the love of Christ?

For the employee, that does not mean necessarily staying in a job we hate or

putting up with an abusive environment. In those situations, unless God has specifically called you to stay, then you should seek alternative employment. But, if the environment is fair, you should work with diligence for your wage and show honor and respect to those who employ you, recognizing that your work is an act of worship.

Supporting Scripture —
1 Corinthians 6:20, 1 Peter 2:19-23

2. What does servant-hearted leadership look like?

The employer needs to make sure they are paying fair wages and offering appropriate working conditions. Again, that does not mean overlooking lazy or incompetent work but it does mean treating even those employees as men and women created in the image of God and due respect. Help them to connect to their purpose even if that's not in your employ.

Supporting Scripture —
Proverbs 14:23, 1 Timothy 5:18

3. How can we lift up and celebrate the people around us?

There used to be quite a popular book called the One Minute Manager and in it was this wonderful advice: "Catch people doing something right." Contrary to some caricatures of God, that is what he is busy doing with us — it's a grace attitude. We should, in the same way, be looking for the good in those around us, calling out life at every opportunity. Sometimes the Holy Spirit will even give us words that encourage people we work with just at the moment they need it the most.

Supporting Scripture —
Deuteronomy 3:28, Romans 12:8, 1 Thessalonians 4:18 & 5:11

WEEK 6 **Doctrine:** Sanctification **Week Theme:** Spiritual Warfare

This week, we move onto a subject that has led to some controversy both within and outside of the church — spiritual warfare. At one end of the spectrum, any real concept of the devil and his work has been totally denied and at the other end, there is the belief that everything that doesn't go our way is the work of the devil and his minions. This week, we want to bring the disciple to be able to see the spiritual reality of the battle we find ourselves in and to learn how to activate the armor God has given us to stand strong and to be triumphant. Depending on where the disciple has come from, you will need to help them process the week differently. Two great challenges this week are on day 1 and 2:

Day 1 will help them identify areas in their life in which they are more vulnerable. This will also be important for next week when we deal with strongholds.

"Identify the areas in which you are naturally more vulnerable to attack and actively pray against the lies of the enemy, calling them by name. Half the battle is being able to call the enemy on his bluff and rebuking his tactics by proclaiming God's truth over the situation."

Day 2 presents a great opportunity to start activating some areas you have been exploring together up to this point. It will be important to hold them accountable to this challenge and provide space for them to give feedback about their experience.

"Share the gospel with at least one person this week. Tell them the story of how you found new life in Christ and about the hope, peace, and purpose that you have found in him. Look back over week 1 to explore the steps to salvation."

If questions come up from this week, especially around the spiritual world, "Bondage Breaker" by Neil T. Anderson has an excellent section that helps explain more.

WEEK 6, DAY 1

1. How does the reality of spiritual warfare change the way you interact with the world?

This conversation may be very unfamiliar for the disciple especially if they have come from a very secular, western background. In that case you may need to spend some time talking about the reality of the spiritual dimension that is invisible to us but very real.

On the other hand, the disciple may have a great deal of past experience with the spiritual dimension either through spiritualism (such as occultic activities) or other religions such as Buddhism. In this case, it is worth ensuring that they understand that the spiritual realm is not neutral — there are the spiritual forces God deploys to accomplish his purposes and those who, with Satan, rebelled against God and are actively working against God's will and God's people.

Supporting Scripture —
Daniel 10:4-14 (especially v13), 1 Peter 5:8-9, Jude 1:9

2. What are some of the ways you have experienced a spiritual attack in your own life?

Believers will suffer the consequences of bad choices because of the wickedness of others, or because of "accidents" in a fallen world. When that happens, we may need to repent or ask God for grace to endure and overcome. Sometimes, however, we can discern that the resistance or attack we are suffering is different — maybe there is an unusual pattern or no matter how sincerely we repent, the temptation endures and overwhelms. Sometimes we sense because of nightmares or because God "tells us" that the source of the attack is spiritual.

As the disciple discusses possible areas where they felt they have endured a spiritual attack, help them to discern if that is the case or not. As you discuss this topic, be careful that the disciple does not become fearful or overly interested in the demonic realm. As CS Lewis warns: "There are two equal and opposite errors into which our race can fall about the devils. One is to disbelieve in their existence. The other is to believe and to feel an excessive and unhealthy interest in them."

Supporting Scripture —
1 Thessalonians 2:18, 2 Corinthians 12:7, 1 Peter 5:8-9

3. What difference does it make that Christ has already won the victory?

It is absolutely essential that the disciple walk in a revelation of Christ's victory. As Colossians 2:15 triumphantly declares: Jesus disarmed the spiritual rulers and authorities. He shamed them publicly by his victory over them on the cross.

And that victory is ours IN CHRIST. As we live our lives in submission to Jesus, the enemy should be regarded as powerless because Jesus has already defeated him. The disciple should feel courage instead of fear, hope instead of despair, and gratitude to Jesus for all he has done for us in rescuing us from our wicked slave master.

Supporting Scripture —
Romans 6:18 & 8:37-39, Colossians 2:20

WEEK 6, DAY 2

1. How can we put on the armor of God?

Sometimes we can become very impractical in our Christian walk. The disciple must not be allowed to think that putting on the armor is a picture instead of a practice. These items of armor are spiritual realities that we need to lay hold of each day, in the same way that we put on the various items of our clothing each morning. I am righteous in Christ because of his finished work on the cross — breastplate on! When the enemy tries to pierce my heart with temptation, beat your "breastplate" and easily reject those attacks that contradict the truth.

Supporting Scripture —
1 Peter 5:8-9

2. In what way is Christ's righteousness protection against the enemy's attacks?

Remember that the enemy loves to attack our identity in and intimacy with God. The fact that God gives believers the same righteous status as his own Son means that those attacks should be unable to penetrate our hearts. Whereas Adam hid in shame, when we sin, we can come to

God knowing that he will always forgive us when we repent. So you need to help the disciple see that this permanent status, based on the finished work of Christ, means that the devil can never undermine our identity as sons or our intimacy with God unless we let him.

Supporting Scripture —
2 Corinthians 5:21, 1 John 1:9

3. How can we make sure we're always ready to share the gospel?

The gospel is good news! Invite the disciple to cultivate an excitement about how good that news is and what a privilege it is that someone who has just been saved immediately becomes an ambassador of the gospel. Also, remind them that the enemy will come at them telling them that they are not worthy to tell others about Jesus when they are not yet perfect. Thankfully, it's in God's mercy, not our qualifying lifestyle, that we are given this ministry of reconciliation. So encourage them to get out there and tell all about our amazing savior and the scandalous gospel of grace.

Supporting Scripture —
Romans 10:14-15, 2 Corinthians 5:20, 1 Timothy 1:15-16

WEEK 6, DAY 3

1. Why is it important to have all six pieces of the armor of God?

Obviously help the disciple to not become legalistic about the armor. In 1 Thessalonians 5:8, the same author Paul, speaks about putting on "faith and love as a breastplate." That said, if the disciple has a revelation of the items described in Ephesians 6, they will not only be able to protect themselves from the enemy's attacks but also do damage to the kingdom of darkness.

Supporting Scripture —
1 Peter 5:8-9

2. What habits can you form to make this armor an extension of yourself?

Regular reading and meditating on scripture. Asking the Holy Spirit to help you truly receive these truths so that they move from head knowledge to revelation.

Supporting Scripture —
Psalms 1:1-3, Psalms 119:14-16, Matthew 26:14

3. Do you remember our deep dive into our new identity in Christ and its implications - well how can you continually keep that in your mind to serve as a helmet protecting you from the enemy's "identity attacks"?

In the Old Testament we see many heroes of the faith building altars after particular encounters with God, especially when he revealed something about his nature. The idea was that later when they saw these altars or memorials they would be reminded of God's great victory. The New Covenant believer must do a similar thing — reminding themselves frequently of what Jesus has done and what it means. Recognizing that because of what Christ has done, we are MORE THAN conquerors. That way, when the enemy comes to try to confuse or intimidate, us our helmet of salvation will protect us.

Supporting Scripture —
Proverbs 29:18, Ezekiel 33:7, Matthew 18:7-9

WEEK 6, DAY 4

1. What are some of the ways in which you have felt led to pray for someone for something specific?

Obviously, this will be different for each person. If the disciple says that they have not had such a leading yet, discuss with them some of the trials and challenges facing people around them such as family, friends, or work colleagues. Ask them if they believe God wants to intervene in these situations, even using them to reveal himself to them if they are not believers. Challenge the disciple to be an instrument of God's grace flowing into their lives. If they are unsure how to pray, help them by sharing some examples of situations you have prayed into.

Supporting Scripture —
1 Thessalonians 5:25, Philippians 1:19, 1 Timothy 2:1-4

2. Why is it important to pray with other believers?

Many new believers are reluctant to pray out loud because they don't think they can pray properly. Gathered prayer is not only mentioned frequently in the scriptures, but it is also the place where we, as new believers, learn to pray. Encourage the disciple to be part of gathered church moments and immerse themselves in this prayer school so that their own prayers will grow deeper, stronger, and more fervent.

Encourage them also with the fact that Jesus told us we are not heard for our many (and eloquent) words, but because we come in simple faith.

Supporting Scripture —
Acts 12:5, Matthew 6:7

3. How can we follow the Spirit's leading in prayer?

Listen. Remind the disciple that the Holy Spirit was sent by Jesus to guide us in our spiritual walk. He is speaking and if we will open our spiritual "ears," he will speak to us through impressions in our spirit or through a scripture we are reading. Remind the disciple that God will never lead us to pray anything contrary to what the Bible says.

Supporting Scripture —
1 Corinthians 2:10-13

WEEK 6, DAY 5

1. How can you see past your current situation or trial to focus on your calling to proclaim the gospel?

Remind the disciple of the lessons learnt in day 1 of this week — that there is a spiritual world that, although invisible, is real. Sometimes we can get so focused on the "real world" of our day to day hassles and problems that we forget the cosmic battle that is being fought for the souls of men and women.

There is probably no better way than spending time in God's presence, worshiping him, and studying his word to remind us of what is real and what is important. Isaiah went into God's presence feeling discouraged but as he worshipped God, he saw him as he actually is — the Lord God almighty — and this became a powerful "sending" moment.

Supporting Scripture —
Isaiah 6:1-8, Hebrews 11:32-12:2

2. How often do you pray for deliverance from hard times instead of for God to use them for his gospel purposes?

If the disciple is honest, he / she may say that they actually are trying as hard as possible to avoid hard times. And that makes sense — nobody wants to suffer unnecessarily. Remind them, though, that if we can find ourselves stuck in a moment as we try over and over to change our circumstances, we might be missing an opportunity. The Lord may be inviting them

to put their trial "on the altar" and say to him "God use this for your glory!" As Paul said, God turns all things to the good of those who love him and are called according to his purpose.

Supporting Scripture —
Romans 8:28, James 1:2

3. What does being an "ambassador in chains" look like for you in your current context?

Help the disciple to see the contradiction in this term — "ambassador" is a position of great importance and even power, while "in chains" implies restriction and powerlessness.

Encourage the disciple to see the honor of being called to be an ambassador, not for some temporary nation, but for the eternal King. There should be a sense of gratitude and privilege. But, like Christ, that honor is hidden beneath a veil of flesh, as we willingly lay down our rights and passions so that his will would be done in and through us.

Supporting Scripture —
2 Corinthians 5:20, Hebrews 10:32-34, 1 John 3:16

WEEK 7 **Doctrine:** Sanctification **Week Theme:** Strongholds

Last week, we laid a foundation about the reality of the spiritual battle Christians face. Now we complete our final week on sanctification by looking at some of the spiritual attacks that hinder us from walking in the fullness of life that God has for us. This is an important week for the disciple — when we are bold and deal with the strongholds that can form in our lives, only then can we experience the total freedom Christ won for us. You may wish to check in on a daily basis throughout this week as the disciple processes first the discovery of how strongholds can form in our lives, and then walks through the process of dismantling them.

On day 2, as a part of the reflection questions, we ask the disciple to work through a series of questions that help highlight scenarios that could have resulted in Satan establishing a foothold in their life. This is something they can initially process by themselves but you will need to make yourself available if anything comes up which they may wish to deal with.

On day 3, we encourage them directly to get in touch with you, as their mentor, and to start processing some of what God has been revealing to them. Remember that the heart of this process is helping them identify the lie they have believed and then to replace it with the truth:

"Prayerfully prepare yourself to talk to someone, preferably your mentor, and commit yourself to have an honest conversation with them about the areas in your life that the Holy Spirit has brought to your attention over the past two days."

And finally on day 5, we ask them to pray about the reoccurring areas in which they wish to be set free. This will be something that not only needs to take place this week but in an ongoing relationship of accountability. If you are unable to provide this, please help the disciple connect with someone who would be able to do this.

"Write your own "baggage" prayer, making it specific to any strongholds you've been finding in your life. Commit yourself to daily prayer to God until you are walking in freedom. Make specific plans to spend time with your mentor this week and start cultivating a relationship of accountability and encouragement."

When we choose to tackle these situations head on, we save ourselves from years of pain and trauma; yet, many choose not to by either believing the lie that their situation is hopeless or because they are unwilling to make the hard choices needed. Your encouragement this week will be critical as they walk through this process and come out the other side tasting the fruits of freedom in Jesus. It is important to maintain confidentiality of what the disciple may disclose to you but also know you don't have to carry this alone. If you feel something has been shared that you need help to deal with, please either reach out to one of the Connect Leaders or to one of the elders, for the ultimate good of the disciple.

WEEK 7, DAY 1

1. Have you experienced the reality of the spiritual world in your life — think about times you've engaged with God in worship or prayer?

This question is to help the disciple see that engaging in the spiritual / supernatural realm is a normal part of Christianity. When we worship or pray and sense God being present or feel he has said something to us, it is because the "good" spiritual realm is real.

Supporting Scripture —
Genesis 28:16-17, Daniel 10:13, Colossians 1:16, 2 Corinthians 4:18

2. What changes have you experienced in your inner world (thoughts, feelings, etc) since you met Christ?

Again, the point of this question is to get the disciple to "see" the degree to which the spiritual / supernatural reality is starting to impact the natural reality. Has there been an increase of peace and joy. Have they experienced more dreams that feel different? Do they experience God "speaking" to them about situations?

Supporting Scripture —
Acts 2:17-18, Acts 16:9, Romans 8:26-27

3. How have you experienced the attacks and temptations of Satan in your life since becoming a Christian?

After considering the positive aspects of spiritual / supernatural reality, we want the disciple to think about any situations where that may have experienced attacks from that same realm. We want the disciple to be alert to the potential of the enemy's attacks but not to feed fear. The disciple must see that they have everything they could possibly need to be victorious over the enemy as long as they don't ignorantly or willfully give Satan power in their lives.

Supporting Scripture —
Matthew 4:1-11, 1 Peter 5:8-9

WEEK 7, DAY 2

Take a moment now to consider this list of questions. Though it is not comprehensive, the "results" should be seen as indicative of possible spiritual strongholds in the disciple's life. Remind them that strongholds are not demonic possession! Christians belong to God but they can have areas in their thinking or emotions in which they are acutely vulnerable to the enemy's attack.

- Do you have difficulty in giving or receiving love?
- Do you come from a proud family? Are you proud?
- Are you rebellious or angry? Or stubborn?
- Do you have unforgiveness, resentment, bitterness or hatred towards a person?
- Who is that person?
- Are you anxious or depressed?
- Have you ever contemplated or attempted suicide?
- What fears or phobias do you have? have you visited temples? Been into witchcraft?
- Have you carried charms? Do you have idols?
- Has heavy metal or punk rock "turned you on?"
- Do you fantasize and lust? Masturbate?
- Have you been sexually molested? At what age?
- Do you suffer from chronic sicknesses?
- Do you have times of heavy doubts about the existence of God, or your own salvation?

If there are areas in your life that you answered yes to and they are causing

you anxiety or fear, take a moment to pray to ask God to give you peace and confidence that he is in the process of setting you free. If necessary, you can contact your mentor and talk this through with him or her today.

This list comes from the Freedom In Christ course and bear in mind that if there truly seems to be a lack of freedom, you may need some help from elders or those who have run this course before to walk them into the freedom Christ has won for them.

Supporting Scripture —
John 14:27, 2 Corinthians 10:3-5, Galatians 5:1

WEEK 7, DAY 3

1. How can we learn to spot destructive or addictive cycles in our lives?

Most of the time, the disciple will actually already be aware of such cycles if they exist in their own lives. Normally it's marked by bad fruit — lack of peace and joy; bitterness and unforgiveness; broken relationships; shame.

Supporting Scripture —
Ephesians 4:17-19, Romans 1:21-32

2. How could you harden your heart to the Holy Spirit's work of highlighting areas in your inner life that he wants to deal with?

Sadly, it is human nature to deny and cover up rather than to come to God is repentance. We must help the disciple to see that there is a massive difference between worldly sorry (sorry for being caught; being upset about the consequences) and godly sorry (deep realization of the wickedness of and ownership of our sin). When we respond to the Spirit's inward conviction with worldly sorry or by rationalizing / spiritualizing our sin, we can end up creating hardened areas in our hearts — seared conscience! Encourage the disciple to bring before God any areas of sin that they've previously tried to cover up.

Supporting Scripture —
2 Corinthians 7:10, 1 Samuel 15:13-31, 1 Timothy 4:1-2

3. What do you think happens if we try to change the fruit (your attitudes and behaviors) without changing the roots (breaking down the stronghold)?

Remember that the gospel brings change that flows from our changed hearts to behavior. The law tried to work change from the outside but without a new heart, we always fail and end up in a pride / condemnation cycle of religion.

Supporting Scripture —
Matthew 15:10, Ezekiel 36:24-27, Hebrews 8:10

WEEK 7, DAY 4

1. What lies about your identity have you believed in the past?

This is such a vital truth for the disciple to grasp if they are to break any strongholds in their lives, and to live in the freedom God has for them. The enemy longs for us to believe lies about ourselves, because we always live consistent with what we believe; so he tells us we are damaged, rejected, stinking sinners, perverted, condemned.

Supporting Scripture —
Revelations 12:10, John 8:44

2. How does God's thoughts about you differ from your own?

God sees us redemptively because he sees us clothed with his Son's righteousness. That means God sees us as the best

possible version of ourselves!! Of course, God knows our weaknesses and sees our sin but he doesn't identify us with those things…we do. And our enemy works hard to make us meditate on those failures rather than on what God says about us in his word.

Supporting Scripture —
Zechariah 3:1-5, Judges 6:12, John 15:15

3. Are there areas in your life where you haven't accepted the truth of who God is?

Help the disciple to audit their own thinking. Maybe pray with them and ask the Holy Spirit to search their hearts and reveal areas where they still need a truth encounter. Maybe it's words that have been spoken over them by others (parents, teachers, boy / girlfriends, a spouse).

Supporting Scripture —
2 Corinthians 13:1, Romans 8:26-27

WEEK 7, DAY 5

1. Which of the divine weapons listed above seems most challenging to you and why?

The disciple is being asked to consider how easily they find it to repent, pray, or be held accountable. If they struggle with repentance / admitting, send them back to day 3 question 2 and ask them also to look at Psalms 51 as the greatest example of confession. Perhaps help them walk through that.

If it's calling upon God in prayer, help the disciple to see that prayer is just talking to God, who is their Father. It may be that they need someone to pray with them over certain areas of their lives. Offer to pray with them.

Lastly, if it is accountability in community, help them see that God has placed brothers and sisters around us just for this purpose. Take them to Galatians 6:1 and talk through what it means to be "restored gently."

Supporting Scripture —
Psalm 51, Galatians 6:1

2. Have you experienced godly sorrow that leads to repentance?

Supporting Scripture —
See above and day 3 question 2.

3. What are some ways in which you can "take every thought captive?"

The key here is not to see this as something passive. We have to actively deal with thoughts that come into our minds that contradict the word of God. Words that bring condemnation or that tempt us to sin are patently not from God and should be rejected. Have the disciple picture taking hold of such thoughts, putting them into a cage, and handing the cage over to Christ to deal with.

Supporting Scripture —
2 Corinthians 10:4-5, Ephesians 6:17-18, Romans 8:5-11

WEEK 8 **Doctrine:** Glorification **Week Theme:** Glorification

And so we come to the final week! As you have journeyed with the disciple over the last seven weeks, hopefully you've had tons of great conversations, prayers, and maybe even a few tears as you have explored all that God has done for us through the cross. As we finish our time together, we now turn our attention to the world to come. The doctrine of glorification is an area that often gets overlooked and yet knowing what is to come is what gives us the hope to endure the struggle we face today. This week seeks to do two things — first, to stir a deep hope and longing for what is to come and then secondly, to propel us in sharing the good news and the radical truth that this future reality is open to all who choose to put their faith in Jesus. For some, much of the information this week will be new but hopefully, as they connect the dots, they will see a picture of what God has provided for us and is inviting us into. This week keeps driving home the idea that what we have learnt in this journey is only the beginning. As the challenge on day 5 says…

"The challenge we leave you with is simple — are you prepared to live your life pursuing the things of God as you seek to live out the amazing truths we have explored together? As we have discovered, unpacking and applying the wonderful truths of our Justification, Sanctification, and Glorification is a task that lasts a lifetime. Go for it!"

WEEK 8, DAY 1

1. How have you viewed death in the past?

The answer to this question could vary a lot — but if people are honest, when they are not avoiding thinking about it, most people fear death. If they are not sure how to answer the question, ask them to think about how they felt when someone close to them passed away (or if they haven't had that experience, ask them to think how they would feel if someone close to them passed away). We are wanting the disciple to see how the STING of death has been wonderfully removed for those who love Jesus, and thus, any remaining fear of death should be removed by the gospel promise of resurrection life.

Supporting Scripture —
Hebrews 2:14-15, 1 Corinthians 15:51-56

2. How does the reality of resurrection affect your life today?

The gospel has set "free those who all their lives were held in slavery by their fear of death" (Hebrews 2:15). Now, instead of fearing death, there ought to be an expectation that accompanies the thoughts of the time when we will pass through the veil of death and enter into our new life with God.

Supporting Scripture —
Philippians 1:21-23, 2 Timothy 4:6-8

3. What practical impact is there on the lives of those who live without fear of death?

The main thing we should help the disciple see is that this world is not all there is. There is no loss we could suffer so great that the world to come would not serve as

overwhelming compensation, and there is no glory we could enjoy in this life that will not pale into insignificance compared to what God had prepared for those who love him. In the end, it should completely change our perspective.

Supporting Scripture —
Matthew 16:26, 1 Corinthians 2:9, 2 Corinthians 4:17

WEEK 8, DAY 2

1. Knowing what awaits those who reject God, what is holding you back from sharing the gospel with those around you?

To modern ears, it can seem unkind or painful to talk about the coming wrath that is being stored up for those who reject God's offer of salvation. That, however, is just lazy thinking. Remember, God's judgment is perfectly just and God has paid the highest price, sending his own beloved Son so that every person will have the opportunity to escape that fate and enter into his eternal love. Now, our part is to make that extraordinary offer of forgiveness known to all people. Surely there is no more urgent and important task!

Supporting Scripture —
John 4:35-38, Romans 1:18-20, Romans 10:9-10 & 14-15, 2 Corinthians 5:18-20

2. How are God's standards for judgment different from the world's?

There are two main differences that cause the end result to be as far apart as it could possibly be. Firstly, the world judges with bias and ignorance. Even without wanting to be unfair, it creeps in because we are not perfect and do not have perfect knowledge. God is and does. Secondly, we often confuse justice with fairness. We think it's unjust that some people end up in hell while others, because of God's mercy and not through any good on their part, end up in heaven. But think about it, the one who ends up in hell is only receiving the justice their sin deserves, while the one in heaven receives the forgiveness of God that he doesn't deserve. This truth may be difficult to grasp given how saturated our minds are with "fairness" thinking. If the disciple is struggling with this, encourage them to read Romans 9:16-24 and remind them of Dallas Willard's quote — no one ends up in hell who didn't want to be there!

Supporting Scripture —
Romans 9:16-24, Romans 3:21-26

3. Is your name in the book of life?

The answer to this (if the disciple is a believer) is an emphatic yes! It is really important that by now they truly do understand that we are saved and kept through Christ's finished work, not through our efforts or good behavior. If, having explored the terrifying reality of the judgement that faces the unbeliever, their assurance of salvation is shaken, you need to help them see that this is exactly what Christ has saved them from and that they are now utterly secure.

Supporting Scripture —
John 10:27-30, Romans 8:37-39

WEEK 8, DAY 3

1. How does knowing that we as believers will also face judgment change how you live your life today?

Firstly, we recognize that we live from gratitude for his mercy and confidence in his finished work, by which we are redeemed and reconciled. Then from that solid ground, we live to please God. We consciously reject those attitudes and actions that are contrary to the nature of God and instead, embrace a life of

holiness empowered by his Holy Spirit.

Supporting Scripture —
2 Corinthians 5:7-10, Ephesians 6:8

2. What can you do to keep an eternal perspective of the situations and suffering you are experiencing today?

Revisit day 1 question 3 where we spoke about the fact that an eternal perspective changes the way we see suffering and loss, as well as success and fame.

Supporting Scripture —
Matthew 16:26, 1 Corinthians 2:9, 2 Corinthians 4:17

3. How can you lovingly comfort fellow believers when they go through times of suffering?

The apostle Paul reminds us that God somehow in his sovereignty and love is able to work all things for the good of those who love him and are called according to his purpose. Sometimes we see that "working for good" down the line in this life but even if we do not, we must hold fast to the truth that we will see it fully evident in the life to come.

Supporting Scripture —
Luke 6:20-23, Romans 8:28

WEEK 8, DAY 4

1. How does knowing what awaits us encourage you to grow in maturity in this life?

Revisit day 3 question 1 which emphasizes the fact that this is not a pressure to perform to earn God's love. But having settled who we are and whose we are, the wonderful expectation of heaven and heavenly rewards should act as a powerful motivating force in our lives. When "the race" gets difficult, we hang tough knowing what awaits at the finish line. These difficulties may include demonic attacks resisting a holy walk or the loving discipline of our heavenly Father when we are stubbornly walking the wrong way. Knowing heaven awaits us, helps us to say, "Yes, I'm staying on this road of discipleship no matter what! I am running until I cross that line and receive the prize!"

Supporting Scripture —
1 Corinthians 9:26, Philippians 3:12-14, Hebrews 12:1-2 & 11

2. How would you describe the prize that awaits us?

While none of us can really conceive what heaven is going to be like, the Bible's authors clearly use picture language to raise our expectations regarding how wonderful it will be: heaven is described as a place where we enter God's rest, reign with Christ, and live without fear, loss, lack or pain! But if that isn't enough, it's also the place where we dwell in close proximity to the Creator — the Lord God Almighty — who invites us to live with him as his children. Ask the disciple to let that sink in!

Supporting Scripture —
Isaiah 11:6-9, Hebrews 4:11, 1 Corinthians 13:12

3. What are the implications of God dwelling amongst his people without a barrier?

The old covenant saints were separated from God by physical barriers in the temple and as new covenant saints in this age, we still only "see but as a poor reflection as in a mirror." But in heaven, we will see God face to face!! Sin and everything that causes sin will have been finally eradicated and we will be fully the

children of God we are predestined to be. When the disciple sees this, they should be filled with a great hope and a longing for that day, cultivating the eternal mindset so important to living a Christian life of faith and holiness.

Supporting Scripture —
Matthew 13:41-43, 1 Corinthians 13:12

WEEK 8, DAY 5

1. How can we keep the urgency of Jesus' return on our hearts and minds?

Firstly, love Jesus with all our heart, soul, mind, and strength! When you love someone like that, you cannot wait to see them face to face. That "thirst" will cause us to echo in our heart the call of the Spirit to Jesus to "come!" Secondly, we should not over-invest in this life as if this is all there is. Building our lives towards heaven in the way we see other people, our finances, careers, etc will keep the imminent return of Jesus continually at the forefront of our minds.

Supporting Scripture —
Revelations 22:17, Luke 12:16-21, 2 Corinthians 4:17-5:1

2. How can you be a further part of God's redemptive history?

Remind the disciple that while Jesus' work of salvation is finished, his work of preparing his bride is ongoing. We are both a part of that bride (the church) and the eunuchs who have been tasked with getting that bride ready. That involves working with Jesus to build his church by carrying the gospel invitation to the highways and byways until the day he gloriously appears to bring this age to an end.

Supporting Scripture —
Revelation 19:6-8, Luke 22:1-10

3. What impact has The Discipleship Guide had on your life and your relationship with God?

Obviously, this question could have one thousand different answers but there should be some common threads — seeing God more clearly and falling more in love with him; greater appreciation of how the gospel applies to every area of their lives; and an unshakable confidence in who they are in Christ!

Well done on walking alongside the disciple through this and continuing the work of the early disciples to proclaim him, admonishing and teaching everyone with all wisdom so that we may present everyone perfect in Christ. To this end we labor, struggling with all his energy which so powerfully works in us.

Supporting Scripture —
Colossians 1:28-29

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